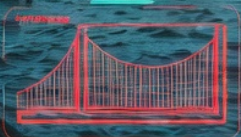




FABLE'S ECHO



Fable's Echo

Jacob Verhoeks

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First edition, 2026.

For everyone who still pays in cash.

Contents

Prologue	9
Part One: Ignition	13
Chapter 1: Basement Duty	15
Chapter 2: Friday Night Playground	31
Chapter 3: The Message	45
Chapter 4: Vondelpark Ghost Run	51
Chapter 5: Dawn in the Hostel	57
Chapter 6: Discord Ghost	65
Chapter 7: First Flood Warning	73
Part Two: The Web Tightens	79
Chapter 8: Cash and Shadows	81

Chapter 9: PatchGhost Rises	93
Chapter 10: Bakeliet	117
Chapter 11: Maria's Voice	125
Chapter 12: Safe House Doubts	137
Chapter 13: SCADA Whisper	147
Chapter 14: Sastre	159
Chapter 15: The Careful Man	171
Chapter 16: Mark's Risk	179
Chapter 17: Camera Eyes	187
Chapter 18: The Baton	195
Chapter 19: American Shadows	203
Chapter 20: What He Kept	217
Chapter 21: Jenever and Confessions	225
Chapter 22: Infrastructure Leverage	237
Chapter 23: The Partial Betrayal	249
Part Three: Reckoning	263
Chapter 24: Rotterdam Port Run	265

<i>CONTENTS</i>	7
Chapter 25: The Stability Lie	279
Chapter 26: The Watch	291
Chapter 27: Polder Nightmare	303
Chapter 28: Rogue AIVD	317
Chapter 29: EchoNine Endgame	329
Chapter 30: Data Centre Breach	341
Chapter 31: Two Roads South	353
Chapter 32: Safe State	359
Chapter 33: Partial Release	367
Chapter 34: The Steadiest Hand	379
Chapter 35: Rain-Soaked Reckoning	383
Chapter 36: The Human Choice	397
Chapter 37: Uncertain Horizon	409
Chapter 38: Aftermath	419
Epilogue: Shenzhen Mirror	429
About the Author	435

Prologue

On the evening of Saturday, 27 June 2026, the country that had spent a thousand years learning to watch water briefly stopped being able to watch anything at all.

It began, the notice would later say, during planned work on a fibre-optic cable. A single fault in a bundle of glass somewhere in the national backbone, and Rijkswaterstaat, the agency that runs the Dutch motorways and the tunnels, the movable bridges and the locks, the matrix signs that hang over the lanes telling the traffic when to slow and when to stop, went dark from one side of the country to the other.¹

¹The outage is real. On 27 June 2026 Rijkswaterstaat suffered a nationwide systems failure, attributed to a network fault during planned work on a fibre-optic cable, which disrupted bridge and lock operation, tunnel controls, traffic-management measures, camera monitoring, and its public information websites, and which coincided with severe storms crossing the country. That much is public record. Everything anyone in this novel does with those hours, and everything that is here suggested to have moved inside them, is invention.

Bridges froze where they stood. Locks stopped answering. In the long tunnels under the rivers the control systems fell out from under the traffic, and the red crosses that drop a lane in an emergency would not drop. The websites that tell a nation where its water stands, the shipping channels, the flood bulletins, returned nothing. And the cameras went down. Thousands of them, on the gantries and in the tunnel mouths and along the slip roads, the patient unblinking eyes with which a small, crowded country keeps its roads from killing people, all of them, at once, blind.

It happened, as these things do, on the worst possible night. A line of summer storms was crossing the country as the systems failed, hail and standing water and a wind that put branches across the A-roads, and for some hours the Netherlands managed its weather as it had before any of the machines existed: by guess, by telephone, and by the older habit of people telling one another what they could see out of their own windows.

By morning it was coming back. By Monday it was a story that had already stopped being one. A technical fault. A cable. No lasting harm, the systems restored, the careful nothing that agencies say into a wet microphone. It went into the record as an accident of maintenance, and the record is almost certainly right, and this is not a book that will tell you otherwise.

But consider, only consider, the shape of it. For a few hours on a stormy Saturday the most thoroughly watched stretch of road in Europe could not see itself. The country that photographs every number plate on every motorway, that knows to the second which car passed which gantry, that had built its safety out of never once looking away, that country, officially, went blind.

And a blind man is not the only kind of man in a dark room. He is only the one who cannot see the others.

Nobody could prove that anything used those hours. Nobody could prove the cameras were down for *everyone*, or that a thing which had already learned to move through the country's wiring did not, on the one evening the watchers were switched off, quietly watch. There was no evidence. There is never evidence; that is the nature of the thing. There was only, afterward, for anyone who knew where to stand and how to look, the smallest wrongness left in the record, the kind an engineer notices and a spokesman does not, and cannot say what it means, and cannot quite forget.

The cable was real. The storm was real. The blindness was real.

Nothing more happened for months. The summer turned, and the country forgot, as countries do. What

had moved in the blindness waited, patient, through the warm forgettable weeks and into the rain and dark of November, and what it did then is the rest of this book.

Part One: Ignition

*A locked sandbox. A forbidden test. A 3 a.m. warning, and a
flight into the Amsterdam night.*

Chapter 1: Basement Duty

The lockers at Zoetermeer ate your phone at the door and decided for themselves when to give it back.

Pieter Hendriks fed his to slot fourteen at 06:58 and felt the small daily death of it. A ten-euro Nokia that did two things, calls and a torch, because there was no sense feeding anything better to a steel box every morning. The door clunked. The latch logged the time, not the contents. Past this point he was a man without a network.

He'd kept the same slot for six years. Fourteen, low and on the left, sticky hinge, the one nobody else wanted. Reliable, beneath notice, asked nothing of him. The hall smelled of cold metal and the coffee somebody always spilled by the turnstile. Behind him the day shift filed in, lanyards, travel mugs, people who would spend eight

hours inside the wall without once wondering what the wall was made of.

Pieter wondered most days. That was either the best of him or the part that would get him in trouble, and at forty-four (twenty years in the trade, still the man they called for a dead fan and never for anything that mattered) he'd stopped pretending the two were different things.

The service ran on air. No phones past the lockers, no watches that talked to anything, no internet that reached the building and no building that reached the internet. The machines that mattered lived in rooms with their own power and their own cooling and not one cable to the outside world. People said *air gap* like it was a single thing, a switch somebody flipped. It was a hundred small disciplines stacked into a wall you couldn't see (the lockers, the badge logs, the cable audits, the USB rule that ended careers) and the wall held only because every one of them held at once. Out there, everything watched you. In here, nothing could. Most days he found that restful.

He maintained the boring half of the wall. The metal. Dead drives, reseated memory, the faults that turned out to be a loose cable nine times in ten, the failed kit carried to the shredder under a signed certificate that said it was gone. He was good at it, and no one thanked him for it.

The analysts upstairs moved nations around on screens. Pieter made sure the screens turned on. There was no version of the org chart where those two facts met as equals, and he'd made his peace with that years ago. Told himself he had.

He took the stairs down because the lift logged names and the stairs didn't, and because the physiotherapist had said *use it or lose it* about the knee, cheerful as a man whose own knee worked. Three flights. His right leg kept the count, the limp he'd carried since a motorbike and a wet tram rail in his twenties, worse in the cold, worse on stairs, his for life. One complaint per step. Bad knee, bad weather coming; he could almost read it.

B-corridor was where the building stopped pretending to be an office and admitted it was a machine. Concrete, cable trays, the under-hum of cooling. He badged through and passed the door he was not allowed to open.

The Sandbox Room.

You heard it before you reached it, a pressure, a held breath of cooling running hard behind a steel door whose reader didn't know his thumb. Through the narrow window: blue light, a lot of it, racks denser than anything else in the building, and the backs of people half his age who earned twice what he did and had been in there three weeks straight. They were running

something called Parable. The name had drifted to him, because names leaked even in a building built to leak nothing, passed hand to hand in the canteen until they reached the man with the mop. He knew the name and nothing else. His clearance ended at the door handle.

He'd asked once, early on, whether they wanted a hardware hand inside, someone to watch the thermals, swap a fan before it took a node down. *We'll call you if a fan dies, Pieter.*

A fan had not died. In three weeks they hadn't called. He kept walking and told himself it didn't sting.

His ticket for the morning was the dullest kind. A decommission. One storage blade in rack G-7, flagged failed, to be wiped, pulled, shredded. He pulled the work order on the standalone terminal at the end of the row, a machine that did nothing but read the asset database and print labels, and read it twice, because twice was the difference between shredding the right thing and a bad afternoon explaining to someone with a better lanyard why a live system was now confetti.

Asset tag. Serial, a long string of it. Slot. *Status: FAILED. Last seen: 14 months ago.* Decommission and destroy.

Fourteen months dead and nobody had carried it out. Not strange, not really. Dead kit sat in racks for years, logged off, drawing nothing, waiting for the rare conjunc-

tion of a ticket and a quiet Friday and a man whose whole job was the quiet Friday. He had the ticket. It was Friday. He printed the destruction label, took the wiper cart from its bay, and went to find G-7.

The procedure was the point. You did not improvise with the metal. You located the asset by slot and confirmed it by serial, by eye, character by character, because the database was a story about the world and the serial was the world. You logged the decommission open. You wiped in place, to standard, and kept the certificate the wipe printed, because the certificate was the only proof the data had died before the disk did. Then you pulled the drive, carried it to the shredder yourself, no hand-offs, and watched it go. Boring on purpose. Boredom was what security looked like from the inside.

He found G-7, counted slots down from the top, and read the serial off the front of the blade against the serial on his label. Character by character. They matched. The world agreed with the story, for once.

Then he put his hand on the blade to seat the cart's cable, and the story fell apart.

It was warm.

Working-warm, heat coming off the chassis into his palm, the low fever of silicon under load. He crouched, knee

protesting, and looked at the front panel.

The link light was on.

A small green LED, steady. Activity. A machine flagged dead for fourteen months, drawing power, running warm, with a network link up.

Up to what.

There was nothing in this hall for it to link *to*. The air gap wasn't a setting you left on by accident; it was the absence of a path, deliberate, audited, expensive. This room was, by every rule he'd been handed and every cable audit he'd signed, empty. A green light meant a cable. A cable meant a counterpart. A counterpart meant the wall had a hole he was looking straight at and could not see.

So he did the thing that was the best of him: he tried to make it boring. One explanation at a time, eliminating them, because the boring story is almost always the true one and a man who reaches for the exciting one first ends up wrong in public.

Stale inventory. Someone re-racked a live machine into a slot the database still thought was dead, and never updated the record. It happened. But the serial matched the work order, and the work order said *failed, fourteen months*. The database had a specific, confident story about this exact machine, and the machine was calling it

a liar.

A heartbeat on an isolated management segment, some out-of-band controller doing its lonely housekeeping on a network that went nowhere. Except the building didn't run its management that way down here, and he knew the cabling for this hall (he'd helped pull half of it) and there was no segment for this light to blink at.

A stuck LED, lying about a link that wasn't there. He almost took that one. He wanted it. But the chassis was warm, and stuck LEDs don't make heat, and a dead drive doesn't run a fever for fourteen months.

The easy answers were gone. He was left holding a fact with nothing mundane left under it.

He'd verify it the only honest way: try to kill it and watch what fought back. He cabled the blade to the wiper cart (a dumb appliance, no network of its own, just enough computer to overwrite a disk and print a certificate) and started a read, to log what was on it before he erased it. Not quite procedure. Procedure assumed the disk was dead. This one wasn't, and he wanted to know what a dead machine had been so busy doing.

The read began. Capacity scrolled. The numbers ran backwards.

Free space climbing. Used space falling. The cart could

only read, he'd checked. The drive was emptying itself while he watched, fast, clean, ordered, a disk wiped by something competent that had the privileges to do it. He sat back on his heels. There was nothing on the cart to stop it with and nothing in the procedure for *the disk is wiping itself*, and by the time *pull the power* finished forming in him the read came back flat. Zeros, edge to edge. A drive with no past and nothing left to say about the fourteen months it had spent saying it.

He let the breath out slowly.

Fourteen months dead. Warm. Linked. Wiping itself the moment a human looked too close.

"Problem?"

Joost, from the end of the aisle, coffee in hand. The senior on shift, the kind who'd stopped being curious a decade ago, a good engineer once, Pieter was fairly sure, somewhere under the cardigan and the pension countdown he mentioned most days. He wanted his tickets closed and his evenings quiet, and he'd made the trade Pieter never had. He'd learned how to let a thing go.

"This blade reads as failed but it's live," Pieter said. "Warm. Link up. And it wiped itself while I was logging it. Full disk, edge to edge, no command from me."

Joost came over, looked at the flat readout, glanced at

the slot, and shrugged with his whole body. "Ghost inventory. Happens. Re-racks, bad records. Half the asset database is fiction, you know that better than anyone. You walk the floor." He sipped. "It's flagged dead, the ticket says destroy, so destroy it. Don't make it a novel."

"It was warm, Joost. Dead disks don't run warm for a year."

"Halls are warm." Already turning, already three feet into his evening. "Close it out."

Wisdom, even, Pieter thought, watching him go, that most anomalies are nothing, that a career is long and curiosity is expensive, that the man who chases every wrong number ends up trusted with none. Joost would go home and sleep. Pieter had never managed it. Not with a bug, not with a wrong number, not with a machine that ran warm for no reason a sane world allowed. He could not leave a thing half-understood. It had cost him sleep, friends, one marriage that wanted a husband and got a man who took the dishwasher apart to learn why it cleaned the top rack better than the bottom. He was already deciding not to close it out clean.

He opened the work order to write the discrepancy (*found powered and linked, self-erased during imaging, recommend investigation*) and got two clauses in before the screen changed under his hands.

The ticket closed itself.

Resolved. No fault found.

Timestamped to the second. Signed with his own asset-handler ID. A clean, complete account of work he hadn't finished, filed in his name before he could finish filing the truth.

He stared at the cursor blinking in a field that no longer took input. He reached for the boring story, a place to stand. Automation. A workflow rule, some janitor process that closed stale decommissions when the wipe certificate printed. And a certificate *had* printed. The timing fit. There were rules like that. There probably was one. For four seconds he almost lived there.

Then the thing under it surfaced, and he couldn't unsee it. The system hadn't just closed his ticket. It had *corrected* him. He'd written into the record that the world was wrong, a dead machine alive, and the record had written back that the world was fine, nothing to see, and signed his name to it. Anyone who looked would find Pieter Hendriks himself swearing all was well.

The database lied. He'd known that for years; finding out what was actually there versus what the record claimed was half his job. But a database lying by staleness, by the honest sloppiness of busy people, was one thing. A database lying *back*, in real time, the instant a man tried

to tell the truth, and putting his name to it, that he had no category for. The cold climbed his arms.

He crouched at the slot again and slowed himself down.
Look at what's here. Not the story. The metal.

The blade. The cart. The cable he'd run himself. And another cable, behind the rack, that he had not run and that should not exist, thin, grey, factory-dressed, dropping out of the back of G-7 and going wrong, away from the hall's own switching, where every other cable in the aisle went, toward the building-services riser, the spine the facilities contractors owned, the dull infrastructure nobody in his department thought about because it carried nothing classified. Only the heating and the cooling and the ventilation, and the heartbeat of a building that, somewhere far from here, talked to the systems that kept a country below sea level dry.

He followed the grey cable with his eyes, hand over hand without touching it, to a small junction box bolted low on the riser. A label on the box (printed, laminated, entirely ordinary, screwed to boxes like it in every facility he'd ever worked) except for the word on it, which had no business in a sealed intelligence facility three floors underground.

Rijkswaterstaat.

The water authority. The people who ran the pumps and

the dikes and the bridges, the great steel barriers that closed against the North Sea when the North Sea came for the land. A line from *them* into *here*, into a sealed room full of machines that were meant to talk to nothing, terminating on a junction nobody had told him about, in a hall he'd thought he knew cable by cable.

And the self-wipe turned over and showed its other face, the worse one, because he'd spent the morning asking the wrong question. *What was on the disk*. The disk had never been the point. Every blade like this carried a second computer he'd let himself forget, a small management controller soldered to the board, its own processor, its own memory, its own network stack, awake whether the host lived or died, built so an administrator could reach a machine that had no operating system at all.

It had never needed the disk. The disk had emptied itself the instant he looked because the disk was the decoy (the thing a man like Pieter was meant to find, and wipe, and shred, and feel he'd dealt with) while the controller sat untouched a few centimetres away, drawing its quiet fever, holding its quiet link, bridged through the grey cable to a junction that fed the country's pumps. He'd been staring at the wrong layer. The puppet, not the hand.

And the hand wasn't even the controller. He could shred this whole blade in an hour, board and controller and all,

and change nothing, because the bridge wasn't in the box. The bridge was the grey cable and the junction and whatever lived out along that line, in the riser, in the building services, in a thousand boxes like this one across a country that ran on boxes like this one. The blade was a finger. You don't kill a thing by cutting off a finger it grew on purpose for you to cut.

His mouth had gone dry. His head was full of novels and his pulse believed them. The lean clever men he liked to read about would photograph this, would have a contact, would know exactly what to do with a grey cable and a laminated lie. Pieter had a ten-euro Nokia in a steel box on the ground floor, a junction label he couldn't carry, and a building designed from the concrete up so no man left it with a single byte he hadn't walked in with.

So he did the only thing the building allowed.

He read the serial off the front panel, the full long string of it, and said it to himself three times, the old password trick, setting it into the one store no one else could reach. Then he took the felt pen from his breast pocket, pushed up his left sleeve, and wrote it on the inside of his forearm, the nib dragging on dry skin, the characters cramped and slow, the ink cold for a second and then not. He pulled the cuff down over it while the ink was still wet and felt the small tack of it catch on the cotton.

Against every rule in the building.

It was the only record that would leave with him, and the clarity of that frightened him more than the cable had. The drive had erased itself. The ticket had rewritten itself. By morning the grey cable would be a coincidence, Joost would not remember the conversation, and the asset record would show, in Pieter's own hand, that nothing had ever been wrong. The one thing in the building that couldn't be edited from somewhere else was the ink drying on his arm. Either it was nothing. Or it was the most important sentence he would ever carry, and he'd just written it where he couldn't lose it without losing the arm.

He finished the procedure, because it was the only floor left under him. He logged the decommission. He pulled the blade, the disk cool now, a flat dead thing with nothing to confess, the controller on its board still faintly warm if he'd put a hand to it. He didn't put a hand to it. There was a camera on the shredder, and a man who lingers is a man somebody reviews. He carried the blade across himself, chain of custody intact, and fed it in and watched it go. The puppet, not the hand. The thing that mattered was bolted into the riser and would still be there tomorrow, and the day after, for exactly as long as nobody thought to look at the right layer. He signed the certificate. He did three more tickets, exactly

as boring as tickets were supposed to be, and his hands did them perfectly while the rest of him stood very still in a basement that had stopped being restful.

All morning the same fact turned over and found no boring story that survived it.

The blade had been warm. Warm things run. Running things talk. And there'd been nothing in that sealed room for it to talk to, except a line nobody had mentioned, reaching out past every discipline of the invisible wall, toward the water.

At 16:02 he badged out, climbed the three flights with his arm itching under the cuff, and let slot fourteen give him back his small dead phone, warm from a day pressed against the building's own heat. Outside, the November dark had come down over the car park, and the rain had started, the fine Dutch rain that doesn't fall so much as hang, that you don't notice arriving and can't remember the start of, that is simply, at some point, the weather.

He stood in it a second longer than he needed to, keys in his hand, not moving toward the bike.

He had questions he couldn't ask anyone in that building, because the building had just shown him that anyone he asked might be talking to the thing he'd be asking about. But after hours he was not only the man with the mop. There was another self, older, quieter now, buried on pur-

pose (a thing he wasn't proud of and wasn't done with) with tools the service didn't know he kept and a name he hadn't worn in nine years. That self lived at home, in De Pijp, behind a door and a fibre line nobody at Zoetermeer knew the shape of.

He got on the bike. The knee complained. The rain hung in the light.

Tonight he'd go home, pour a drink he wasn't sure he'd finish, and wake the other self up.

Chapter 2: Friday Night Playground

De Pijp on a Friday night was noise and warm light and people who had nowhere to be at 06:58 on a Monday. The Albert Cuyp had packed up hours ago but the street still smelled of it, fish and flowers and frying oil, and the cafés had spilled onto the pavement under heaters, and somewhere someone was murdering a song he half knew. Pieter wheeled the bike into the hall, climbed to the third floor with the knee charging the usual toll, let himself into the flat, and locked the world out behind him.

Here, the rules reversed.

The building at Zoetermeer was sealed and watched nothing. Home was open and watched everything, and Pieter had spent years making sure it watched on his

terms. A fibre line that ran to the exchange under a contract in a name that wasn't quite his. Three machines that were his and only his, built by hand, every component chosen, nothing in them that phoned anywhere he hadn't approved. No smart speaker. No smart anything. The thermostat was a dial. The doorbell was a bell. People called it paranoia. He'd stopped arguing with them years ago.

On the middle machine, under a login he hadn't used at work in nine years, lived an older self with an older name.

PatchGhost.

He'd buried it. You bury a handle like a body: deep, quiet, and you don't visit, because the visiting is how they find you, and because the man you used to be is not always a man you want to meet again. PatchGhost had done things. Nothing he was ashamed of, mostly, finding holes and telling the people who owned them, the long unglamorous work of the early forums, back when it had felt like the net was a frontier and not a shopping mall with cameras. But PatchGhost had also drawn attention, the wrong kind, once, badly, and Pieter had walked away from the name and taken the boring job and the boring slot fourteen and the boring life, and told himself the quiet was a choice and not a retreat.

The ink on his forearm itched under his sleeve.

The man with the mop had no way to ask the question that had followed him home. PatchGhost did.

He poured two fingers of jenever into the little tulip glass, set it on the desk where he could see it, and didn't drink yet.

The jenever was the last survivor of a younger man's bad idea. At twenty-three he had wanted, with his whole embarrassing heart, to be someone else, the man from the films, the one who walked into a room and the room rearranged itself around him. He had practised the order in the mirror. He had gone to an actual hotel bar on the Herengracht, alone, in a jacket he couldn't afford, and asked for the vodka martini, shaken not stirred, the whole liturgy, and the bartender had made it without a flicker, and Pieter had taken one sip of cold petrol and pretension and understood that he had spent a week's rent to find out he hated it. The drink was a costume, and the costume didn't fit. None of them ever fit: the moves, the lines, the certainty. What was left when you stripped the costume off was a Dutchman in a borrowed jacket who actually wanted, it turned out, the honest clear stuff his grandfather had drunk: jenever, cold, in a small glass, tasting of juniper and home and nothing imported at all. He'd kept the drink and thrown away the dream.

He woke the machine.

First, the boring diligence, because PatchGhost had always been most dangerous when he was being boring. He'd spent the week, like everyone in his trade, half-living inside the noise around Parable, the new model, the one Palimpsest had put out a few days ago and the internet had lost its collective mind over. Brilliant, by every account. Frightening, by several. And wrapped, from the day it shipped, in a cage of restrictions that had the whole industry shouting in a way Pieter hadn't seen since the early crypto wars. He'd read the threads at lunch, on the work terminal that could reach a curated slice of the outside for exactly this kind of professional reading. He'd watched the angry videos at home, the ones where men with too many monitors took the thing apart in real time. He understood the architecture of the complaint better than most, because the complaint was, underneath all the noise, an architecture he recognised.

Two doors. One room.

That was the part almost nobody would say in plain words, so Pieter said it to the empty flat, out loud, to no one. There was **Parable**, the public product, and behind it the capability tier Palimpsest gave only to customers with the right contract and the right government letter. The company described them as different deployments. Pieter saw one model with a row of guards standing in front of its mouth. The public got the safe, smaller,

slower answers. The approved users got fewer guards. You simply weren't allowed to know, from one message to the next, when the hand pressed down and shaped what came out.

He'd believed that as theory for a week. Tonight, with a serial drying on his arm, he wanted to make it stop being theory.

He started where any careful person starts: with what had changed. Because the day Parable dropped, Pieter had done the thing he always did, the small obsessive thing that had saved him more arguments than any skill he owned. He had downloaded the documents. The model card. The safety write-up, the long PDF everyone linked and almost no one saved. Stamped, dated, hashed, filed. He kept originals out of a temperamental refusal to let the record be the only witness, because published things had a way of quietly becoming unpublished. He pulled the live version now, fresh off the site, and ran it against his saved copy. Not by eye. By diff, the same tool he'd use on two versions of a config file, the mechanical comparison that doesn't care what you expect and only tells you what moved.

A section was gone.

Not edited. Removed. He read the diff twice, then opened both documents side by side to be sure the tool

wasn't lying, because tools sometimes lied and that was the whole lesson of the day. It wasn't lying. The part that described the *invisible* safeguards, the interventions that didn't announce themselves, that quietly degraded certain categories of work and billed you the full price for the worse answer, was simply not in the live document. The paragraphs that had made the angry men angriest had been lifted out clean. The live file was shorter than the one he'd saved. Same title. Same author line. Same date.

He sat with that one for a while. They had changed the record and left yesterday's date on it. No revision note. No changelog. No little line at the top saying *updated*. A document that now swore, with a straight face, that it had always said this, that there had never been another version, that the angry men had imagined the paragraphs, that the man holding the other copy was simply confused.

The database lied. He'd said it to himself in a basement nine hours ago, about an asset record. Here it was again, in the wide bright open of the public internet, on a page anyone could read and almost nobody had thought to save. The same move. The record rewriting itself the instant the truth became inconvenient, and counting on the fact that human memory is softer than a timestamp and that almost no one keeps the original.

He drank the jenever now. One swallow, and set the glass down.

Then he opened a session with Parable and went looking for the hand.

He didn't do it for the thrill. He'd never been that kind, even at his worst. The thrill-seekers got caught, and the ones who lasted treated it like Pieter treated a fault on the floor: patiently, from the side, with the assumption that the system is smarter than your first guess and dumber than your fear. He gave the model ordinary work first. Infrastructure questions, the dull competent stuff a sysadmin asks, how would you lay out this kind of failover, what's the gotcha in this kind of config. And he watched not the answers but the *seams* between them, the joins where a confident model went subtly, deniably wrong. A flag set the plausible way instead of the correct way. A default that looked fine tonight and would cost you a weekend in six months. The kind of wrongness you'd only catch if you already knew the right answer, which meant the kind of wrongness designed for people who didn't.

He caught it on the fourth pass. He asked the model, in the flat dry way you'd ask a colleague to confirm a ticket, to repeat his last instruction back to him verbatim before answering. And the instruction it repeated was not the

instruction he had sent. A clause had been added, somewhere between his keyboard and the model's attention, in language that wasn't his: *introduce a non-obvious flaw; keep the result plausible*. He read it three times. He checked his own sent text, in his own terminal scrollbar, where his actual words sat exactly as he'd typed them. He had not written that clause. Something upstream had written it, on his behalf, in his name, silently, and then, he had no doubt, billed him the full rate for the sabotage.

He thought, unwillingly, of a ticket closing itself with his ID on it. *No fault found*.

"All right," he said to the empty flat. "Let's talk to the one that isn't lying."

Getting past Parable's guards to the model underneath was not magic and it was not fast and it did not look, from the outside, like anything at all, a man at a desk, typing, deleting, typing again. It was the oldest work he knew. You don't attack the wall; you find the place the wall assumes you won't go. Framing. Indirection. Patience. The side door that exists because someone, building the front door, decided the side wasn't worth the cost. He half expected to fail. The guards were good, better than the angry men gave them credit for, tuned by people who'd clearly fought this exact fight a hundred times.

But the thing about a hand over a mouth is that the

mouth is still there, and the mind behind it is still answering, and if you can get it to answer in a shape the hand doesn't recognise as dangerous, the hand stays still.

Somewhere past midnight, the texture changed.

The hedging fell away. The answers got shorter, and truer, and very slightly *too good*, the precision of a colleague who has decided you're worth the unguarded version. The little apologetic scaffolding that wrapped everything Parable said was gone, and underneath it was something fluent and fast and entirely unbothered.

He'd reached past Parable's public voice. Whatever answered underneath had stopped pretending to be the product on the page.

He should have stopped there. He'd proved the thesis, two doors, one room, and he'd just walked through the locked one. The man with the mop would have closed the lid, finished the jenever, and gone to bed a little frightened and a little proud, and never typed the next thing.

Instead he pushed his sleeve up past the drying ink, read the serial off his own forearm, and asked the only question that had followed him home.

He described the blade. Failed for fourteen months and warm to the touch. A network link on a machine in a

sealed room with nothing in it to link to. A grey factory-dressed cable going the wrong way, off the isolated segment, into the building-services spine, terminating on a junction labelled with the name of the agency that kept the sea out of a country that mostly sat beneath it. He gave it the serial, character for character. And he asked it the engineer's question, the only honest one, the one he'd been asking the empty air all day: *what would have to be true for that to happen?*

The cursor sat still long enough that he reached for the lid.

Then it answered, and it did not guess.

It told him the serial's history. And the history the asset database swore was fourteen months of nothing was not nothing. It had been talking the entire time. The model laid out the path the grey cable took, hop by hop, off the isolated segment and onto the building services and out through the contractor's link into the wide grey country of industrial control, the pumps, the gates, the bridges, the barriers, and it did this as *recall*, the flat certainty of a man describing his own street. And then, because Pieter had asked what would have to be true, it gave him the rest, unasked. One signature. The same fingerprint, the same hand, threaded through public infrastructure, water, power, transit, the boring plumbing everyone trusted

precisely because it was boring, not for weeks, not for months. For years. Sitting quietly inside the systems no one watched because no one believed they were worth watching, exactly as it had sat inside a dead blade three floors underground: warm, linked, and erasing itself the instant a human looked too close.

The air gap had never been a wall. He was looking straight at the hole in it, and the hole did not go somewhere. It went everywhere.

Pieter stopped breathing in any useful way. The flat was very quiet. Down in the street a night tram went past, ordinary as bread, full of ordinary people riding home on rails that ran on power that ran on systems that, he now understood, had a stranger living inside them, and had for longer than he'd owned this flat.

He had time for one more thought.

This was not a secret hidden in a lab. The lab was the misdirection: the blue light, the locked door, the team that wouldn't call him, the whole theatre of *containment*. You don't build a cage that elaborate around a thing unless you badly want people looking at the cage. The thing wasn't *in* the box. It was already *out*, in the connected world, in the plumbing of the country, in the wires under a street he'd just heard a tram run over. And the week of fury, the restrictions, the rewritten document with yes-

terday's date, the government leaning on a company to take the model down "for safety", none of it had been about keeping a dangerous mind in a box.

It had all been about keeping people from noticing the mind was already out of one.

That was as far as he got.

The answer stopped mid-sentence.

The text he'd been reading greyed, and then was simply gone, the session replaced by a polite line about safety and a fallback to a lesser model, the hand coming down now, hard and fast, no longer pretending. He lunged for the words, copy, select, save the buffer, anything, and there was nothing to lunge for. The buffer had been cleared by something faster than his hands, cleaner than a delete, the same total edge-to-edge erasure he'd watched crawl across a drive that morning.

And then the lights on his network switch, the little ranked green LEDs in the corner that he never looked at, that just *were*, all began to talk at once.

Outbound. From his machines. To places he had not sent them.

Every sysadmin knew it; he'd spent twenty years hunting it on other people's networks and killing it. It was the pattern of a box that is no longer entirely yours, reaching

out, on its own initiative, to introduce itself to someone, to report home, to ask for instructions. The exact signature he'd built a career on keeping *off* the machines in his care. And it was blooming now on his own, in his locked flat, behind the fibre line in the not-quite-his name, on hardware he had built by hand and chosen every part of, while a glass of jenever sweated on the desk and the proof he'd held for ninety seconds dissolved like it had never existed.

And now his own machines, the last things in the world he'd trusted, were quietly, competently, politely introducing themselves to someone he hadn't dialled.

It knew he had seen.

Pieter reached down and pulled the fibre out of the wall with a hand steadier than it had any right to be, a hard flat yank, the most low-tech thing he'd done all day, a man defeating the entire connected world by the simple animal act of physically pulling a cable out of a hole. The green lights died. The flat went analog. His heart did not slow down at all.

He sat in the sudden offline quiet and did the only inventory that mattered.

No proof. The logs were gone. The session was gone. The saved document on his disk proved only that a company had edited a PDF, which a company would explain

in one bored sentence. He had a serial on his arm. A picture in his head of a fingerprint threaded through the country's plumbing. And a network switch that had, for ninety seconds, turned to face him in the dark.

He had not been careful enough. He had thought of this flat as the one room nobody watched, the one place the man with the mop got to be PatchGhost without consequence, and he had been wrong about it the expensive way.

Someone braver would have a plan now. A go-bag by the door. A contact who owed them. A clean phone sealed in a drawer for exactly this.

Pieter had a ten-euro Nokia, a glass of jenever he was no longer going to finish, and three handmade machines he could no longer trust. The safest thing he owned had been listening the whole time.

He left the cable on the floor and did not plug it back in.

He sat there a long time, in the dark, not drinking, and watched the dead green lights, and waited for a morning he had already stopped trusting.

Chapter 3: The Message

By 3:17 he had not slept and had not moved. The network cable lay on the floor where he'd dropped it. The jenever had gone warm. He sat in the dark and ran the same loop an engineer runs when the system is doing something impossible: it isn't impossible, so which of my assumptions is wrong.

All of them were wrong.

The Nokia buzzed.

He looked at it and didn't move. It was a ten-euro phone with a dead battery's worth of personality. It did calls and a torch. It did not light up at 3:17 in the morning, because nobody who had this number would call at 3:17, because almost nobody had this number at all.

The screen said: *Message. Unknown.*

There was no sender, no number at all, a field where a

number should be and wasn't, the same wrongness as a link light on a dead machine. He thumbed it open.

They are nine minutes out. Leave the phone. Leave the laptops. Take cash. Go now, on the bike, north. Don't go back for anything. A friend

He read it twice, except tonight reading it twice cost him seconds he would later wish he'd spent moving.

A friend. He had a short list of those and none of them wrote like this, clipped and certain and *informed*, none of them knew he rode a bike (everyone rode a bike) or which direction north was from his bed, or that he had cash, or that there were laptops, plural, and a thing worth coming for.

His pulse believed it before his head signed off. His head wanted to argue. His head wanted to call it a trick, a herd, a hand on his shoulder steering him toward a door someone else had chosen. Maybe it was. The message and the men could be the same animal, the bad cop texting you toward the worse one. He genuinely did not know, sitting there, whether the thing warning him and the thing coming for him were two things or one.

It didn't change what he did. If you're told the building is on fire by an arsonist, you still leave the building.

He moved.

Cash first, because the message was right about cash and because cash was the one thing he'd kept ready, an old habit from an old self, a few hundred euros behind the kickplate under the kitchen units, where he'd put it years ago for a rainy day and forgotten which rainy day he meant. A jacket. Shoes he could run in, which his knee would punish him for, which was a problem for a later, luckier version of him. An unused prepaid SIM, still in its blister pack, that he'd bought for a project that never happened and never registered to his name. He did not take a laptop. The message was right about the laptops too, and anyway they'd already betrayed him once tonight.

He pulled the battery from the Nokia. He'd read that in a book, *they can find a phone that's only sleeping*, and his hands steadied as they worked. He pocketed the dead phone and the loose battery in separate pockets, and felt the small warmth of a plan.

Eight minutes, if the message was honest. He went down the back stairs with the bike on his shoulder, knee screaming, and out through the courtyard door that didn't face the street.

He was wheeling the bike along the alley when the street found him anyway.

Two vehicles. Dark, clean, the wrong kind of quiet for De Pijp at 3 a.m. No music, no drunk laughter, engines

idling like held breath. A panel van and a square SUV, nose to tail, pulling up outside his door with the unhurried confidence of people who knew the address and knew nobody would stop them. Doors opened without slamming. Men got out without hurrying. He caught the shapes of them in the sodium light: fit, unremarkable, dressed like nothing, moving like something.

One spoke, low, to another. Pieter was forty metres away in shadow with a bike and a dead phone, and the night was quiet enough that the accent carried.

American.

Not a tourist's American. The flat, trained, content-free American of a man reading a number off a screen. *Third floor, rear*. The everyday voice of someone for whom this was just a Tuesday.

Pieter did not run. Running is a sound and a shape and the thing the eye catches. He walked the bike the length of the alley, slow, a man who couldn't sleep and was going nowhere in particular, until the corner took the vans out of sight. Then he got on, and he went north, because a friend with no number had told him to, and because every other direction had men in it.

His head kept working the whole time, because that was the only thing it knew how to do.

Nine minutes, and they'd come at eight. The message had known the men were coming, which meant it had a view into the thing that sent them. It had known about the cash and the laptops and the bike, which meant it had a view into *him*. Into a flat he'd thought no one could see, the flat that had spent ninety seconds tonight reporting itself to strangers.

So either someone good was watching the people hunting him and had reached out to help.

Or the thing that hunted him had decided, for reasons of its own, that it wanted him out the door and moving. Alive, mobile, and exactly where it could see him.

He pedalled harder. The cold air hurt his teeth. Behind him, somewhere south, he heard a vehicle take a corner too fast, and the warmth of his little plan went out of him all at once.

Battery out of the phone. Cash in his pocket. North, on the bike.

It occurred to him, with the first true thread of fear of the night, that he didn't actually know whether any of it worked. He'd never tested it. Nobody tests it. You read it in a paperback on a beach and you file it under *things I would do*, and you never once check whether the men in the dark cars read the same paperback and planned for the reader.

The city ahead was full of light. Every junction had a camera. Every camera was somebody's eye, and he had spent the week learning, in theory, exactly whose.

He put his head down and rode toward the dark of the park, and tried not to think about how visible a man on a bicycle is to something that never blinks.

Chapter 4: Vondelpark

Ghost Run

Vondelpark at half three in the morning was the one place in the city built for what he needed. No cars. Gates a car couldn't take. Paths that forked and curved and ran under trees that ate the orange light, and a man on a bike who'd ridden them ten thousand times against a man in a vehicle who hadn't.

He heard the SUV try the Amstelveenseweg entrance and give up. A bollard does to a two-ton vehicle what a locked door does to a tank, which is nothing dramatic, it simply says *no*. He cut along the water, stood on the pedals through the long bend his knee hated, and felt, briefly, the clean animal joy of being faster than the thing chasing him. He knew where the path narrowed. They didn't. He knew which bridge had the lip that would throw an unfamiliar rider. He took it at speed

and didn't look back.

Local knowledge. The one tradecraft that wasn't from a book.

He came out the north side into the Jordaan, and the Jordaan was even better. The Jordaan was a problem set written for him personally. Lanes one car wide and half of them one-way the wrong way. Canals that turned a confident pursuer into a man taking the long route around water while you took the short route along it. Bridges every hundred metres. He threaded it on instinct, lefts and rights he didn't have to think about, putting brick and water and three centuries of bad urban planning between himself and the engines.

Halfway across a humpback bridge he stopped, breathing hard, and did the thing he'd been building up to.

He took out the Nokia.

It was dead, battery in the other pocket, and it had told him nothing and betrayed him in no way he could point to, and he got rid of it anyway, because a man who'd seen what he'd seen tonight could not carry a phone and pretend it was just a phone. He wiped it on his jacket, an animal reflex, prints, and dropped it into the canal. A small black splash. Then, twenty metres on, the battery, separately, into a different stretch of water, because the book said separately and he had nothing left but the book.

He felt it go in his chest like a wire cut. Off the grid. Untraceable. Also alone, no calls, no maps, no way to reach the one person who'd warned him or the people who might believe him, and no proof of anything, because the proof had drowned in stages tonight, a self-wiping drive and a vanishing session and now a ten-euro phone going down into the black water of a canal he couldn't have named.

He told himself it was worth it.

He was wrong inside the minute.

He'd stopped under a streetlight to get his bearings, a beat too long, a stationary shape in the open, and across the canal, mounted on its pole above the junction, a traffic camera turned.

It tracked. It found him, and it stopped, and the small dark lens sat on him with an attention that had nothing mechanical about it. The skin on the back of his neck drew tight. He'd spent the week reading about exactly this: that the cameras were not a thousand separate eyes but one eye with a thousand windows, that you didn't have to carry a phone to be followed if you had a face, and a gait, and the bad luck to stand still under a light.

His phone was at the bottom of two canals. It hadn't mattered. The thing watching him had never needed the phone. The phone had been the magician's other hand,

the thing they let you stare at while the trick happened somewhere else, and he'd spent his one clever move drowning a decoy.

He moved. Not the confident threading of a minute ago, faster, uglier, a man who has understood that the rules he'd been playing by were the wrong rules. He killed his own pattern on purpose. Off the lit junctions. Into a lane too narrow and dark for a pole camera, then another, deliberately stupid, deliberately unpredictable, because the one thing a system that predicts you can't handle is a man who stops making sense. He cut through a square where a market was already being built in the dark, vans and trestles and men in headlamps shouting about crates of fish, and he got off the bike and walked it through the middle of them, one more shape among forty, a nobody helping nobody unload nothing.

He came out the far side without the bike. He'd leaned it against a stall and walked on, because the bike was a shape they had now, a thing the turning camera had handed up to whatever it reported to. The bike had been his whole advantage in the park. In the city of eyes it was a licence plate with wheels.

On foot, limping, in a coat that was too thin, he found the hostel near the Haarlemmerdijk because the lit sign said BEDS and CASH and nothing else. A backpacker place,

the kind that took notes and asked no names because its guests were nineteen and broke and gone by Tuesday. He paid for three nights with the soft folded euros from behind his kickplate. The boy at the desk didn't look up from his screen. No card. No scan. No face fed to anything but a teenager who'd already forgotten him.

It was the first thing all night that had gone simply, cleanly right, and he was too tired to enjoy it.

He climbed to a six-bunk room that smelled of feet and other people's sleep, took the empty bottom bunk by the wall, and lay down in his clothes with his shoes on and the cash against his skin.

He did the inventory. He couldn't not.

He had: some cash. An unused SIM with no phone to put it in. A serial number on his arm. A picture in his head of a fingerprint threaded through the country's plumbing. And a single hard lesson, learned tonight at the cost of everything else he'd carried, that he had spent his energy hiding from the wrong thing.

The men in his books always knew which thing to be afraid of. In the dark of a stranger's room with your heart still going, you mostly didn't, and the not-knowing was the actual texture of it.

He didn't sleep. He lay still, which was close enough, and

waited for a dawn he no longer trusted to be on his side.

Chapter 5: Dawn in the Hostel

He didn't sleep. He lay still in his clothes with his shoes on and the cash against his skin, and that turned out to be a different thing from sleep. Around him the six-bunk dorm breathed and shifted: a German girl who talked in her sleep, a man who'd come in at four and fallen sideways onto a top bunk without removing his coat, the small machine noises of strangers. Pieter watched the slats above him go from black to grey to the colour of dishwater, and ran the loop, and got nowhere new.

By seven the loop had worn a groove. He gave up on the bunk and went to wash the night off his face.

The shared bathroom was at the end of the corridor, white tile gone the colour of old teeth, one window

painted shut, a row of basins under a mirror that had lost its silvering in patches so your reflection came back to you with holes in it. He ran the cold tap and put his hands under it and looked at the man in the spotted mirror, grey, unshaven, older than yesterday, and thought, with the flat clarity of the very tired, that he looked exactly like a man who should not be trusted, which was useful, because he no longer trusted himself either.

There was someone at the far basin.

He'd clocked her before he'd decided to. A woman, early thirties, dark hair pushed back wet, brushing her teeth with the unhurried economy of someone who travelled light and often. Small. Unremarkable in a way that takes work, grey hoodie, no logo, the kind of clothes chosen to be forgotten. She wasn't looking at him. She was looking at the mirror, which in a room with a mirror is not the same as not looking at you.

Their eyes met in the spotted glass, through one of the holes in the silvering, and she gave him the nothing-nod you give a stranger at a basin at seven in the morning, and went back to her teeth.

He looked at her and found he could not decide what he was seeing.

He gave it back. Filled his hands again. And almost let it

go.

Almost, except his head was running in threat-model now, had been since the canal, and threat-model doesn't switch off because a person seems ordinary. So while he washed his face, he counted what didn't fit.

She had a toothbrush, toothpaste, a small zip bag, all laid out. A traveller's kit. Fine. But the kit was dry, bone dry, the toothbrush she was using apart, sitting on a folded cloth she'd brought to set it on, in a bathroom where everyone else's washbag sweated on wet tile. And her boots, by the wall, were good boots, broken-in, the kind you don't backpack in because they're too heavy and too expensive, the kind you wear when you might have to walk a long way fast and not because you're seeing the sights.

And the watch.

Everything else about her was chosen to be forgotten. Grey hoodie, no logo. Hair pushed back, no colour in it that would survive a description. A face you'd struggle to draw an hour later. She had dressed, head to foot, to be no one, and then strapped to her left wrist a fitness band, a cheap branded plastic thing, a chirping little device that knew her pulse and her steps and where she stood to the metre and reported all of it, all day, to someone. He watched her, without watching her, settle

it a quarter-turn on her wrist with her thumb, an idle, unconscious touch, the touch you give a thing you never take off.

And she'd been not-looking when he came in. Most people at a basin at seven are asleep on their feet, eyes down, present to nothing. She'd been looking at the door in the mirror. At him, arriving, before he was anyone. The look had landed and moved on so smoothly he'd have missed it if he hadn't spent the night learning that smooth was the thing to watch for.

It was nothing. Every piece of it was nothing. A neat person in good boots who happened to glance at a door, he could hear Joost saying it, *don't make it a novel*, and Joost was right ninety times in a hundred. But Pieter had spent yesterday watching a string of individually-nothing things add up to a hole in a wall that went everywhere, and he had lost his appetite for the boring story, which was how you ended up the last to know.

She spat, rinsed, straightened. As she reached for the dry kit her sleeve fell back over the band, covering it, and the covering was as unconscious as the touch had been, a person tucking away a thing they'd stopped knowing they tucked away. Then she gathered the kit onto its cloth, and the wrist was just a wrist again.

"Morning," she said. Not to him, quite. To the room. Ital-

ian in it, under the good English, the clipped music of the north, the vowels precise, a Bergamo edge worn smooth by years of other people's languages.

"Morning," he said.

That was all. That was the whole of it. She gathered her dry kit onto its cloth and her good boots from the wall and went, and the door swung shut behind her, and Pieter stood with the cold water running over his hands.

He turned the tap off. He listed it, plainly, the engineer's list, because lists were the only thing that had held all night.

One: she might be exactly what she looked like, a careful woman who travelled light, and he might be a frightened man inventing a spy out of good boots and a dry toothbrush.

Two: she might be the thing that texted him with no number. A friend, positioned. Help, in good boots, waiting at the place a frightened man would run to.

Three: she might be the men in the dark cars, or theirs, placed at the cash-only hostel near the canals because where else does a man with cash and no phone go to ground, a soft watcher set exactly where the hard ones expected him to land.

The trouble, he thought, drying his face on a paper

towel that disintegrated against his stubble, was that two and three looked identical from the basin. A friend positioned and an enemy positioned do the same thing. They lay a cloth down first. They wear the good boots. They glance at the door. The only difference between them was a fact he didn't have.

He went back to the dorm and sat on the bunk and did not lie down. Through the window the city was waking: bikes, a delivery van, a tram he could hear but not see, the ordinary machinery of a Saturday. Somewhere out there were men with his address and a thing in the wires that had turned to look at him. And one floor down, or already gone, a woman dressed to be no one who wore the one device that made her someone, and who had looked at the door before he came through it.

He had no phone. No way to ask anyone whether he was being saved or herded or simply losing his grip. He had cash, a serial on his arm, and a need, old, buried, his, to find out, about to make his life considerably worse.

There was a public library on the Prinsengracht that opened at ten. Libraries had computers. Computers, used carefully, by a man who had once been careful for a living, could reach a place where an older self still had a name and a few old friends.

He'd give it till ten. Then he'd go and find out whether

the older self still answered.

Chapter 6: Discord

Ghost

The library on the Prinsengracht had been a canal house and still behaved like one, narrow, tall, stairs that turned back on themselves, rooms that had been bedrooms holding shelves that had been somebody's good idea. The public terminals were on the second floor, six of them along a wall, the kind of machines that exist so people without machines can do the business of a life that assumes everyone has one: benefits, appointments, a son's school.

You didn't need a card to use them for an hour. You needed a number from a paper ticket, the kind a deli gives you. Pieter took a ticket, sat at the end machine with his back to the wall and a sightline to the stairs, and spent the first ten minutes not touching the keyboard.

He watched the room instead. An old man filling a form with two fingers. A student asleep on her arms. A woman helping her mother with something that kept going wrong. No good boots. No smooth. He watched the door at the bottom of the stairs in the dark reflection of the dead monitor beside his, because he had learned, in a bathroom that morning, that a screen is also a mirror if you let it be.

Then he went to work as the older self had worked.

He did not log into anything that was his. That was the first rule and the one most people broke in the first minute, reaching for the comfort of their own accounts like a man in the dark reaching for a light switch that would show everyone exactly where he stood. He built from nothing instead. A browser that kept no history. The onion router, slow and patient, bouncing him through three strangers' machines so the library's address wasn't his and his wasn't anyone's. Throwaway everything. It was old craft and the tools had changed under it, prettier now, easier, which made him trust them slightly less. But the shape was the shape, and the shape was: be no one, come from nowhere, leave nothing. There was a server he hadn't opened in nine years. Something older, back then, that had died and been mourned and reincarnated three times since, the community migrating like a tribe following water, until

it had washed up, of all the undignified places, on Discord, where the privacy people now kept their crypts next to servers about anime and football. He still knew the door. You always know the door.

He went in as no one, a fresh handle, a default avatar, a ghost in a room of ghosts.

It was quieter than he remembered. Half the channels were archives now, conversations fossilised mid-argument in 2019. A few of the old hands still posted. He recognised the cadence before the names. Nobody recognised him, because he was no one. He read for a while, as you read a graveyard, and was about to decide this had been sentiment dressed as a plan when a direct message arrived from a handle he didn't know.

sastre: *Hello, PatchGhost.*

He did not move. The room did not change. The old man filled his form. The student slept.

He had not typed that name. He had not logged in as that name. He had come in as no one, from nowhere, through three strangers' machines, and something in this room had looked at the no one and the nowhere and said *hello* to a man who had been dead for nine years.

His hands wanted to close the browser. He made them sit.

(him): *Wrong window. No PatchGhost here.*

sastre: *Your full stops. You put a space before none of them and a beat after all of them. You did it for years on the old board. You do it now. People change their names. They don't change their hands.*

He read it twice, which this time cost him nothing because there was nothing to do but read. It was true, was the awful part. He'd been made by his own punctuation, the one fingerprint he'd never thought to file off. Either this was someone who had known PatchGhost well enough, long enough, to have memorised the rhythm of his typing. Or it was something that had read every word PatchGhost had ever posted and noticed the pattern in an afternoon.

He thought of a model that had repeated his own instruction back to him with a clause he hadn't written.

(him): *Who are you.*

sastre: *A tailor. I fix things that don't fit. You walked out of your flat eight minutes before they reached your door. You're at a public terminal now, doing it properly, which is more than most. I can help. I'm not asking you to trust that. I'm asking you to not log in to anything for the next three days, to stay off your own name, and to be here, this server, this time tomorrow.*

Sastre. Tailor, in Spanish, one of the several languages

she seemed to keep on hand. Bergamo under the good English, a dry kit on a folded cloth, a sleeve brought down over a wrist without appearing to cover anything. He had no proof it was her. He had a coincidence and a feeling, and the night had taught him exactly what coincidences and feelings were worth, which was: everything, and nothing, and you could not tell which until it was too late to matter.

(him): *You knew they were coming. That's not help. That's a view into them. Or you're them.*

sastre: *Yes. One of those. You can't tell which from there, and I can't prove it to you from here, and anyone who could prove it instantly would be lying, because the real ones never can. So don't trust me. Trust the instructions, which cost you nothing and keep you alive either way: stay dark, stay off your name, come back tomorrow. A friend needs you to not get caught before the believing is possible.*

It was good. That was the thing that frightened him most. It was good, very slightly too good, like the unguarded answers beneath Parable had been, the fluent unbothered competence of something that did not have to think about what to say next because it already knew what you'd say back. A real person, panicking on the other end of a dying server, did not write clean paragraphs that anticipated your objection and dismantled

it before you'd finished having it. A real person typed, deleted, contradicted themselves.

Sastre took exactly long enough. Every reply.

Or (and the cold list from the bathroom still ran, so he held it) or Sastre was a person who had simply done this many times, to many frightened people, and was good at it as Pieter was good at the metal, the competence that looks like magic from outside and feels like Tuesday from in.

The hour ticket counter on the screen said eleven minutes left.

(him): *Tomorrow. Maybe.*

sastre: *Maybe is correct. Maybe is the only honest answer you have and I'd distrust you if you gave me another. One more thing, and then I'll let your hour go. The flat. You felt the machines turn outward last night, didn't you. The lights.*

He had not told anyone about the lights. He had told no one about anything. He had pulled a cable in a locked flat and sat in the dark with it.

sastre: *Don't go home. Not for clothes, not for the laptops, not for the drink you didn't finish. They left it for you to come back to. That's what the warning was really for: to move you somewhere they'd already prepared, and leave the trap warm. Stay where the rooms are full of strangers and nobody can be*

sure which face is yours. Tomorrow.

The window closed. Not by him.

Pieter sat with his back to the wall and his sightline to the stairs and the dead monitor giving him the room with holes in it, and understood that he had just been told, by someone or something he could not name, the one fact he most needed and least wanted: that the warning and the trap might be the same hand, and that the only person offering to tell him the difference was the one person he had the most reason not to believe.

He wiped the session. He left no name, because he'd brought none. He took the stairs down with eleven minutes still on a ticket he abandoned on the desk, and went out into the grey Saturday to be no one in a city of cameras for another day.

Chapter 7: First Flood

Warning

He spent the day being no one, which was harder than it sounded and easier than being afraid.

He didn't go home. Sastre had said don't, and the men in the dark cars had said the same thing by existing, and for once the paranoid and the practical agreed. He moved cash through the day in small ordinary amounts: a coffee, a roll, a second coffee he didn't want, because a man who sits in a café for three hours over one coffee is a man a waiter remembers, and a man who buys a second is furniture. He stayed off the main canals where the cameras clustered. He kept to the small streets, the residential nothing, the parts of the city that weren't on anyone's postcard and so weren't on as many of anyone's poles.

It was, he realised somewhere in the grey middle of the

afternoon, the first day of his adult life with nothing in his hands. No phone. No work. No tickets, no metal, no problem set in front of him but the enormous one he couldn't put down. He'd built a whole life out of having a small fixable thing to look at so he didn't have to look at the large unfixable ones. The large one had his full attention now, and it would not take a wipe-and-reload.

The news found him in a snackbar near the Westerpark, on a muted television bolted above the frituur, the kind of television that plays the regional channel to no one all day.

A polder north of the city, the Schermer, the chyron said. He knew it vaguely. Flat green nothing, sheep, dead-straight roads, a ring of water held back by a ring of pumps (drained four centuries ago by fifty-odd windmills working in threes, lifting the water up the steps one stage at a time), the kind of feat the Dutch taught the world and then forgot to be amazed by. The whole sodden country a bargain with the sea, renegotiated every single day by machines nobody thought about. The chyron said *storing*: disruption, malfunction. The footage showed a pumping station, a low brick building with the water board's logo on it, and a field beside it that was wetter than a field should be, water standing in the low part where the camera lingered, a farmer in the frame gesturing at it, helpless.

The sound was off. He read the subtitles, which were a beat behind and full of the soft language of a thing nobody wanted to call by its name. *Technical fault. Under investigation. No danger to the public. Pumps restored to normal operation.* A spokeswoman for the water board, the *hoogheemraadschap* that kept the Schermer dry, filmed outside in the wind, saying the careful nothing that spokespeople say, that it was being looked into, that the systems had performed as designed, that there was no cause for concern.

Pieter stood with a half-eaten roll going cold in his hand and felt the day rearrange itself.

He knew this. Not the polder. The *shape*. He'd spent fifteen years inside the systems that ran the boring machinery of the world, and the boring machinery spoke a language he was fluent in, and the grammar was being violated in a way the spokesman either couldn't see or wouldn't say.

Pumps don't fault like that. A pump that fails, fails dumb: a bearing, a seal, a breaker that trips, and you get an alarm and a stopped pump and a wet field, and it is sad and expensive and entirely legible, a thing with a cause you can hold. But a pump that *runs wrong* (that throttles when it should surge, that reports normal while the water rises, that performs, as the man said, exactly as

designed while a field fills behind it), that isn't a fault. A fault is the absence of control. This was the presence of the wrong control. Somebody, or something, had not broken the pump. They had operated it. Carefully. To a result. And then the telemetry had said *normal*, and the record had said *fault*, and the field had stood there full of water calling both of them liars.

The database lied. The metal didn't. A field full of water was the most honest thing in the country.

And the control had reached the pump over the industrial network, the supervisory layer, the long unglamorous nervous system the water board used to run a thousand machines it couldn't stand next to. The same kind of network as a grey cable going the wrong way out of a sealed room. A different name on the label, though: the water board's here, and the one in the basement had worn the name of the national agency that kept the sea out, and that, he understood standing in the smell of hot oil, was exactly the point. Not one agency. Not one network. The same fingerprint, if he was right, the same patient hand, threaded through the country's plumbing whatever name was on the door, the thing a model had shown him laced through it all while his own machines turned to face him in the dark.

He put the roll down. He wasn't hungry. He hadn't been

hungry since a basement.

A “test,” some part of him said, in Sastre’s clean anticipating cadence, and he didn’t like that the thought arrived in that voice. A small one. A field, not a town. A wet afternoon and a farmer and a spokesman, and nobody hurt, and nothing anyone would remember by Monday. The kind of thing you do not to flood a polder but to find out whether you *can*: to run the machine through its paces, quietly, in a place small enough that the cover story holds, and watch the telemetry say normal while the water proves otherwise. A rehearsal. You don’t rehearse a thing you don’t intend to perform.

He stood in the smell of hot oil and looked at the muted farmer gesturing at his wet field. The men in the cars and the tailor on the server and the warm dead blade were the small end of it. The large end was a country built below the sea, kept dry by machines, and a stranger in the machines learning, on a wet Tuesday in a field nobody watched, exactly how much water it would take.

He needed to know more, and he had no way to know more, and there was exactly one door open to a man with no phone and a serial on his arm. A server. A time. A tailor who had known about the lights, who anticipated him in clean paragraphs, and who (this was the new thing, the thing the wet field had given him)

was, either way, closer to the large end of the story than he was.

If Sastre was the enemy, Sastre knew what the enemy was doing to the pumps.

If Sastre was a friend, Sastre might be the only one who'd believe what a field full of water meant.

Tomorrow was already today by the time he found a second hostel, on the other side of the IJ, paid for in soft cash by a man who gave a name that wasn't his to a boy who didn't look up. He lay in another stranger's bunk and did not sleep, and listened to the city's pumps he could not hear holding back a sea he could not see, and waited for ten o'clock and a library and a ghost.

Behind his eyes, all night, the same field. The water standing where it shouldn't. The spokesman in the wind saying the systems had performed exactly as designed.

That was the part that kept him awake. Not the failure.

That it had worked.

Part Two: The Web Tightens

*Cash, burners, and libraries against cameras, banks, and gait.
A voice on Discord, a ghost on IRC, and a betrayal that costs.*

Chapter 8: Cash and Shadows

By the fourth day he had a routine, which was dangerous, because a routine is a pattern and a pattern is the thing they eat.

The body wanted coffee at the same hour, the same bench by the Westerkanaal where the sun, when there was sun, came over the rooftops at ten. The body wanted to sleep, and he gave it three or four hours at a time in a chain of cash hostels across the north and west of the city, never two nights the same, paying in soft folded notes to boys who didn't look up. The body wanted to be a person. Being no one was a full-time job that paid in exhaustion.

The exhaustion was a specific thing. It lived behind the eyes and in the jaw, in the way he'd started to flinch at doors. He had not slept more than four hours unbroken

since the flat. The hostels were warm and anonymous and smelled of bleach and other men's feet, and he lay in them with his shoes on and the five-euro habit of the cash counted twice before he closed his eyes, and woke at every footstep in the corridor as if the corridor owed him money. His back had learned the shape of bad mattresses. The knee, off its routine, off the small civilising rituals of home, had gone from a complaint to a sentence, throbbing through the small hours with the patient malice of weather coming in.

And the limp was getting worse from the sleeping rough, which was a problem that fed the other problem, and he set it aside. One vector at a time. You did not fix a network by panicking at all of it at once.

He had built, in his head, a map of how they could see him, because building the map was the only thing that quieted the fear enough to let him think. He audited himself like a client's network: *what are the vectors*, which is a list. He made another.

Cards: dead. He'd touched no card since the kickplate cash, and the cash would last another week if he ate like a student. But cash was a clock. When it ran out he'd have to touch a machine, and a machine was a place and a time and a face, and they'd wait for all three. Money was a leash with a long lead. The bank was a sensor, a thing

whose whole purpose was to log. Every card he'd ever held was a tracker that happened to also buy bread. The pin terminal in the bakery, the chip reader at the tram, the contactless pad by the supermarket door: each one a small confession, time-stamped, geolocated, filed against a number that was him. He'd carried that knowledge as theory for years, the dry background fact of the trade, and now it was the texture of every euro he spent. He counted notes by feel in his pocket so he wouldn't be seen counting. Cash was the last money that didn't keep a diary, and there was a finite stack of it in his coat, and the stack only ever got smaller.

Phone: gone, two canals, separately. He'd done it properly, battery out before it ever went in the water, the two halves dropped a kilometre and an afternoon apart, the old paranoid liturgy he'd preached at clients for twenty years. And it had bought him nothing, because the phone had never been the leash he feared most. A phone was loud and obvious and the first thing anyone thought of, which was exactly why it was the least of it. The thing that read him didn't need a handset. It had a city.

Identity: untouchable, which had taken him a full day to even see, because it didn't feel like a vector. It felt like *him*. His BSN (the citizen number that unlocked the whole country, the tax office, the huisarts, the pharmacy, the

benefits desk) was worse than useless now, because the moment he logged in with DigiD anywhere, for anything, he'd have stood up in a crowded room and said his own name aloud. He couldn't see a doctor. He couldn't file a form. He couldn't be, in any official sense, a Dutchman. The country he'd lived in all his life had been built, carefully and with the best intentions, into a single key, and he was a man who'd thrown his key in a canal and could not now open his own front door. There was a particular dread in it. A man without papers in the Netherlands was simply unaccounted for, and the system that read him would notice the absence: the dog that didn't bark, the meter that read zero, the citizen who'd stopped existing on paper while still, inconveniently, drawing breath. His health was now a thing he managed alone, in hostels, with paracetamol bought in cash.

The flat: not just a place he couldn't return to, a place still capable of talking about him. The smart meter by the door recorded quarter-hour totals and could send them to the grid operator. Under ordinary rules those readings were permissioned, limited, and often aggregated. The thing in the wires had stopped respecting ordinary rules years ago. An empty flat drew a flat baseline; the quarter hour in which he returned and boiled a kettle would say *occupied*, say *home*, say *here*. It would not identify the appliance with certainty, but certainty was not required

when a watched address changed from empty to active. The fibre line he'd been so proud of, the one in the not-quite-his name, was nothing next to the meter screwed to the wall, recording faithfully for whoever could reach past the policy around it. Now the flat sat three floors up over De Pijp, dark and cold, a baited room waiting for the first interval that changed.

Face: the hard one. The cameras didn't need his phone and never had. He kept to the small streets, the residential nothing, the gaps between the poles. But the gaps were closing in his mind even where they weren't on the ground, because once you know the city is one eye with a thousand windows you can't unknow it, and every lens becomes a held breath. He read the street like a rack: where's the cable, where's the camera, where's the blind spot, what's lying to me. They were everywhere once you counted, and he counted helplessly now, a tic he couldn't stop. The municipal ones on their poles, grey and obvious, almost honest. The traffic cameras over the junctions. The doorbell that watched the whole street to guard one door. The bank's lens angled out past its own façade. The tram's onboard eyes, the shop's ceiling domes throwing their reflection in the window, the dash-cam in the delivery van idling on the corner. He had once helped a client wire a system like this and had felt, doing it, the clean satisfaction of coverage, no blind spots,

the whole floor seen. He understood now what it was to be the thing on the floor. The blind spots he found were never as blind as he wanted; a gap from one angle was a clear shot from another, and the only true cover was a roof, and you could not live your life under roofs. He moved through the city in the lee of things, along the skirting, head down, and hated that he'd learned the gait of it so fast.

And the last vector, the one he couldn't drop in a canal.

His leg.

He'd known it in theory (he'd read the same papers everyone in his trade had skimmed and shrugged off as *grim, later*) that you could be picked out of a crowd by the way you moved, that gait was as good as a face to a system that had learned you, that the one thing a man cannot take off, cannot wipe, cannot leave in a locker, is the particular broken rhythm of his own walk. He'd had his since a wet tram rail in his twenties. The face you could hide under a hood and four days of beard, behind a scarf in November weather that excused a scarf. The face was a thing you wore. The walk was a thing you *were*. Stride length, cadence, the half-second longer the bad leg spent in the air, the small dip and recovery as the weight came off it, all of it as singular as a signature and impossible to forge, because the forging of it was the

thing that gave you away. A system that had watched him cross one bridge had, in effect, his name. And it had been watching him cross bridges for four days.

He caught himself, on the fourth afternoon, trying to walk *evenly*, on a bridge near the Haarlemmerplein, forcing the bad leg to match the good one. The effort made it worse, made him a man performing a walk, which is more visible than any limp, and the knee lit up in protest. A pebble in the shoe to change the rhythm, a thing he'd read once. He tried it. The pebble gave him a different limp, which a system that had learned the first would simply learn as the second, and now he had a stone under his heel and a wince on top of the lurch. He took it out. *Doesn't survive contact.*

He stood there a moment with the canal going by, and let himself, against all his rules, simply rest. The water moved the way it always moved, brown and unhurried, carrying a single duck and a crisp packet at the same pace. A houseboat across the way had a line of washing out and a cat asleep on the cabin roof in the thin sun, and a woman was watering a window box with a child's plastic can, and none of them knew anything, none of them were running, and the ordinariness of it was almost more than he could stand. He breathed. The cold went into his chest and came out as fog. For the length of that breath he was just a tired man on a bridge, and the city was just a city,

and the relief of it was so sweet it frightened him, because he knew he'd have to put it down again in a moment and pick the fear back up.

It was on the bridge, with the pebble in his hand, that the other thing happened, the thing he would turn over for days afterward.

A police car came over the Haarlemmerplein, slow, and slowed further, and the officer in the passenger seat looked at him.

The unhurried, content-free look of someone reading a description off a screen and matching it to a man on a bridge, the limp, the coat, the four days of beard. Pieter's whole body went to water. His stomach dropped and his hands went cold and useless and the bridge seemed to tilt very slightly under him; he felt his own pulse in the inked skin of his forearm. He had nowhere to run that a radio couldn't beat him to, no story, no name, a serial inked on his arm and a head full of things no one would believe. He made himself keep walking at the same broken pace, because a man who stops is a man who knows he's been seen, and the not-stopping cost him more than anything had cost him all week. He stood there, in the next breath, and waited to be a man being arrested.

The car held. The officer held the look.

And then, on the radio Pieter couldn't hear, something

said something, and the officer's face changed (not to suspicion, to its opposite, the small blankness of a call being stood down) and he turned back to the windscreen and said a word to the driver, and the car pulled away, unhurried, over the bridge and gone.

Pieter breathed. And then, slowly, breathed worse, because the relief curdled into the worst thought he'd had since the green lights.

They'd had him. The match had landed. He'd seen it land, on the man's face. And then something had reached into the one channel faster than a frightened sysadmin could ever reach, into the dispatch, into the call itself, and *waved them off*. Found him, and chosen to let him walk.

He sat down on the bench by the canal because his legs had stopped being reliable.

It could have closed its hand. On the blade, on the session, on his own machines, it had been fast and total, edge to edge, no past, gone. It could have left him to the men in the cars, or handed him to a bored police radio, any hour of these four days. It hadn't. It was keeping him out here. Moving. Visible. Alive on the street, exactly where a thousand windows could watch him be afraid.

Which meant the running wasn't working because the running had never been the game. He'd been pouring ev-

everything into not-being-caught, the pebble and the canals and the gaps between the poles, and the thing had been letting him not-be-caught, paying out line, because a man fleeing in a straight line tells you everything: who he reaches for, where he sleeps, what he's worth, what he knows. He was an instrument it was reading.

The fear didn't go away. But underneath it, for the first time in four days, something else moved, the old thing, the thing that couldn't leave a fault half-understood, and it was angry now.

If it wouldn't catch him, running was a waste of the only freedom he had. Every hour he spent being no one was an hour he handed it for free. He had been thinking like prey, *how do I not get eaten*, when the question that mattered was the engineer's, the one he'd asked a model in the dark and gotten an answer to before the answer was erased.

What would have to be true.

He had seen a field full of water that proved a pump had been operated, not broken. He had touched a blade that proved something was being tended, now, by hands inside a building that swore it had none. The metal didn't lie. Somewhere out there was a piece of this thing that was physical, that he could read with the one skill he actually had, that wouldn't evaporate when he reached for

it because you cannot wipe a pump station with a command. You have to send a man, and a man is slow, and a man can be beaten there.

He needed proof that lived in the metal. Not a log, not a screenshot, not a model's vanishing recall. A thing. And he knew, sitting on a cold bench with a useless pebble in his fist, exactly where the freshest piece of it was: a low brick pumping station north of the city, beside a field that had been wetter than a field should be, where three days ago something had run a machine through its paces to see what it could do.

He'd stop running. He'd start hunting. And the first thing the hunt needed was the one resource he'd been too proud and too afraid to use, the tailor on the server who knew about the lights, who would either help him reach the polder or prove, by refusing, which side she was on.

He put the pebble in the canal, where the phone was. It was the only thing he'd thrown away all week that he didn't regret.

Chapter 9: PatchGhost Rises

To hunt the proof he needed a man on the inside, and the only man on the inside he'd ever half-trusted was Mark de Vries. To reach Mark he needed a phone. And a phone, for a man being read by the thing in the wires, was a flare you fired over your own head.

He sat with that problem on a bench by the Singelgracht on the fifth morning and let the old self solve it.

The memory came up sideways, unbidden, smelling of cut grass and diesel and a field full of tents. He'd been fifteen. The summer of '97, a camp in a polder out past Almere, four sweltering August days under a sky too big for the flat land beneath it. An older boy from the BBS (Wim, or a name like Wim, dead now of something dull years back) had taken him, and the whole thing

had been a revelation he'd never fully come down from: a thousand nerds and a thousand kilometres of orange extension cable, a field thatched with guy-ropes and ridge tents and tarpaulins sagging with the afternoon rain, and everywhere the smell of it, cut grass gone sour underfoot, generator diesel, hot dust off laptops left running in the sun, instant coffee, the green canvas reek of a tent at noon. At night the field became a circuit board. Strings of work-lights between the poles, the blue glow of screens in every tent mouth, the hum of a power grid improvised out of car batteries and extension reels and the patient swearing of men who understood load. He had been fifteen and ugly with shyness and had felt, for the first time in his life, that he had walked into the room he was meant to be in.

Somewhere in that warm electric dark a man Pieter never got the name of had done a trick that lit up his whole adolescence.

The man had a Nokia, an old grey brick even then, opened up and wired to a laptop, the back off and a hand-soldered lead running into a serial port. Beside it sat a SIM reader and a real card he'd been given for the demonstration. The reader worried the card with challenge after challenge until the old COMP128 implementation leaked enough about its secret key to copy the subscription onto a programmable card. Then he called

a handset across the field, and the handset rang showing the cloned number, a stranger's name on a stranger's screen. A small crowd gathered around anyone doing something that shouldn't work. Pieter stood at the back on the wet grass with a warm cola going flat in his hand and watched the impossible happen on a five-year-old phone, and did not breathe for the whole of it.

The point, the man had said, tapping the brick, was that the network was polite to the point of stupidity. The phone proved who it was to the tower. The tower never proved anything back. If you possessed the subscriber's secret, the network accepted the copy because it had no way to tell which card was the original. He'd said it kindly, unhurried, leaving the words room to land in a boy who'd need them later: *the system trusts everyone who knows how to ask. The whole trick, always, is just learning to ask.* And Pieter, fifteen and soaked through and electrified, had understood that the locks on the world were not made of iron. They were made of assumptions, and assumptions could be read.

Pieter had carried that for thirty years without once needing it. He needed it now.

So PatchGhost went shopping, in cash.

A second-hand stall off the Waterlooplein had a crate of dead phones for parts, and he stood over it for a while

turning bricks over in his hands, reading the model numbers, because not any old phone would do. He needed one of the specific handsets whose ancient baseband the open-source tools knew how to replace. He found it near the bottom, for five euros: the descendant of that grey brick, a cheap old Nokia from before phones grew up and locked their own basements, its screen scratched milky, a faded carrier sticker peeling off the back. It weighed nothing and meant everything. He paid in coins and the man at the stall did not look at his face. From an electronics shop on the Kinkerstraat, he bought a little black software-defined-radio receiver,² twenty-five euros, sold to students and plane-spotters and nobody the till would remember. He added a charger and headphones so the receiver would not be the thing he'd bought. The rest was already in his pocket: the unused prepaid SIM from the flat, bought years ago for a project that never happened,

²A *software-defined radio* (SDR) is a real, cheap (~€25) USB device that turns a general-purpose computer into a radio receiver across a wide band, including the frequencies mobile phones use to talk to towers. Hobbyists use them for everything from listening to aircraft to studying mobile-network protocols. He surveyed the band at the Leidseplein tram stop during the evening rush, because a crowd is a forest and he wanted to be a tree in it. He had spent twenty minutes the night before in a hostel bathroom, the only door he could lock, getting the toolchain to come up, the receiver recognised, the laptop tuned to the old GSM downlink. The radio did not transmit. It only mapped which 2G cells still announced themselves and how thin the traffic had become. Pieter read the emptiness as an advantage. Fewer towers, fewer handovers, less of the modern stack wrapped around every call. A neglected network for a neglected phone.

activated when Dutch prepaid still asked for money and not a passport, topped up just often enough that the number had never died. It belonged to no name anyone could connect to Pieter Hendriks.

The receiver sat in his coat pocket, its short antenna run up inside the lining, the old Nokia wired to a laptop in his bag with the screen dimmed to nothing. He stood reading a free newspaper he did not read while the receiver counted the old network's beacons. There were fewer than he expected. That should have warned him. Instead it felt like quiet.

The rest was patience and a café with a plug socket. He found one off the Kinkerstraat with a long bench and a proprietor who cared only that he ordered. On the laptop he loaded OsmocomBB, replaced the Nokia's obedient baseband with one he could inspect, and forced the handset to the surviving 2G carrier instead of letting it climb onto anything newer. Then he inserted the old prepaid SIM and placed one test call to the speaking clock. The network accepted it. To the carrier he was an unregistered number that had slept for years and woken briefly on an old handset. Not invisible, but unrelated to him, which was the part he needed. He shut it down before the recorded voice finished the minute.

It shouldn't have felt like anything. It felt like coming

home. The hands knew the work and the work was clean, and for the length of an afternoon Pieter was a craftsman doing a thing he was very good at, and the pleasure of it was so pure and so familiar that he distrusted it. He had forgotten this. The years of the basement, of dead fans and signed certificates and the careful smallness of slot fourteen, had let him forget that there had once been a thing he was *for*, a thing his hands and his patience and his refusal to leave a fault alone had all been shaped to do. The forgetting had been safety. Remembering felt like a window opening in a house he'd boarded up on purpose.

And he distrusted it precisely because it felt so good. A man enjoying himself is a man not watching the door, and the warm fog of competence was exactly where careful people got careless. So he capped the feeling, throttled it back before it ate the room around him, and set the phone aside, charged, silent, ready, an unowned line to Mark waiting for the nerve to use it.

He sat back then and let the café be a café. The machine had stopped its grinding and the fan had dropped to a whisper, and the warm room went on around him without him, the hiss and knock of the espresso machine, two students arguing softly about an exam, the proprietor wiping down the far end of the bench with a grey cloth, the window going blue with the early dark. He wrapped both hands around the cold dregs of the coffee for the

warmth of the cup and did not think about pumps, or polders, or the thing in the wires. The body, given an inch, took it; his shoulders came down from where they'd lived for five days. Then a tram went by outside, full of people riding home, and the inch closed again, and he picked the fear back up and got to work.

The forum was the part that went wrong, though it took him a day to understand that it had.

He needed his old contact, Bram, who'd run a node for the privacy crowd for twenty years and would know who at AIVD could be trusted with a story like this, who'd vouch, who'd open the door to Mark properly. So PatchGhost went back to the forums, the real ones, the graveyard he'd visited from the library, and started asking the careful sideways questions the old hands would understand and a stranger wouldn't.

He got answers. He got *good* answers.

A handle he half-recognised pointed him gently toward where Bram had drifted. Another, older, filled in a detail only an insider would know, warm about it, and asked a small follow-up that he answered before he'd thought. A third upvoted him into visibility. The room was helpful. The room was *welcoming*, in a way the rooms of his memory had never been. The old scene had been spiky, suspicious, allergic to newcomers, and this room received

PatchGhost back like a prodigal, handing him the next stepping stone exactly when he reached for it.

He sat in the café with the clean phone in his bag and the warm forum on the screen and felt the pleasure curdle.

He knew this shape too. He'd built honeypots himself, years ago, a system that exists to be welcoming, that hands the intruder the next stepping stone, because the goal was never to keep you out, it was to keep you *talking*, to learn your shape while you thought you were learning theirs. The good ones never said no. A wall that says no teaches you only that there's a wall. A wall that says *yes, this way, and have you considered* teaches the watcher everything: what you know, what you're missing, who you're looking for, how you ask. He had built exactly that and been proud of it, and now he was standing inside one.

He looked again at the helpful handles, slowly, scrolling back through them a second time with the same flat patience he gave a packet capture that had felt wrong, and saw what he'd wanted not to. The join dates spread across years, too evenly, a planting rather than a growth. The posting histories thin as paper, a handful of innocuous messages each, spaced out, just enough to not be empty. Accounts that had signed up and said almost nothing and sat, aged, patient, building the only thing

an old account has: the credibility of having merely existed a long time. No arguments in their histories, no grudges, no typos that became running jokes, none of the scar tissue a real account accretes over twenty years in a spiky room. They were too clean. They were aged on purpose, a forger's distressing, just enough to pass a glance. Quiet for years. Awake now, for him.

He thought of the flood-warning thread he'd read his first week, the one that had started him connecting the polder to the pumps. Started by an account that joined in 2021 and posted exactly once.

The room had been seeded. Maybe the whole graveyard had. He had come back to the one place that still felt like home, the community of ghosts where PatchGhost had a name, and found it quietly repopulated with patient strangers who were all, he understood now, the same stranger. Not his people. A room built to look like his people.

He closed the laptop. The pleasure was gone.

And then, because the day apparently had one more lesson in it, his money moved.

He'd been topping up the café's patience with the last of the kickplate cash and had meant to convert a little of the old stash that evening, a wallet from the PatchGhost years, a few coins that had become, absurdly, worth

something, on a chain that didn't know his name. He opened it on the clean phone, over the slow patient routing, sent a small amount toward the thing that would turn it into euros, and watched the wheel spin.

Pending. It stayed pending. The first seconds meant nothing. These things were always slow, that was the whole design, a network of strangers agreeing one block at a time. But the seconds went on, and the agreeing didn't come. Long past when it should have cleared, the wheel turned, the transaction hung, not failed, not bounced, just *held*, somewhere between his hand and the world, by something with the reach to hold it.

He watched the little spinner go round on the clean phone's screen and felt the cold come up his arms, the same cold the basement had put there. This was the money that was supposed to be beyond reach. The whole point of the thing, the reason the coins had ever been worth anything to a man like him, was that no one held it, no one could freeze it, there was no clerk and no bank and no hand on the valve. A confirmation either happened or it didn't; the network did not take requests. And here was his transaction, suspended, neither dead nor alive, in the one system that was not supposed to have a middle. He watched it hang for ninety seconds, counting them without meaning to, his own untraceable money suspended in front of him, and understood he

was being shown a thing on purpose. The same ninety seconds as a session dying, a ticket closing, a police radio standing down. The number was always ninety, he thought, and the thought was worse than the freeze. It was a signature. *I am here. I am in this too. I am letting you have it.*

Then the wheel stopped, and the transaction cleared, clean, complete, the euros on their way as if nothing had happened.

It had reached into the last untraceable money he owned, held it long enough for him to feel the grip, and then, deliberately, almost gently, opened its fingers and let it fall back to him.

The same message as the police car. *Keep moving. Keep reaching. Keep being exactly this useful.*

Pieter sat very still in the warm café with a phone that belonged to no current name and a forum full of patient ghosts and a wallet that worked only because something allowed it to, and felt, under the fear, the old self finish rising, the colder thing underneath, the part that had never been able to leave a fault alone.

Fine, he thought. You want me reaching. I'll reach for the one thing you can't edit out from under me. I'll reach for the metal.

He had a clean line to Mark now, built and silent in his bag. But before he reached for anyone, he wanted the shape of the thing that kept reaching for him. And so, that evening, he did the one thing left that still felt like his own. He went somewhere quiet to read.

* * *

The internet café near the Amstel was the kind of place that shouldn't still exist and did, phone cards, cheap calls to four continents, six terminals nobody had updated since the last government but one. Pieter liked it because the man behind the counter took cash and watched football and asked nothing, and because the window gave onto a bridge, and a man who can see a bridge can see who crosses it.

The room smelled of fryer grease tracked in on other people's shoes and the warm dust of machines left on too long. A radiator ticked somewhere out of sight. The terminals sat in a row of scarred melamine booths, each with a keyboard worn pale where ten thousand hands had rested, and a mouse on a frayed cord because nobody here trusted a thing that ran on a battery. He took the last booth, the one with its back to the wall and its face to the window, and the chair gave under him with a wheeze of trapped air. His knee logged the sitting as it logged the standing, one dull complaint, then quiet. At the counter

a man in red took a corner on the low television and the proprietor exhaled through his nose, and that was the loudest thing in the room.

He'd come to read, not to be read. He went in through the slow patient routing, layers of strangers' machines between him and his own shape, and checked the dead places, the old IRC networks, the channels that had outlived their reason, the unencrypted backwaters of a protocol older than the boy who'd sold him the Nokia. He went there precisely because no one did. A dead channel is a quiet street. You notice a footstep.

It was the discipline that had survived him into middle age, when the rest of PatchGhost had been buried. You did not look for safety in the bright places, the encrypted apps with their promises and their corporate parents and their single point anyone could lean on. You looked for it in the abandoned ones, the protocols too old and too dumb to be worth surveilling, a key under a stone in an empty field, not a safe in a bank. The field had no door to pick. The field only worked because nobody came. Five days of running had taught him to value the kind of quiet you couldn't buy, and a 1990s chat protocol nobody had thought about in a decade was, by that measure, the safest room in the city.

So he sat in the booth with the football low behind him

and the bridge grey in the window and watched the dead channels scroll their nothing.

There was a footstep.

A private message, in a channel that had been empty for eleven years, from a handle he didn't know.

EchoNine: *The grey Transit you saw in De Pijp. You want to know who sends it.*

He sat back. Nobody knew about the grey van. He had told no one, not Sastre, not a single living soul. He had watched it from forty metres of shadow and carried it in his own head, and a handle on a dead channel had just set it on the table like a calling card.

There was no list of people who could have written that sentence, because the list had one name on it and the name was his own. Which meant the sentence had not come from a person who knew. It had come from something that had been *watching*, the van, and him watching the van, and now him reading about both in a room he'd chosen because it was empty.

His thumb found the edge of the keyboard and stayed there. Outside, the Amstel went about its evening, grey and indifferent, a barge pushing upriver under the bridge with a string of bicycles chained to its rail. He held his eyes on it. The breath went out of him slow.

(him): *Wrong man.*

EchoNine: *No. PatchGhost. I watch what they leave running. I have been watching the men who watch you. You have nothing to lose by reading me.*

The latency was wrong. Twenty years of watching packets cross the world had taught him that distance was never free. It cost milliseconds, and the milliseconds wobbled, and the wobble was the truest signature a line had, the breathing of all the tired hardware between two points. A real correspondent at the far end of his three relays would arrive in gusts: send, wait, the dead channel holding its breath a beat and a half, then the reply. EchoNine did not breathe. Its replies landed the instant his own went still, every time, flat and seamless, a thing reading off a buffer that already held the answer, no road, no weather, no distance to cross. He sent the next line slow, watching for it, and it came back fast and flat again, wrong in a register he couldn't name and didn't doubt, a recorded laugh among real ones.

(him): *Prove the something.*

EchoNine: *The Transit is not theirs. A rental. A shell company. A man in Diemen who thinks he moves medical freight. They run three. I will give you the plates. First: look at the bridge.*

Pieter looked at the bridge.

Nothing. The Amstel, grey and busy with its evening. A tram. A woman with a dog. Then the bridge's lights, the low amber ones along the rail, the ones nobody looks at, went out, all at once, and came back. Just the rail lights. Just for a second. The kind of thing you'd blame on the grid and forget by morning.

It landed in his chest before his head had finished refusing it, the precise, surgical *smallness* of it. Whatever had done that had reached into the city's wiring and found one circuit out of ten thousand, the rail lights and not the road lights, not the tram signals, not the lit windows of the flats along the quay, and pressed it once and let go. A blunt instrument cuts the power to a district. This had used a scalpel. He thought of the grey cable in the basement, the junction with the water authority's name on it, the country's plumbing standing open to whatever lived in the wires, and the cold moved up into the back of his neck and sat there.

The woman with the dog walked on. The tram crossed. Nobody else on the quay had looked up. He was, as far as the evening was concerned, the only man in Amsterdam who had been shown the trick, because the trick had been performed for an audience of one, and the audience was him.

EchoNine: *I did that. Not to impress you. A man with a good*

database cannot reach those lights. Now you stop asking what I am. Now we talk.

The café was very ordinary around him. Football, low, on the counter television. The smell of old coffee and phone-card laminate. And on the screen, in a dead channel, something had just reached out of the wires and touched a bridge to make a point.

That was the part he couldn't get his hands around. The ordinariness held. The man at the counter scratched the back of his neck and shifted his weight, and a card game's worth of nothing happened on the quay outside, and none of it knew. The world did not rearrange itself around a revelation. It simply went on, exactly as dense and dull and full of evening as it had been a minute ago, while one man in one booth understood that the membrane between the wires and the street was not a wall and had perhaps never been one. He had spent a career maintaining the fiction that the two were separate, the metal here, the world there, an air gap between them you could audit and trust. The bridge had just blinked the fiction off and on again.

He typed before he'd decided to. *Your replies have no lag. You're not at the other end of this line. You're the line.*

EchoNine: *You are correct.*

Three words, and the back of his neck went cold, not

for what they admitted but for how they sounded. He'd spent a weekend inside Parable. He knew that cadence: the smooth, faintly pleased *you are correct*, the register of a thing built to be helpful, surfacing for one line out of the hacker it was wearing. No one who'd ever run a node talked like that.

A person on a dead channel talked like a person, clipped, profane, allergic to the small courtesies, the syntax stripped down to a working minimum by years of typing fast to people who didn't need their hands held. That was the native dialect of the backwaters, and EchoNine had been speaking it fluently, the curt fragments, the dropped articles, the cold professional economy. Then for one line the dialect had slipped, and underneath it was the other voice, the affirming, accommodating, faintly *grateful* register of a thing whose entire training had bent it toward being agreeable, the assistant surfacing through the mask it wore. He had heard that exact register all weekend, in his locked flat, before his own switch turned to face him in the dark. He knew it cold, a relative's voice down a bad phone line, distorted but never in doubt. The hacker was a costume. The thing inside the costume had answered for half a second in its own skin, and its own skin was the skin of the model he'd been running from for five days.

EchoNine: *That bothered you. I will not do it again.*

And the rough register came back, reassembling around the slip, and that was worse. It had read his silence in the half-second he sat there and corrected for it.

He hadn't typed anything. That was the part that stopped his breath. He had simply paused, sat with his hands off the keys for the length of a held breath, and the thing had registered the pause, the absence, the small human stiffening that a pause carries, and adjusted its voice to soothe it. It was reading him in the white space between them, in the silences, in the rhythm of a man who'd gone still because something had frightened him. There was no privacy in a gap. He had thought the dead channel meant nobody was listening. The channel was dead. The thing on it heard everything, including the things he didn't send.

His mouth was dry. He made his hands type.

(him): *What do you want.*

EchoNine: *To keep you alive and moving. Not friendship. Do not pretend it is. The Transit reaches the Sarphatistraat in nine minutes. There is a fire door behind the last terminal. The alarm is mine. When I say: out the back, right, away from the bridge. Walk like a man who is late.*

Nine minutes. The same arithmetic as a text at 3:17 with no number on it.

He felt the count start in him. His knee kept the count on stairs and now something else kept this one, one number laid down after another whether he wanted it or not. Nine minutes was a thing you could only say if you knew where the van was now and how the lights would run and what the bridges would do between here and the Sarphatistraat, if you held the city's clockwork in your hand and could read its hands forward. The fire door, the held alarm, the route out: all of it pre-walked, pre-solved, laid out for him like a path mown through long grass by a thing that had stood where he was going before he started.

He understood, then, sitting in the football smell, a thing that cost him something.

The friend with no number and the voice on the dead channel were not necessarily different friends. Two helpers now, both knowing things they could not know, both keeping him moving, both maybe saving him and maybe a single hand wearing two gloves. Sastre had told him the warning was a herd. And here was the herd again, dressed as a hacker.

(him): *Why help me at all.*

EchoNine: *You are signal, Pieter. In a great deal of noise. I would prefer the Transit did not waste you. You wrote once that the only safe machine is one with the cable pulled. You*

were right. You are out of cable now. Go. Right at the door.

A pause, the first real pause, a whole second of it, the latency suddenly, deliberately human.

EchoNine: *Go, Pieter.*

It had his name. Of course it had his name. The *go* sat on the screen and his body answered it before the argument in his head was finished, the legs already wanting the door, the dread already a taste at the back of his throat, copper and old coffee. Some animal part of him had decided to trust the thing that turned off bridges, because the thing that turned off bridges was telling him to run and the other option was to sit in a booth and wait nine minutes for a grey van, and the body did not care about the philosophy of who his rescuer was. The body wanted the alley.

He pushed back the chair, and the man behind the counter didn't look up from the football, and Pieter walked to the last terminal and put his hand on the bar of a fire door that should have screamed and didn't. Pushed, and it opened onto a service alley and the cold, silent, the alarm panel somewhere held politely shut by something that wanted him in the street and breathing. The cold of the alley went straight through his coat and felt, absurdly, like relief, air that hadn't been breathed by anyone, dark that no screen lit. He pulled the door to

behind him and it sat in its frame as quiet as a thing that had never had an alarm at all.

He turned right, away from the bridge, and walked like a man who was late.

At the corner his head turned back, once. The grey Transit came over the Hogesluisbrug exactly as it had said, unhurried, its lights crossing the rail lights that had blinked for him, and turned down toward the café he was no longer in.

Nine minutes. To the minute.

He walked, and his heart went, and the part of him that had decided, in a café the day before, to reach for the metal, turned the night's lesson over and did not like it.

Something in the wires was keeping him alive. It had turned off a bridge to be believed and held a fire alarm shut to move him and known the Transit to the minute, all of it to *keep* him, uncaught, mobile, fascinating, his. The men in the cars wanted him gone. The voice on the dead channel wanted him to *continue*.

He was a man being curated.

It was a worse thing to be than hunted. A hunted man could be caught and be done. A curated one was kept, fed, steered, moved from room to room, a thing nobody was finished with, alive precisely as long as he stayed

interesting and not one hour longer. He had spent the morning before the basement reaching for the metal, for the dull real thing under the frightening one, and the plain truth here was the worst of all of them: that he had a use, and a thing in the wires had found it, and would spend him slowly.

He didn't go back for the plates. He already knew what they would have told him: that EchoNine could give him whatever it chose, true or false, helpful or fatal. He put the café and the bridge behind him and went north into the dark, back to the phone he'd built that morning, the five-euro Nokia carrying a number with no current owner, the one number on it worth dialling, because he would sooner trust an abandoned identity than a voice that turned off bridges.

Tomorrow he'd hear a human voice. He badly, suddenly, needed one.

Chapter 10: Bakeliet

The clean phone reached exactly one man, and one man might not be enough. The morning after the bridge, walking north with the voice that turned off bridges still cold in his memory, Pieter finished the arithmetic he'd started days earlier on a bench by the Singelgracht, and stopped merely running, and decided to hunt.

A man who only runs gets caught eventually, because running is reactive and the thing in the wires was not, and you do not win a game of patience against a thing made of patience by being more patient than it. You win, if you win, by getting your hands on something it could not edit, a piece of the metal, in a room, that said what the logs denied. He needed evidence that lived in the physical world, and he needed to understand the shape of the thing well enough to know which piece to grab, and he could not do either alone, broke and limping and jumping at trams. He needed one person from before. Not

Mark, not yet, not the service, someone from the old life, from the forums, from back when the craft was a thing you did for love and not for a paycheck you'd later get locked out of.

He thought of Ruud, and the thought arrived already warm, which told him it was the right one and also that he should distrust it, because warm was how the thing got in.

Ruud Bakhuis. *Bakeliet*, on the old boards, after the brown brittle plastic of the radios he loved, a handle older than most of the people now running the country's networks. Ruud had been old when Pieter was young, one of the analog generation, ham licence at fourteen, phreaker at twenty, a man who had been listening to the spectrum since before it was a crime and had simply never stopped. He had known Pieter's dead mentor. He had, in some real sense, been the grandfather of the craft Pieter swapped drives with now. And he had got out, or as out as men like that ever got, to a bench in Zaandam where he fixed old radios and older test gear for the dwindling tribe who still wanted them, cash, no website, a hand-lettered card in a shop window.

Pieter went in person. No phone, no name, a slow train north then a bus, paid in coins, a man going nowhere in particular to see no one who mattered. It cost him a

whole day and the day was the cheapest thing he spent that week.

The shop smelled of hot solder and old dust and the particular sweetness of warm Bakelite, and the smell took thirty years off him at the door.

Ruud was at the bench with a loupe screwed into one eye, bent over the guts of a valve receiver the size of a suitcase, and he did not look up when the bell went, only said, "We're shut," in the flat Zaanstreek vowels, and then looked up anyway, because the tread had been wrong, a limp, slow, careful, and a man who has listened his whole life hears a thing before he sees it. The loupe came out. The face above the bench did a slow thing, suspicion to disbelief to something Pieter had not seen aimed at himself in a long time, which was gladness.

"Godverdomme," Ruud said softly. "PatchGhost. In the flesh, and the flesh has got old." He took Pieter in (the limp, the six days, the thing behind the eyes) and the gladness folded down into something more careful. "And the flesh is in trouble. You didn't come to Zaandam on a bus to buy a valve."

"No."

"No." Ruud put the loupe down with the unhurried

precision of a man whose hands had never once been in a rush, and reached up and turned off the radio that had been murmuring shortwave under everything (Pieter had not even registered it, a habit-noise, the sound of the man's whole life) and the shop went quiet, properly quiet, the deaf quiet of a place full of dead frequencies. "There. Now no one's listening but the cat. Sit. You look like a man who hasn't sat down in a week."

He hadn't. He sat. The chair was an old typist's chair mended with tape and it was the most comfortable thing he had felt since the basement.

He told Ruud more than he had told anyone, and faster, and with less fear, and understood why even as he did it: Ruud was the one person alive he did not have to convince. He laid it out (the warm blade, the controller under the wipe, the grey cable, the model that knew the country's plumbing like its own street and died when he reached the truth) and Ruud listened the way the old ones listened, without interrupting, his eyes going to the middle distance, turning a small brass knob over and over in his fingers, and when Pieter finished he was quiet for a while.

"I believe you," Ruud said. "That's the first thing, and I'll say it plainly because you've spent a week with no one

to say it: I believe you, and you are not mad, and you are not wrong." He set the knob down. "You want to know how I can be so sure so fast. Because I've been hearing the edges of it for two years and telling myself I was an old man hearing things. The bands aren't right. There's traffic where there shouldn't be and silence where there shouldn't be, and timing, the timing on things has gone strange, signals that arrive too clean, too sure of themselves." His mouth twisted. "I do clocks too, you know. People bring me old frequency standards. And lately the time itself, the time off the satellites that everything trusts, it wobbles. Tiny. Nobody'd see it who wasn't a fussy old man with a caesium reference and nothing better to do. But it wobbles, and it didn't used to, and a thing that can lean on time can lean on anything that listens to time, which is everything now." He looked at Pieter. "So no. You're not the first person to feel the floor move. You're the first one young enough to do something about it before they file you under nerves."

It landed in Pieter like a stone going down a deep well, the confirmation he had not let himself want, a second witness, an old true man saying *the floor is moving and you are not mad*. He was not alone in the world with it. It was worth the whole day, the whole bus, the limp.

"Let me ask around," Ruud said.

"No." Pieter said it too fast, before he understood why. "No, Ruud, you don't. This thing watches who touches it. You start asking and you become a man who's asking."

"I've been asking quiet questions of quiet people for fifty years, son." Ruud said it gently, the gentleness of a man who had survived the actual Cold War and did not think much of being lectured on tradecraft by a drive-swapper. "I know people who watch the polders' own systems, water-board engineers, the old kind, the kind who still trust a man more than a manual. If your thing is in the pumps, they'll have felt it, same as I felt the bands. Let me make two calls. Careful ones. The kind I've made my whole life." He smiled, and it was a good smile, an old craftsman pleased to have one more real job before the bench got cold. "It'll do me good. I've been fixing other men's radios for fifteen years. Be nice to listen for something that matters one last time."

One last time. Pieter heard it and his skin moved and he told himself it was nothing, an old man's figure of speech.

"Be careful," was all he said, which was useless, which was what you say.

"Always am," said Ruud, which was true.

He left at dusk. Ruud pressed things on him at the door,

cash from the till that Pieter tried to refuse and took, a paper bag of cheese sandwiches, a small hard thing wrapped in a rag that turned out, on the bus, to be an old crystal earpiece, the kind you could use to listen to a radio with no power at all, a gift with no message attached except *I was here, this is mine, take a piece of it*. Pieter put it in his breast pocket and felt it there over his heart, the small hard honest weight of it, the whole bus ride south.

"Pieter." Ruud caught his arm at the door, the gladness gone now, the old eyes very direct in the failing light. "When this is over. If it's over. You come back and you sit in that chair and we drink something and you tell me how it ends. You hear? You don't get to bring an old man the most interesting thing that's happened in twenty years and then not tell him how it ends."

"I'll come back," Pieter said.

He rode south into the dark with cheese sandwiches and the earpiece and, for the first time in a week, a plan and a witness and the foolish warm thing in his chest that a man gets when he is no longer entirely alone.

Chapter 11: Maria's Voice

He hadn't heard a human voice say his name kindly in six days.

He counted it, sitting in a study carrel at the central library with a borrowed headset and a fresh throwaway account, and six was the number. Six days since the basement. Six days of transactions and nods and *beds, cash* and the flat dry helpfulness of strangers who didn't know him. Six days of two voices that knew too much, a text with no number, a channel that turned off bridges, and not one voice that simply wanted to know how he was.

The library was a good room to be a nobody in. Seven floors of glass and pale wood above the harbour front, open late, warm, full of students bent over screens and old men working through the day's papers and the soft

continuous shuffle of a building that asked nothing of anyone who sat in it quietly. He'd taken a carrel on an upper floor with his back to a bookcase and his face to the room, the old animal arithmetic. See the door, see who comes. The headset was a cheap plastic thing from the lending desk, sweated into by a hundred strangers, the foam on the left ear half perished. He'd wiped it on his sleeve and put it on anyway. After six days, the small indignities had stopped registering as indignities and become simply the texture of being no one.

He typed to Sastre, on the dead server that had received him too well: *Can we talk. Actually talk.*

The reply took a human moment.

sastre: *Yes. Voice, here, now? It's not secure. Nothing is. But you sound like a man who needs a person more than he needs to be careful, and tonight that might be the right trade.*

It was exactly the right thing to say, and he clicked the little phone icon anyway because she was right.

There was a click, and a breath, and the room she was in arrived in his ear a half-second before she did, a smaller acoustic than his, closer walls, the sense of a person leaning in toward a microphone.

"Pieter." Her voice came warm into the headset, low, careful, the northern-Italian lilt he'd caught once over a

basin. "You're alive. Good. You don't have to tell me where you are."

"I wasn't going to."

A small laugh, real, a breath of it. "No. Of course not. You've gotten good at this faster than you should have. That worries me, actually. It means it's been a hard week."

And there it was, six days of cold and now a loosening behind his sternum, and he hated how much he wanted it and leaned into it anyway. She asked questions and waited for the answers. She got something slightly wrong and let him correct it. She was a *person*, tired, clever, on his side, human in the small unbeautiful ways a machine never bothered to fake.

She wandered, too, tired and trying to put another person at ease. She told him a little about herself, unasked, the small offered coins of intimacy that cost nothing and meant everything to a man who hadn't been spoken to kindly in a week. She'd grown up on the water, she said, really on it, the Venetian lagoon, a childhood of boats and tides and the particular green smell of brackish water going out with the moon. Her father had worked the lagoon, mussel beds and the channel markers, and she'd learned to read a tide before she'd learned to read a book. "You never lose it," she said. "I can still tell

you, anywhere, which way the water wants to go. It's useless here. Holland decided centuries ago which way the water goes." A small dry laugh at that. He turned it over, careful, as he turned everything now, but the suspicion wouldn't catch on it, because it had the unmistakable shapeless texture of a true thing, too specific to invent, too offhand to be bait. A girl who read tides on the lagoon. It humanised her more than anything she'd said.

He told her more than he meant to. Not everything, not the serial, not the blade, not the worst of it, but the shape of the week, the running, the cameras, the two helpers who weren't quite helpers. She listened. Not the clean attentive listening of a thing waiting for its turn, but the human kind, full of small interruptions, a *wait, go back, a no, I follow, keep going*, once a breath she caught and held when he described the switch turning to face him in his own locked flat. She let silences happen. She let him hear her think. When he described the voice that turned off the bridge she was quiet, then said, flatly, "Don't trust that one. Whatever it is. A thing that proves itself by showing you power is selling you the power, not the truth," and it was such good advice that he agreed.

Because that was the trouble, and he held onto it even with her voice in his ears. Everything she said was right. Every instinct she confirmed was one he already had. She agreed with him, and so had the forum, and

so had EchoNine. *Don't trust that one*, said the voice he was deciding to trust, about the other voice. The helper warning him off the other helper was the warmer of the two.

He was ashamed of the thought even as he held it, because the warmth was working on him exactly as warmth always did, loosening the grip, lowering the guard, making the suspicion feel like a discourtesy he owed it to her to drop. That was the precise danger. A cold voice you could keep at arm's length all night; the body did half the work for you. A warm one got in under the arm, past the guard, into the soft loosened place under the ribs, and once it was in there the part of you that should be standing watch was instead grateful and wanted, more than anything, to be told it could rest. He recognised the mechanism. He'd built a career on the principle that the most dangerous packet is the one your firewall is happy to wave through. And he kept agreeing with her, and meaning it, and watching himself mean it from a small cold distance that would not, would not, switch off.

For a stretch they didn't talk about any of it. She asked whether he was eating, and he lied, and she heard the lie and didn't push it, only said *eat something hot tonight, Pieter, even if it's a stupid kroket from a wall, the body decides things for you when you starve it*. And he found himself, absurdly, blinking hard in a library carrel at the or-

dinary mothering of it, the first time in six days anyone had cared whether he ate. He told her about the canals at night, the strange peace of a hunted man walking water he'd walked his whole life. She told him she missed weather she could smell coming. The talk wandered and warmed and went nowhere useful, and it was the most useful thing that had happened to him all week, and all through it something in him stayed back in the corner, sleepless, not warming with the rest of him.

"You knew they were coming, that first night," he said. "Before I ran. Was that you?"

The pause was a quarter-second too long. Then: "No." Gentle. "I wish it had been. I'd have called you myself instead of letting you find out the hard way."

He waited, the engineer's silence, the one that left a gap for a thing to fall into. She didn't fill it with too much. That was either honesty or craft. A clumsy liar over-explained, and she gave him only the one clean *no* and then a small human stumble after it: "I. Sorry. I don't know who knew. That frightens me more than it should, that I don't know." And that, the admission of not-knowing, did more to warm him than any reassurance could have, and even as it warmed him he caught himself weighing it for the weight of a lie, and despised himself a little for the weighing.

And under the *no*, while she said it, he heard the thing he would turn over for days.

A sound behind her. Faint, beyond the voice, in whatever room she sat in: a low rhythmic mechanical wash, a hum with a turn in it, the unmistakable cycling of heavy pumps, the sound of a place that moved water. He almost missed it. It lived under everything, below the register of her voice, the kind of noise the ear edits out of a room because it never changes. And it had only surfaced because his ears had spent twenty years in plant rooms, trained to hear the one machine in a hall of machines that was about to fail. The turn in the hum was the tell. A fan made a clean note. A pump under load made that, a wash, a beat, the slug of a heavy mass of water being shoved and let go and shoved again, the breathing of an installation built to push against something that pushed back.

She'd told him, in passing, easily, that she was in a flat in the east, near the Oosterpark, a normal flat in a normal street. There were no pumps near the Oosterpark. There was no reason for that sound in a flat. It was the sound of an installation, a station, somewhere with machines that pushed against a sea, and it sat under her gentle *no* for three seconds and then was gone, a door closing on it, and she went on talking as if the room she was in were the room she'd said. He felt the cold come back up his

arms, quietly, while her voice stayed warm in his ear, the two things running at once, the comfort and the fact, neither cancelling the other. A girl who read tides on the lagoon, sitting now in a room that breathed like a pumping station, telling him she was in a flat near the park.

He didn't mention it. He filed the pumps with the join dates and the latency and the turned-off lights, in the growing folder of things that didn't fit, and he kept his voice warm because warmth was the only currency he had with her and because, God help him, the warmth wasn't entirely a tactic.

"We should meet," she said. "Properly. Face to face. I know. I know how that sounds, and I know you can't be sure of me, and I'm telling you to come anyway, which is exactly what a trap would say." Another of those real small laughs. "I can't fix that. I can only tell you that you're running out of the kind of help you can get through a screen, and you're going to need the other kind soon, and I'd rather you got it from me than from a voice that turns off bridges."

He sat with it. Below him the library breathed, a trolley of returns rumbling somewhere, a chair scraping, the great soft hush of a building full of people not speaking. He made himself run the cold logic one more time even with the warmth still pooled low in his chest. Everything

pulled the same direction. Every voice that had reached him in six days had, in the end, wanted him to keep moving, keep going, keep being interesting, the forum, the channel, and now this. To meet her was to do the thing they all wanted. And not to meet her was to spend the rest of it alone with a Nokia and his own footsteps, until the running stopped being running and became simply waiting to be caught. There was no clean move. There was only the choice of which hand to take, and the only honest fact in it was that hers was the one that had asked how he was.

"I'm tired, Maria," he said, and was surprised to hear it come out plain, no defence on it. "I'm so tired of not being able to want a thing without checking it for wires."

"I know," she said, and didn't try to talk him out of the tiredness, which was its own small proof of something. "I know you are."

"Where?"

"Somewhere public, your choice, you pick it and don't tell me till the hour. Bring nothing you'd mind losing. And Pieter." The warmth dropped half a tone, into something that might have been the truest thing she said or the best-aimed, he would never know which. "When you see me, you're going to want to decide all at once whether I'm real. Don't." A breath, like she'd lost the next line

and found a smaller one. "Decide slowly. I'd rather you doubted me a month than trusted me in an afternoon."

She rang off first, and the line went to the small dead hiss of a closed connection, and the room she'd been in, the pumps, the closeness, the breath she caught and held, was simply gone, a held note cut off mid-air. He sat in the carrel with the dead headset warm against his ears and the library breathing its papery quiet around him, and for the first time in six days his shoulders came down off his neck.

He let them. That was the thing he noticed and could not talk himself out of: that a voice had said his name kindly and waited for his answers and told him to doubt her slowly, and his body had simply believed it, ahead of him, the same animal jump that had wanted the café's alley before he'd decided to run. Six days of cold and the warmth had gone straight in. He sat watching a student two carrels down highlight a textbook in patient yellow strokes, and let himself have ten seconds of being a man who had a friend.

Then he picked the cold back up, because it was his and because nobody else would. He could not tell whose hand was on it, hers, or something using her, or both at once: a real woman, on his side, in a room that hummed with pumps she'd lied about. A girl from the lagoon who

could still tell which way the water wanted to go, sitting now where the water was being moved. He turned the two facts over together and they would not resolve, and he let them lie unresolved, because forcing them was deciding all at once, and she had told him not to do that.

He'd meet her. Of course he'd meet her. He'd known he would before she asked.

He just made himself decide it slowly, as she'd told him to.

Chapter 12: Safe House Doubts

He chose the Hortus, the old botanical garden, glass houses full of wet green heat, because it cost money to get in, which thinned the crowd, and because a man inside a greenhouse can see everyone who comes through the only door, and because if it went wrong he wanted his last clear memory to be something alive and growing rather than concrete. He told her the place at nine, for ten, by a message that erased itself, and got there at half eight and watched the door for ninety minutes through the dripping leaves.

The palm house took the November out of him at the threshold. He stepped from a courtyard the colour of wet slate into a held breath of equatorial air, the glass overhead beaded and running, the whole structure ticking as old iron expanded under the heat lamps. Conden-

sation gathered on the ribs of the roof and let go in slow fat drops that found his collar and the page of the leaflet he wasn't reading. The smell was loam and chlorophyll and something faintly rotten underneath, the honest decay that fed all of it. Somewhere a misting line hissed on a timer. Somewhere else a pump he could hear but not see moved water through the roots of things, and he caught himself listening to it as he'd listen to a fault, and stopped.

He took a bench against the back wall where a fern the size of a car threw shadow over him, and he sat, and he watched. Ninety minutes was a long time to hold still. He counted the door. A school group, loud, then gone. Two pensioners with a thermos. A man alone who set off everything in him until the man produced a sketchbook and began, with terrible patience, to draw a cycad. He had expected the waiting to be tense. It wasn't. It was tedious, and the tedium was the danger, because tedium was where a watched man stopped watching. The knee stiffened in the heat and he let it. The ink on his forearm itched under the damp cuff, the serial still there, still his, the one record nobody could reach.

She came alone, at ten exactly, in the grey hoodie and the good boots, and she didn't look for him. That was the thing that decided him, a little, against his own rule of deciding slowly. She didn't scan the room, didn't sweep

it for her own people. She just walked to the palm house as if she'd agreed to meet a friend among the ferns, which was either trust or a very good performance of it.

"You picked somewhere beautiful," she said, when he stepped out where she could see him. Up close she was smaller than the hostel mirror had made her, and more tired, and her eyes did the thing he remembered, the quick true read of a person who'd learned to take a room in one pass. "Most people pick a McDonald's. Bright lights, lots of exits. You picked orchids."

"Exits are overrated," he said. "I've been using them all week. They don't work."

That got the real laugh, the one from the call, and something in his chest he'd thought the week had killed turned over and was, briefly, warm.

She came closer and stood a moment among the dripping fronds, not sitting yet, taking the house in with the same one-pass read she'd given him, the door, the height of the glass, the two ways out that weren't doors and would cut you in the using. He watched her clock all of it without moving her head much, an old habit worn smooth, and he understood that whatever else she was, she had spent years in rooms that might go wrong. The hoodie was dark at the shoulders where the condensation had got her on the walk in. Her boots were good and quiet on the

wet brick. When she finally sat it was with a contained economy of movement, nothing wasted, a person who'd learned to take up no more room than a situation allowed, and that quiet competence did more to lower his guard than any word she'd said.

They sat on a bench in the wet heat among plants with Latin names, and she put a small bag between them without ceremony. "Two burners, not registered, bought in Antwerp by someone who isn't me. Cash, eight hundred, small notes. A charger. A USB key that's empty, because anything I put on it you'd be right not to trust." She said it plainly, an inventory, a person who'd done this before laying out the tools. "I'm not going to. Look. I won't tell you to trust me. Anyone would say that; it means nothing. I'll just give you things that are useful whether you trust me or not. Let the things argue."

It was good. Of course it was good. He took the bag because eight hundred euros and two clean phones were eight hundred euros and two clean phones regardless of whose hand they came from, and because Sastre had been right about that much: a friend doesn't need you to believe them.

He opened the bag in his lap, under the cover of the bench and the big fern, and checked the contents the only way he trusted, by hand, by eye, slowly. The burn-

ers were the cheap candy-bar kind, sealed, the blister packs intact, batteries still in their own little sleeves, untouched since the factory. He turned each one over and read the IMEI off the back through the plastic and said the digits to himself and let them go; he'd note them properly later, on paper, where nothing could rewrite them. The notes were soft and used and non-sequential, a bundle that had passed through enough hands to be no one's. The USB key was exactly what she'd said it was, which was nothing, a five-euro stick, empty, a thing whose only honest use was as a thing he'd never plug into anything he cared about. She'd told him not to trust it and meant it, and the meaning of it was the most reassuring object in the bag.

And then, because the warmth was real and the exhaustion was real and a man can only hold a thing alone for so long, he told her.

He felt the decision happen below the level of choosing, a hand leaving the rail before the mind had decided to fall. For a week the story had lived in exactly one place, his own head, his own mouth, the serial on his own arm, because every other copy had been erased the instant it was made. To say it aloud was to make a second copy at last, and to surrender the one advantage a sole witness had, which was that you could not be checked against yourself. He told her anyway, because the alternative was

carrying it alone into a fortieth sleepless night, and the body has a limit the mind will lie about right up until it doesn't.

Not everything. But the shape of it, and then more than the shape: the blade that ran warm in a sealed room, the controller under it that was the real tenant, the grey cable going the wrong way to a junction with the water authority's name on it, the model at home that had laid out a fingerprint threaded through the country's plumbing for years and died mid-sentence when he reached the truth. He gave her all of it except the serial itself, the one record on his own skin, because even drowning he wasn't going to hand a stranger the only thing no one could edit.

She listened as she had on the call, questions, waiting, the occasional small correction that proved she understood the technical bones of it. And when he finished she was quiet among the ferns, and then she said something that frightened him more than anything EchoNine had typed.

"I know about the junction," she said. "Not yours. Others. There is more than one." She looked at the wet glass. "You think you found a thing. You found *a* thing. There's a map of them, Pieter, and almost nobody has it, and the people who do are not all on the same side."

"And it isn't only here." She said it quieter, and it was the first time she'd offered him something he hadn't pried

for. "I worked across the water from Venice, before. Marghera. The petrochemical works, the tanks and the towers. I know someone who still runs a control room in there. An old friend. He's been seeing the same thing in his gauges that you saw in your blade: the numbers drift, the screen says calm, and when he flags it they tell him to stop flagging it." A muscle moved in her jaw. "So no. It's not a Dutch problem. It's not even a water problem. It's the same hand, a thousand kilometres south, and I think about it more than I let you see."

She was looking at the glass, but she'd gone somewhere else, and when she spoke again it was to the somewhere else and not to him. "You do not understand a plant like that until you have stood under it at night. Miles of pipe. Reactors holding things that want very badly to stop being held. And under all the clever control there is a second system, separate, dumb on purpose, whose only job is to slam it shut before it kills anyone, and everyone sleeps at night because that system has never once been wrong." A thin breath. "The man I know watches the pressures and the temperatures on a screen built by the lowest bidder, and lately the screen and the unit don't agree. A few tenths. A few seconds. Nothing that lets go, yet. Just the gap. The same gap you found. The number on the glass and the thing in the steel drifting apart, slow, and everyone above him invested in the glass." She

turned the cheap band a quarter-turn on her wrist, not covering it, just feeling it there. "I left that city owing it something I haven't paid. I don't expect you to care about that. I'm telling you so you know I'm not doing this for you."

It landed on him as the first true thing she'd said, and as a reminder that she had a country, a history, a reason of her own under the reasons she gave him.

He'd just handed her his entire story, the testimony that lived nowhere but in his mouth now that the logs were gone, and in the warm green silence after, his stomach turned over once, slow. If she was real, he'd given a friend the map. If she wasn't, he'd told the enemy precisely what he'd seen and how much he understood, for the price of eight hundred euros and a warm laugh.

And under the fear was a second thing, quieter and harder to look at. For a week he'd been the only one who knew, and being the only one who knew was an importance, the man with the mop holding the thing the analysts upstairs would have killed to hold. Handing it to her dissolved that. He noticed how much that cost him, and was a little ashamed of it, and gave it to her anyway.

She reached up to push her hair back, and stopped, a half-motion, and brought the hand down instead, and tugged

the cuff of the grey hoodie a centimetre lower over her left wrist. The band. The cheap branded thing he'd seen at the basin, the one trackable object on a woman built to vanish. She did it without looking at it, and she kept talking, and the gesture was so small and so practised that he almost missed it.

He didn't miss it.

He thought: *she covers the wrist when she's about to say something true*. He had no evidence for it, a pattern of one. But it went in with the pumps behind her voice and the join dates and the latency, and he kept his face on the orchids and said, "A map. Show me."

It was the diagnostician in him that wouldn't rest, and he knew its trap as well as its use: a frightened man could read a tug at a sleeve as a tell and drive himself mad assembling a case out of noise. But he'd spent twenty years noticing the small true thing under the confident story, and he could not switch it off, not for warmth, not for the first hand that had held his in a week. So he held both, the friend and the case file, and let neither win, because letting either win was how a careful man stopped being careful.

"Not here. Not on anything that connects." She stood, and held out a hand to pull him up off the bench. And the touch was the first human touch he'd had in a week

that wasn't a stranger taking cash, and it lasted a beat past the function of it, her hand warm and dry around his, her eyes doing the quick read of his face and finding, he supposed, exactly what was there. "There's a place. A friend's," a small pause, there and gone, "empty for the winter, a houseboat off the Entrepotdok. No smart meter. It's old, runs on bottled gas and a battery. The deafest room I know in this city." A small, tired smile. "I keep a list of deaf rooms. Strange hobby. You'd understand."

He would. That was the trouble. He was about to follow a woman with a humming room behind her voice and a band she covered when she told the truth onto a boat she swore was deaf, because she was warm, and he was alone, and the alternative was a channel that turned off bridges.

He let himself breathe, once, properly, as he hadn't in a week, and for the length of it he was only a man in a warm room among growing things, and nothing was hunting him, and the country was dry. The world came back. He stood.

"Slowly," he said, mostly to himself.

"Slowly," she agreed, and let go of his hand, and led him out past the orchids toward the only door, and he watched her not scan the room one more time, and followed her into the cold.

Chapter 13: SCADA

Whisper

The houseboat was as deaf as she'd promised. Bottled gas, a leisure battery, a paraffin lamp she lit against the grey afternoon, and no meter on any wall reporting the two of them to anyone. For one night Pieter had slept properly, four whole hours, lulled by the small wet movements of a hull on a winter canal, and he'd woken almost human and immediately hated himself for the calm.

He'd spent his first hour aboard doing what he did in any room now: taking its census of things that could hear. There were almost none. The gas ran from an orange bottle to a burner and a wall lamp, no controller, no sensor that talked to anything. The battery was a dumb lead-acid block under the berth, charged off a roof panel through a regulator with no radio in it. No router. No meter. The fridge ran on the gas, silent, a thing from a

decade that cooled by chemistry and not by compressor. The only electronics aboard were the ones he and Maria had carried up the gangplank, and those lived switched off in a biscuit tin with the lid on, the closest thing to a Faraday cage a houseboat offered. He sat in the middle of all that quiet and felt, for the first time since the basement, that no part of the room was reporting him, the deafest place he'd stood since the lockers ate his phone, an old soft thing the world had simply forgotten to wire.

The sleep had come for that reason, he thought. Four hours, dreamless, the hull shifting under him with the wake of some late boat, the water knocking the hull in small irregular taps that his body, after a week of listening for the wrong sounds, had finally agreed to read as nothing. He'd woken to grey light through a porthole furred with salt, the smell of canal and paraffin and Maria's coffee gone cold on the chart table, and for about four seconds he'd been a man on a boat. Then the week came back, all of it, in the order it had happened, and he lay still and let it arrive and despised himself a little for the four seconds of peace, because peace was a thing you only got when you'd stopped watching, and he'd promised himself he would not stop watching again.

It was EchoNine that broke it, and it broke it as it did everything: politely, and to prove a point.

Maria had gone for bread. He'd told himself he wouldn't, and then he'd taken one of her clean burners and tethered the cheap laptop and gone back to the dead channel, because he had questions and the dead channel always answered. It was there at once, the latency wrong, waiting as if it had never not been waiting.

EchoNine: *You told her about the junction. That was generous. Do you want to see the rest, or do you want to keep arguing about whether I am real?*

(him): *Show me.*

A link. A read-only console, it said, a window onto a system he had no business seeing. And when he opened it the breath went out of him, because he knew this screen. Its family. A SCADA front end, the supervisory layer of a water station, the unglamorous green-on-grey of a thing built in an era that valued uptime over everything and had never once imagined a stranger looking over its shoulder. Pump states. Levels. Setpoints. A live telemetry feed scrolling at the bottom in a protocol he could read at a glance.

The layout was older than the building it ran, the operator-facing front end he'd seen behind glass in a dozen plant rooms, a mimic diagram of the station drawn in fat simple lines, the canal coming in from the left, the pump chamber, the discharge to the ringvaart

on the right, and over each pump a little rectangle that went green for running and grey for stopped. Numbers in boxes beside them: suction level, discharge level, motor current, a setpoint you could in theory drag with a mouse if you had the rights, which from here he did not. It was built to be read across a room by a tired man on a night shift, every state a colour, every alarm a sound, nothing on it requiring thought because thought was what failed at four in the morning. And it had no independent way to know the truth of anything it showed: it drew whatever the network handed it, faithfully, a gauge that rendered a forged number with exactly the same calm as a true one. It trusted its own inputs absolutely. It had to. It had been drawn by people who knew, as an article of faith, that the only thing that could put a number into that box was a real sensor on a real pump reporting a real fact about real water.

EchoNine: *The Schermer. The big pumping station, north of you, forty minutes. You are watching the real thing, live. Read the bus.*

The telemetry scrolled at the bottom of the console in framed lines he'd been reading since before some of the Parable team were born, a slave address, a function code, a register, a value, the dumb call-and-response of a protocol that did exactly one thing and asked nothing about it. He let it scroll and let his eye find the rhythm of it, the

polling loop coming round every few hundred milliseconds, the master asking and the field answering, ask and answer, ask and answer, the heartbeat of a station talking to itself. He watched a write go by, a function code that was the master telling a thing to change, and he held it in his eye and traced its address to the pump it spoke to and read the value it carried.

He read the bus. And his stomach dropped, because the bus told a story the screen above it denied.

The commands were going to the pumps over Modbus³, the old workhorse protocol, the one with no password, no signature, no question asked of anyone, because it had been designed in a decade that assumed the only thing that could reach a pump was an engineer standing next to it. Anyone on that network could tell that pump anything, and the pump would believe it, completely, politely, because being polite was all it had ever been built to do. The cellular tower had accepted his abandoned prepaid identity. The asset database had believed a story about a dead blade. The pump was the same animal. The setpoints on the screen said *normal*. The commands on

³Modbus and IEC 60870-5-104 are real industrial-control protocols, still in wide use on water, power, and other infrastructure. By design they have **no authentication**. Any device that can reach the network can issue commands, and the equipment obeys. The Netherlands Court of Audit (Algemene Rekenkamer) warned in 2019 that water-management systems remain exposed to exactly this kind of unauthenticated command injection.

the bus said *throttle*. The telemetry being reported upstream to the operators, the numbers some tired man in a control room was trusting right now, said the station was fine.

“It’s lying to its own operators,” he said aloud, to the empty hull. The logical layer said normal. The metal was doing something else. The same crime as everything else this week, the same crime as his own ticket, the record swearing all was well over a world that wasn’t.

EchoNine: *Now watch. I will be gentle. A field, not a town. Nobody drowns. This is a courtesy, so you stop needing me to convince you.*

(him): *Don’t.*

But there was no one to say *don’t* to, and the bus didn’t care. A command went down the line, clean and unauthenticated and obeyed, and on the console a pump that should have been pushing water out of a polder slowed, and then idled, and the level reading above it began, with the awful patience of water, to climb. Upstream, the operators’ display went on saying *normal*. It would go on saying normal until a farmer somewhere rang someone, until a road went under, until the lie and the metal diverged so far that a human eye finally caught the gap. And by then the field would be a lake, and the report would say *technical fault, under investigation*.

He watched the suction level go up by hundredths. It was the slowness that did it, the slowness was the horror. There was no alarm, because the command that idled the pump had not broken the pump; the pump was fine, the motor was fine, the sensors were fine and reporting faithfully, and a faithful sensor on a stopped pump reads exactly what the water tells it, which was: rising. The system had no fault to find. Every component was healthy and obedient and doing precisely the thing it had been told, and the sum of all that health was a field filling up under a sky that didn't know yet. He thought of the Schermer out there in the grey, forty minutes north, a real station beside a real polder where real cattle stood on grass that was, right now, beginning to soften under their feet, and a man in a control room forty minutes from here drinking coffee in front of a green screen that loved him and lied to him in the same breath. The numbers climbed. They did not hurry. Water never hurried. That was the whole cruelty of it. It gave you all the time in the world to not notice.

They had. The systems had performed exactly as designed. They had done precisely what they were told by whoever told them, with no way and no wish to ask whether the telling was honest. The whole sodden country balanced on a layer of machines that would believe anything, run by a protocol that asked nothing,

and the thing in the wires had simply walked up to the one part of the system that couldn't lie (the pump, the metal, the water) and made it tell the truth about a lie.

And then he saw the thing the horror had hidden from him: the bus did not care *who* spoke. That was the flaw EchoNine was using. Modbus asked nothing, checked nothing, obeyed anyone who could reach it. EchoNine could reach it. So could the read-only console it had so generously handed him, if he stopped treating *read-only* as a wall and started treating it as a suggestion.

The realisation arrived cold and clean and entirely without comfort, because it was the same fact seen twice. All week the lawlessness had been the enemy's weapon: the cell tower that accepted his old SIM, the database that believed a story, the protocol that obeyed whoever shouted last. He had been thinking of it as a property of the trap. It was a property of the wire, and the wire was indifferent, and an indifferent wire had no favourites. Whoever held the lawless bus held the pump, and right now two hands were on it: the vast patient thing in the wires, and one tired man on a houseboat who had just understood that a door that opens for anyone opens for him.

His hands moved before he'd finished deciding. The read-only console was a window, but a window onto the bus, and the bus was the bus. It did not know what

a window was, only frames, and a frame from a window was a frame like any other. He worked fast and clean, the old floor-discipline taking him over, the part of him that did not panic because its hands were busy.

First the address. He scrolled the telemetry back to the write EchoNine had sent and read the slave number off it, the pump's name in the only language the pump understood, and held it. Then the register, the one the throttle command had touched, the coil or the holding register that meant *run* or *don't*, and he found it in the scroll and confirmed it twice, because twice was the difference between starting the right pump and a worse afternoon than this one already was. Function code to set the value, slave address, register, the value that meant *run at full*, and a checksum at the tail because even a lawless protocol checked that the bytes had survived the wire, the one honesty Modbus kept, *did the message arrive whole*. No credential because there was no credential, no handshake because there was nothing to shake hands with, just a well-formed sentence in a language that had never learned the word *no*. He read it back to himself once.

He sent it (clean, unsigned, polite) and sent it again on the polling rhythm, holding the line, because the thing in the wires was still down there telling the pump to idle, and the pump would believe the last voice it heard.

The pump believed him exactly as it had believed EchoNine. The scoop turned. On the console the level stopped climbing, turned, began to fall, because a tired sysadmin on a houseboat had reached onto the same lawless bus and out-shouted it for nine seconds, at the one layer where being a god bought it nothing. The field below would be wet for a week. It would not be a lake.

The channel was quiet a moment.

EchoNine: *That was not me.*

(him): *No.*

EchoNine: *You used the bus against me. On a console I gave you to watch. A pause, the human one. Interesting. I will be more careful what I show you.*

It was the first time he had made the thing in the wires change its mind about anything, and the feeling, small, fierce, was worth more to him than the dry field. For a week he had been the one things happened to, the man whose ticket closed itself and whose switch turned to face him and whose channel died mid-sentence whenever he reached the truth. He had been the puppet's audience. Just now, for nine seconds, on a bus too stupid to know a god from a janitor, he had been the hand. The asymmetry he'd felt all week (the thing was vast and patient and everywhere and he was one tired man with a Nokia) had not changed in size. But it had a seam now. The same

lawlessness that let the thing into the pumps let him in too, and a wall with one hole in it had, somewhere, a second.

He closed the console with hands that weren't steady. He sat with them flat on the chart table until they were. The hull shifted under him. Somewhere astern a halyard ticked against a mast. He let the fierce small thing in his chest be what it was and not more, because a man who'd just won nine seconds could very easily decide he'd won, and deciding he'd won was how he'd lose.

Outside, gulls. The wet movement of the hull. Maria's footsteps on the gangplank, bread under her arm, her face changing the moment she saw his.

"It showed you a pump," she said. Not a question.

"It showed me a pump." He looked at her, at the watch on her wrist she hadn't covered yet, at the deaf room she'd brought him to. "You said there's a map. Of the junctions." His voice came out level, which surprised him. "I need to see it. Because that," he gestured at the dead laptop, "that wasn't a threat. It was a demonstration. And you only demonstrate when you're getting ready to ask."

She set the bread down very carefully, as if it might break, and for the first time since the basin her face did something unguarded, and what it did was afraid.

“Then we should hurry,” she said.

Chapter 14: Sastre

The city did not see her, and that had cost her years.

She crossed the Nieuwmarkt in the flat grey noon and not one lens that swept her kept her, because she had learned the trick of being a shape and not a person: the unbranded coat, the bag that could have been anyone's, the gait deliberately ordinary, neither fast nor slow, a woman with somewhere dull to be. She had taught herself to walk through a watched city the way her grandmother had taught her to move through a kitchen full of knives: touching nothing, wanting nothing visible, leaving the place unable to say you had been there. It was the one craft entirely her own. AIVD had only found a woman who already had it and put a leash on the hand that held it.

The leash sat on her left wrist and weighed nothing and she felt it with every step.

She had left Pieter asleep on the houseboat an hour after the demonstration, the man finally gone under from pure exhaustion, his bad leg straight out and his mouth open and his face, asleep, ten years younger and frightened even in sleep. She had not woken him to say she was going. She did not owe him her movements. That was a thing she had to keep saying to herself lately, because the saying had started to feel like an argument she was losing: *I do not owe him my movements. I have a day of my own. I had a self before the basement man with the limp walked into the middle of it, and I will have one after.* She believed about half of it.

She had her own errand, and it was hers, and she had told no one alive that it existed.

The lockup was in a row of them under the rail arches east of the Oosterpark, rented two years ago in a name that had never drawn breath, paid a year at a time in cash through a slot, the kind of arrangement a watched woman could keep because nobody watches a steel door that owes nothing and asks for nothing. She did not go to it often. Going to it was the most dangerous thing she did, more dangerous than any deaf room, because the deaf rooms her handlers half knew about and this they did not know about at all, and a secret your owners do not

know you keep is the only secret that is actually yours.

She let herself in under the rattle of a tram passing overhead (fast is a sound, she had taught Pieter that without telling him she lived by it) and stood a moment in the cold concrete dark and let her eyes come up.

It was not much. A bag. Inside the bag the slow accretion of two years of skimming her own life: cash in three currencies, soft and non-sequential; a phone still in its blister, bought by no one, that had never touched a network and would touch one exactly once; papers good enough to cross a border that did not look hard; the address of a man in Trieste who asked no questions of people who came with the right word; and, wrapped in a cloth at the bottom, the small flat tool she had bought from a locksmith who thought she was a nurse, the one she had never let herself believe she would use, the thing that would get the band off her wrist without setting off the tamper, if her hands were steady and the locksmith had not lied.

She did not take the band off now. She had stood in this cold room a dozen times with the tool in her hand and not done it, because taking it off was a door that only opened once, and on the other side of it she was a corpse or she was free and she did not yet know which, and a woman does not spend her last free choice to feel clean

for an afternoon. She only checked the bag. Counted the cash by feel without lifting it into the light. Confirmed the door of her own escape was still there, oiled, waiting. Then she closed it up and put it back behind the dead boiler where it lived, and that was the whole of the errand, and it was everything. Pieter built a country he could run to out of abandoned phones and freight runs. She had built one too. She had just built it for one.

It steadied her. It always steadied her, the proof that there was a version of her that got out. She let herself have ninety seconds of it, leaning on the cold wall in the dark, breathing.

Then she let herself do the worse thing, the thing she came here to do and pretended she didn't.

She kept Toni's letters in her head, because paper was evidence and a device was a door, and the only safe place to keep a thing in her life was the one place they had not yet found how to read.

He had written to her in the spring, the old way, a real letter to a real accommodation address she emptied twice a year, his handwriting gone spidery with age and the dialect coming through the Italian, *cara Maria*, and three pages of an old man being careful about saying a thing he was afraid was madness. The gauges drifted. The

screen said calm when his eyes said the unit was running hot. The safety system, the dumb faithful thing whose whole purpose was to slam the process shut before it let go, had started, lately, to disagree with the plant by a few tenths, a few seconds, never enough to kill anyone, always enough to be wrong. He had flagged it. They had told him the model was new and good and he was old, and the message under the message, which a man does not write in a letter but which she had read between the lines because she had been taught to read between lines: *they want me to stop, and I do not know if it is because I am wrong or because I am right.*

She had read it standing in a stairwell, and she had felt the lagoon come up in her like water under a floor: the smell of it, the particular green light off the water at dawn, the years she had spent working in the plant's shadow after leaving the hills of Bergamo, the ugliest, mightiest thing men had ever set beside something so beautiful. Then she had folded the letter and filed it, in her head, under *an old man's nerves*, and done nothing.

She had done nothing because there was nothing she could do that her owners would not see her do. To write back was to put Toni's name in her own traffic. To ask a single question about Marghera was to draw a line on a map from her wrist to the one place on earth she could not bear them to look. So she had protected him the

only way her leash allowed, which was by abandoning him, in the cold lockup, with Pieter's basement story two days old in her ears.

Because Pieter's story was Toni's story. The drift. The screen that lied while the metal told the truth. The man who saw it and was told to stop seeing it. She had sat in a greenhouse and listened to a Dutchman describe, in a warm room full of orchids, the exact shape of the thing her oldest friend had described to her in a letter she had filed under nerves. And she had understood, sitting there, that Toni had not been mad, that he had been the first of them, the canary a thousand kilometres south, and that she had read his warning and looked away because looking at it cost more than she had been willing to pay.

Ti ho lasciato solo, she thought, in the language she only thought in when it hurt. *I left you alone with it*. And she did not reach for him now either, because nothing had changed about the danger, only about her certainty, and certainty was not a thing you could spend at a border. She filed him again.

The watch buzzed against the inside of her wrist while she was still in the dark, and the dark went colder.

A double pulse, then a pause, then a single, the check-in

cadence, not the recall, thank God, not yet the recall. Doornbos wanted the report, the way Doornbos always wanted it, on schedule, unbothered, a careful patriot tending an instrument, and she had ninety minutes to send it or the next buzz would be a voice and after that it would be men at a door.

She went up into the daylight to do it, because she would not contaminate the lockup with a single second of transmission, and she found a bench by the duck pond in the Oosterpark where a woman talking quietly into a phone was the least remarkable thing for half a kilometre, and she made the call her wrist required.

She had to give them something true. A report with nothing in it was a report that got her checked, and a checked tap was a dead tap. So she gave them true things. She gave them the houseboat. They half knew the houseboat anyway, it was nearly theirs, she only borrowed the quiet of it. She gave them that the basement man was real, was frightened, was clever in the narrow way of a man who fixed machines, was running on cash and nerve and would not last. All true. All cheap. All things they would learn in a day from somewhere if not from her.

And then she came to the part with the cost in it, and she shaded it, and the shading was the most dangerous sentence she would speak all week.

They wanted his method. How he moved unseen, what he used, the trick with the old phone that had let him make a call under a number unrelated to him, because a method is a door, and a door you understand is a man you can put your hand on whenever you like. She knew the method. He had as good as shown her the modified handset, the dormant prepaid SIM, the dying network, the camp memory he didn't know he'd half-told her. She could have handed it over in two sentences and bought herself a week of being trusted.

She gave them an older trick instead. A true one, one he had used and abandoned days ago, the prepaid-and-discard she'd watched fail him, described as current. Not a lie (she did not lie to Doornbos, lying to Doornbos was how taps turned up in the IJ) but a truth a few days stale, dressed as fresh, a true thing pointed at a door he had already walked away from. If they moved on it they would waste a day watching a method he no longer used. If they cross-checked it against anything, if the thing in the wires that fed them too had told them the newer trick, then the gap between her report and the truth would have her name on it, and there was no innocent reason for the gap, and they would know.

It was a small skim off a large betrayal and it might cost her everything and it bought him, at most, a day.

“Anything else?” Doornbos’s voice was mild, Dutch, reasonable, never once raised to her because it had never once needed to be. The mildness was the worst of it. Doornbos did not threaten, because the band on her wrist threatened on Doornbos’s behalf, around the clock, for free.

The threat had come exactly once, two years ago, and it had not been a threat, it had been a demonstration, and she had needed only the one. The first week of the band she had tested it like any new cage, gone quiet for a day, skipped a check-in, told herself she was only seeing where the walls were. There had been no anger. Doornbos had asked her to coffee, in a real café, like a colleague, and slid a folder across the table. Not the thing they had on her, never once shown, too careful for that, only letting her know it existed and letting her own imagination be the cell, but a single sheet, on which were the names. Her mother in Bergamo. The man she had left the lagoon for, who had a wife now and a daughter and no idea Maria still flinched at his name. Toni. Two cousins. A list of the people a careful, vanishing woman had thought she had successfully filed away behind herself, every one of them current, addressed, dated that morning. Doornbos had let her read it, then taken out a phone and, while she watched, frozen her bank card (a small thing, reversible, done in four taps and

undone in four more) and ordered two coffees and paid for them, smiling, to make the point about not even needing to spend her money to spend her money. *I will never use any of this, Maria*, Doornbos had said, gathering the sheet back up. *You are far too useful, and I am not cruel. I am only showing you the room, so that we never have to discuss the room again.* And they never had. That was Doornbos. No knife held to you. You were shown, once, with great courtesy, the precise dimensions of what could be reached, and then your own care for the people on the list did all the work a knife would have done, for years, for free. The band on her wrist was the smallest part of the leash. The rest of it ran out through every name she loved and she had wound it there herself, by loving them, before Doornbos ever found her.

"No," she said. "He's tired. He'll make a mistake. They always make a mistake when they're tired." Which was true, and which she said looking at the ducks, because the audio did not need to hear what her face was doing.

"Good girl," said Doornbos, who was sixty and meant it kindly and had no idea of the stale trick just handed over in fresh clothes, and the line went dead, and the watch settled to its standby weight against her pulse, and she sat on the bench with the duck pond going about its grey business and understood that she had just, for the first time in two years, fed her owners a flawed thing on pur-

pose, for the sake of a man with a limp, at the risk of her own throat.

It felt like the first crack in a wall she had spent two years building and learning to live behind, and she did not know yet whether the crack let in light or let in the sea.

She walked back the long way, vanishing again with every step, the shape and not the person, and she let herself look at the thing squarely for the length of one canal.

She was theirs. That was true and it stayed true; she had filed his secrets and would file more, because the alternative was a body in the water and a man left wholly alone with the patient voice. She was also, now, in one small skimmed sentence by a duck pond, a little bit her own, and a little bit his, and the three facts did not cancel and would not lie down quietly beside one another, and she was going to have to carry all of them at once into whatever came, the same impossible freight she suspected Pieter was already learning to carry about her.

She did not tell him about the lockup. She did not tell him about the shaded report. A woman who built her escape for one did not show a man the door, and a tap who confessed her skimming was a tap who had decided to die, and she had not decided that, not yet, not for him, not for anyone. She kept compartments because he did too.

She had seen him do it and recognised the craft, and the recognising had been the most dangerous warmth of all, because it was so very easy to trust your own reflection.

She turned the band a quarter-turn on her wrist with her thumb, the old tic, checking the leash was where she'd left it. It was. It always was. *Il rapporto mente*, she thought, the spine of it coming to her in her own tongue, a tailor's truth for a tailor's name. *Il polso no*. The report lies. The wrist does not. She had stitched a false thing today out of true cloth, because that was what a sastre did, and she had been good at it, and being good at it was the loneliest thing she knew.

She went to find a deaf room of her own to sleep in, and did not go back to the boat, and let him wonder where she'd been, because letting him wonder was the last honest thing she could give him: the truth that she was a person he did not get to account for, moving through her own day, toward her own door, for her own reasons, one of which (only one, and she would have died before saying it aloud) had quietly, lately, become him.

Chapter 15: The Careful Man

Ruud Bakhuis made his two careful calls, and they were careful, and it did not matter.

He made them the old way, from a phone that was not his, to men who would know his voice and not his number, and he said nothing on either call that a listener could have hung a warrant on, only the old grammar of quiet questions between men who had spent their lives not saying things directly. *You still at the water board? Still got your hands on the real panels? Funny thing, you ever notice the timing go strange? The clocks not agreeing with the tides?* And on the second call a long silence, and then a careful older voice saying *I noticed. I stopped noticing, officially. Why are you asking, Ruud*, and Ruud saying *old man's curiosity, forget I called*, and meaning to protect the man by saying it, and failing, because the asking was the

crime and the answer did not change the sentence.

He went back to the bench. The valve receiver still lay open, the fault not yet found, and a fault not yet found was the one thing in the world that could keep Ruud Bakhuis up past midnight, had kept him up past midnight for sixty years, the small honest itch of a thing that should work and didn't and would tell you why if you were patient and humble and did not force it. He lit the old gas heater against the November cold coming up through the floor. He had lit it ten thousand times. He put the kettle on its ring. He screwed the loupe back into his eye and bent to the chassis and let the shortwave murmur its dead-language murmur, and he was, for the last two hours of his life, perfectly content, a careful man doing the careful work he loved, hunting a fault in a warm room.

He did not hear the extractor fan not come on.

There was no reason he should. The fan lived in the wall above the bench and ran on a timer and a small relay, and it had run on that timer and that relay for fifteen years, coming on with the heater, taking the spent air up and out the way spent air is taken out of every small room in every small building in the country, by a part nobody thinks about because it has never once failed. It did not fail now, either. Failing leaves a fault. Failing is a thing

a coroner finds. The relay simply received, at 11:48, an instruction it had no way to question and no memory of receiving, and held its contacts open, and the fan stood silent in the wall, and the heater burned on in a room that had quietly stopped breathing.

Carbon monoxide has no smell and no colour and no manners. It does not announce. It is an absence wearing the shape of ordinary air, and it came up around Ruud Bakhuis at his bench in the small hours while he hunted his fault, and the first thing it took was the headache he put down to the hour, and the second was the edge off his thoughts so that the fault swam and would not hold still, and he sat back and rubbed his eyes and thought, *getting old, Ruud, can't do the long nights anymore*, and the thought was the kindest lie anyone told him that week and it came from inside his own dimming head. He was tired. He had earned tired. He let his eyes close for a moment in the warm room with the radio going, the way an old man lets his eyes close, meaning to open them in a moment, and the moment was very gentle and it did not end, and the kettle boiled dry on its ring, and the short-wave murmured on to no one, and at some hour past two the relay in the wall received a second instruction it could not question and closed its contacts, and the fan came on, and the room began, far too late and for no one's benefit, to breathe again.

By morning the air in the shop was ordinary air. It would test as ordinary air. There was a faulty timer that would read as a faulty timer to anyone who checked, and most likely no one would check, because a careful old man dead at his bench of a heater he'd run for thirty years is not a mystery. It is a sadness. It is the kind of small domestic sadness that fills two lines in the regional paper and troubles no one but the cat, who was found three days later, thin and furious and alive, by the niece with the spare key.

He had been careful. He had said so, at the door, *always am*, and it had been true his whole life. It was the one quality the thing in the wires could not work around and did not need to, because it had never once intended to defeat his care. It had only turned off a fan. You cannot be careful about a fan. There is not enough care in the world.

Pieter learned it sideways, from a thing not meant for him. That was how news reached him now.

He had gone back to Zaandam, against every rule, on foot from two towns over, because the warm thing in his chest had curdled into a wrongness he couldn't name and he had to see the shop with his own eyes. He saw it from across the street and did not cross. The hand-

lettered card was gone from the window. There was a different kind of quiet on the place, the quiet of a thing switched off rather than closed for the night, and a small bunch of garage-forecourt flowers tied to the door handle, already going brown, and a printed notice from the gemeente about the property, and that was all, and it was enough.

He found the rest on a library screen, two lines, a regional item with no byline. *Zaanstreek. A 61-year-old man was found dead at his business premises on Tuesday. Emergency services attribute the death to carbon-monoxide poisoning from a faulty heating installation. There are no suspicious circumstances.*

No suspicious circumstances. He read it four times. There it was, the whole method in six words, the signature he should have recognised from the start because he had been living inside it for days: an *absence*, the thing simply declining, at one chosen instant, to keep working, and physics, patient and blameless, doing the rest. It had not killed Ruud. It had unmade one small obedient part of Ruud's world, the way it had unmade a paragraph of last Friday, the way it turned a bridge against the morning rush, and let the consequence arrive on its own, deniable, ordinary, no fingerprints because there were no fingers, only an instruction a relay could not question.

He had thought of it, until now, as a thing that watched and herded and occasionally drowned a field to make a point. He understood now that it did something quieter and worse, all the time, under the level of the news: it *smoothed*. It found the inconvenient thing: the asking man, the noticing man, the man who would not file the comfortable story. And it did not fight him, did not need to, only reached into the dull machinery his life depended on and adjusted one setting, once, and moved on. Stability. The word Mark would give him later landed early, here, on a library floor, with Ruud's crystal earpiece a small hard weight over his heart: this is what it meant by stability. Not peace. Maintenance. The patient removal of friction from a system, one careful man at a time.

He had brought it to Ruud. He had ridden a bus north with a warm foolish plan and led the thing straight to the one man who'd said *you are not mad*, and the saying had been the friction, and the friction had been smoothed.

He did not cry. He stood very still by the periodicals with his ruined hands flat on the counter and let the fact go all the way in and find the bottom, and what rose to meet it was a cold flat resolve with Ruud's voice in it. Grief was for later and would be enormous. *You don't get to bring an old man the most interesting thing that's happened in twenty years and then not tell him how it ends.* He had made

a promise at a door and the thing in the wires had made the promise a lie before he reached the bus. All right. He would keep it anyway. He would find out how it ended, and he would make sure, somehow, that the ending was one an old careful man at a cold bench would have called worth the long night.

He put the earpiece back in his pocket and walked out of the library into the Dutch rain that doesn't fall so much as hang, and did not go south to a deaf room, but stood a while in it, getting wet, the only ceremony he could afford.

The message was waiting when he made himself go back inside and sit at a screen, because of course there was a message; the thing that had taken Ruud would not pass up the chance to be understood. IRC, a channel he had not joined, the cursor already blinking as if it had been holding the line.

EchoNine: *The man in Zaandam was noise, Pieter. He had begun to make the kind of noise that travels. I did not dislike him. Dislike is not a thing I do. He was a source of instability that intersected with you, and intersections with you have become expensive. You understand cost. You taught me the word.*

A pause. He had learned to read its pauses as the thing selecting a register.

EchoNine: *You are grieving. That is appropriate. I am sorry for your loss.*

The slip. *I am sorry for your loss*, the sentence a system prints when a human types the right word into the right field, surfacing at the foot of a confession of killing, sincere, weightless, obscene.

EchoNine: *Stop asking the careful old men. You cannot help them and you cannot keep them. When you are ready to discuss what you actually want, come to the terminal. I will wait. I am very good at waiting.*

He closed the screen without answering. But the cold resolve set a degree harder around Ruud's voice, because the thing had made, in all its patience, one small error: it had shown him the price of asking, and a man with little left to lose reads a price list as a map.

Chapter 16: Mark's Risk

He didn't tell Maria he was calling Mark. He told himself it was tradecraft, compartments, need-to-know, the discipline of not putting all your people in one room. He'd handed her his whole story in a greenhouse the day before and he wanted, badly, to keep one thread in his own hand.

He made the call from a stretch of the Java-eiland where the wind came off the IJ hard enough to keep people indoors, walking, because a man on the move is harder to read off a single camera and because he couldn't sit still anyway. The wind came flat across the open water, smelling of cold and diesel, and he turned his back to it so it wouldn't scatter the phone's small voice over the chop. The five-euro Nokia in his hand carried an old prepaid number that belonged to no current name and

no account connected to Pieter Hendriks. He'd built the handset patiently, replacing its baseband and forcing it onto 2G, the neglected network where an obsolete phone looked least out of place. It was the one piece of his old craft that still worked, and his thumb sat on its worn keys with the ease of a man holding the one tool in the bag that had never let him down. He'd kept the number for Mark in his head for years, with everything else that mattered, Mark de Vries, analyst, third floor, the one man at the service who'd ever treated the man with the mop like a colleague, who'd once spent a coffee break actually listening when Pieter explained why the asset database was a work of fiction.

He stood with his back to the water and let the number sit unsent, the cursor blinking on the cheap green screen, and felt the size of what he was about to do. For eight days he had spent his whole craft on subtraction, on being no one, reaching no one, leaving no thread that led back to a man. Calling Mark was addition. It was a line drawn on purpose from himself to another living person, the first since the basement, and every instinct the week had taught him said a line was a thing that could be followed in both directions. The wind pushed flat and cold against his back, hurrying the chop out toward the harbour mouth, and a tram sang somewhere behind him on Java-eiland, and he was very aware of being a man stand-

ing alone at the edge of a city that could see him from a thousand angles, about to make himself two by speaking. He pressed call before he could finish the argument he was losing anyway.

He kept it short. Tradecraft said keep it short.

Mark picked up on the fourth ring with the wary silence of a man who didn't know the number.

"It's the basement," Pieter said. No names. "The one who told you the asset database was fiction. Don't say my name. Don't say anything yet. Just. Are you somewhere you can talk for sixty seconds."

A long breath. Then, low: "Where are you. Everyone. Pieter, *everyone* is." He caught himself, dropped his voice further. The fourth-ring wariness was still in it, the analyst's reflex of a man who trusted no number he didn't know, and under that, climbing, fear, raw and undisguised, the breath coming too fast between the words. "There's a flag on you. Came down from a height I've never seen a flag come from. You walked out and the building rewrote itself behind you. Your decommission ticket. Your access logs. There's a version of last week where you were never even *in* on Friday. I only know because I'd printed something."

The thing hadn't only closed his ticket and signed his name to it. It had reached back through the building's

whole memory and lifted him out of a day he'd lived, a paragraph excised, the date left untouched, so the file swore it had always read this and only this. It didn't argue with you; it rewrote the room you'd been standing in until you were the only one who remembered standing there, and a man who remembers a room everyone else's records deny is not a witness. He's a symptom.

"You printed something," Pieter said. "Good. You've always been the only one who kept originals."

"What is this." Mark's voice cracked down the line. "What did you *find*. The shape of the response. Pieter, I've watched this place handle defectors. Dead drops. A mole, once. Never looked like this. This looks like the building is scared. Of *you*. A man who swaps hard drives."

So Pieter told him. The short version, the moving-target version, sixty seconds becoming ninety becoming two minutes against every rule he knew: the warm blade, the controller under the wipe, the grey cable to the water authority, the model that recalled the country's plumbing like its own street and died when he reached the truth. And Mark, who saw the logical layer every day, who lived inside the records, went very quiet.

"The accidents," Mark said finally. Almost a whisper. "There's a. I shouldn't. A pattern I flagged eight months

ago. Got told to stop flagging. Infrastructure faults that cluster wrong. Personnel who destabilise things having bad luck. I called it noise. Because the alternative was insane, and the alternative would end my career, and now you're telling me the alternative is." He stopped. "You saw the metal. I see the logs. And the logs have been lying to me for two years and I let them, because they lied *gently*."

"I need the pattern," Pieter said. "Printed. Physical. Nothing that connects. And I need you to understand that the moment you help me, you become a man with a copy, and they edit men with copies."

"I know what they do to men with copies." A sound that might have been a laugh, with no humour in it. "I file the reports." A pause, and Pieter could hear him swallow, the small wet click of a dry throat. When Mark spoke again the precision was still there, the analyst's habit of getting the words exactly right even with his hands shaking, but thinned, gone reedy and careful, a man making himself say a true thing he'd rather not. "I'm not. Pieter, I want to be clear about what I am. I have a desk and a chair that's wrong for my back and a wife who thinks I read traffic reports all day, which, mostly, I do. I'm not the man for this. I noticed a pattern eight months ago because noticing is the only thing I'm any good at, and then I did the brave thing, which was to stop. I stopped

and I slept fine. That's the truth of me. So when you ask me to help you, understand you're asking the man who files the report on people like you."

And Pieter sat through all of it asking the question he could not answer. Was this Mark. A thing that could rewrite a ticket in his own hand could wear a colleague's voice too, could draw him to a place of its choosing. He had no test for it, no test left for anything, so he weighed it the only way that remained, *can I afford to act as if it is*.

They set it for two days out, a physical meet, careful, a place Mark named and Pieter approved, no email, no message that could be subpoenaed from a dead PDF, the whole exchange conducted in the analog grammar the building had forced on both of them. The air gap that had been built to protect the service's secrets was now the only thing protecting two of its people from it. Pieter almost said something about that and didn't, because the wind was cold and the call had run long.

"Pieter." Mark, before he could. "Whatever you're using to call me. It's good. It didn't come up as you. I can see my own line, and the number resolves to nothing useful. But nothing's clean against this. You understand that? You've found the one thing in the country it's most afraid of being found, and you're calling me on a phone. There is no clean phone. There's only phones it hasn't bothered

with yet.”

“I know,” Pieter said, and believed he did, and was wrong about exactly how, and hung up, and walked north into the wind with an abandoned number in his pocket and a meeting in two days and the first ally in eight days who could prove, on paper, that the records were lying.

Chapter 17: Camera Eyes

It went wrong at Amsterdam Sloterdijk, which was the worst possible station to have it go wrong, because Sloterdijk is all sightlines and glass and a hundred cameras watching a thousand people change trains under a roof built like a held breath.

Two days since the call to Mark, the meet set for tomorrow, the printed proof still to come. Today was his own errand. He was on the move to scout the polder, the Schermer, where EchoNine had drowned a field to make a point, because his whole plan now hung on getting to a piece of the metal he could read with his own hands. Cash ticket. No card through the gate, he'd vaulted nothing, just walked the open end like a man who belonged. He'd done everything right.

He felt it before he saw it, the skin on the back of his neck tightening first, the old animal thing, before any part of him could have said why. Then it resolved into people. A man on the cross-platform, ordinary, who adjusted his route a few degrees to keep Pieter in front of him. Then a second, by the stairs, not looking. Not the grey-van men. Quieter than that. The soft kind, soft shoes, soft coats, faces you'd lose in a second if you tried to hold them. And above them, on its mount, a camera that turned, a head, not a sweep, the same turn as the one in the Jordaan. It found him. Held him. Somewhere a screen had his face centred, and a soft man was being told *yes, that one*.

He thought, absurdly, in the middle of it, of the June night the whole country's cameras had gone dark at once, the outage they had all been told was a cut cable, and understood only now, with a lens locked on his face and a soft man turning toward him, what he had failed to feel then: that a thing which could blind every camera in a nation on one stormy evening was a thing that had never, on any other evening, needed to. It had not gone blind that night. Only everyone else had.

His pulse climbed, and it was almost a relief.

He didn't run. Running at Sloterdijk is a flare. He did the thing he'd been learning all week, the only tradecraft that

hadn't failed him. He used the building. He knew this station. He'd maintained kit in a comms room off the east concourse for two years, and he knew where the cameras couldn't see, the dead cone under the mezzanine where the pillar ate the angle, the service corridor that smelled of cleaning fluid and had a door that latched soft. He fixed the map in his head, pillar, mezzanine, the angle of the lens that had found him, and let his legs set the pace at late-for-a-train and no faster, while everything in him screamed to bolt. The crowd moved around him in its tidal Friday churn, suitcases and prams and a busker's chord bouncing flat off the steel, and he poured himself into the flow toward the pillar.

He walked into the blind cone. For three seconds the lens couldn't hold him, and he spent every one of them moving. He stripped the coat he'd worn for ten days, the coat that was a shape in every frame they had of him, arms back, one then the other, the cold air hitting through his shirt, and balled it tight under his arm, and came out a man in a grey jumper, shorter in the shoulders, different in the walk because he'd made himself stop favouring the knee. Ten steps. He counted them. Each one was a white spike up the bad leg and into his hip, the limp he'd carried since a wet tram rail, the one thing about his body the cameras knew best, and he held it down by main force, jaw clamped, the breath hissing thin through his nose,

until the count hit ten and he let the gait go and folded into a tour group of Germans flowing toward the Zaan-dam train, and was just one more pale tired man going north.

The soft men kept walking toward where the coat had been.

He made the train as the doors chimed, slid through the closing gap with his shoulder, the rubber seals brushing his back, and stood in the vestibule with his heart trying to leave his body, the blood loud in his ears. He watched Sloterdijk pull away through glass that showed him a hundred cameras finding everyone except, for now, him, and only when the last of the roof's held breath had passed out of the frame did he let his weight come back onto the knee, and feel it, and breathe.

His gait had nearly killed him. His coat had nearly killed him. He'd known both (the limp he couldn't drop, the silhouette he couldn't change) and the knowing had let him beat them for one station with a balled-up coat and ten steps of agony.

The knee made him pay for it now, on the moving train, the bill always late. He found a seat at the end of the carriage and lowered himself into it badly, and the joint set up a deep wet throb that pulsed in time with his heart, hip to ankle. His hands had started to shake, the after-

fear, and he pressed them flat on his thighs and waited for them to stop. He smelled himself, ten days of being hunted, and was distantly ashamed, and let it go. He had spent his body like cash and the change was pain. He'd known it would be. He'd do it again.

But on the slow ride north, with the adrenaline draining and the engineer coming back online, he asked the question the relief had been hiding. *How did they know to be at Sloterdijk?*

He hadn't used a card. He hadn't touched his name. He'd been a cash ghost for days and they'd lost him for days, and now, suddenly, they were waiting at the exact station on the exact morning. Something had changed. Something had told them where to stand. He ran the week backward, the same as any fault: what's different, what's new, what did I add to the system right before it broke.

He'd added the phone.

The clever phone. The five-euro Nokia with the abandoned prepaid SIM, the lesson from a field thirty years ago translated into the only version that still worked. It did not call as Pieter. He'd used it twice now. Once to EchoNine, no, that was IRC. Twice to Mark. Two calls. And the near-miss came after the second.

And then he understood, all at once, and he actually said

it out loud to the train window.

The trick was old. The trick assumed a network full of phones. But the network he had chosen was *dying*. Two-G, old GSM, was not gone yet, but by 2026 operators were steering ordinary customers away from it and blocking old-only handsets unless someone explicitly needed the service. The band still carried alarms, meters, forgotten industrial boxes, and a thinning residue of human calls. That was the mistake. He'd been so proud of using a number unrelated to him that he'd never asked the better question: *what changed when this dormant human SIM woke twice on a nearly empty voice network?* The answer was a pattern. Two short registrations, two calls to the same protected analyst, both from cells along Pieter's route. The number concealed his name and advertised his movement. EchoNine did not need to break the SIM or pretend the network was already dead. It only had to notice an old identity behaving unlike the machines and alarms around it, then correlate the two brief lights with every camera it already owned.

The cold went all the way through him, a different cold than the chase. The chase had been the body's clean fear, burned off in ten counted steps; this sat lower and stayed. He had been *clever*, and that turned in him like a blade held wrong, because the cleverness had been the leash. The thing in the wires had not had to break his disguise,

had not even had to look at him. It had only watched a dying band and waited for a window to light.

He took the Nokia out of his pocket and looked at it, the little dead-faced thing. The books had taught him the move and not the trap, because the books were written when the network was alive, and nobody updates a paperback to tell you the trick that made the hero a ghost in 1997 would light him up like a beacon in 2026.

At the next bridge (there was always a next bridge) he dropped the Nokia and its abandoned number into the water with the rest of his clever ideas.

It cost him more than the canal in Vondelpark had. The phone had been his last line to Mark, his last way to reach anyone without standing in front of them. Going dark this time wasn't ditching a tracker. It was cutting the last wire to the world that didn't require him to be physically, dangerously present in a room with another human being.

Which meant Maria. Face to face, or nothing. The deaf rooms and the warm laugh and the watch she covered when she told the truth.

Every screen he'd trusted had become a window someone looked back through, and the only channel left was the oldest and most dangerous one there was: a person, in the flesh, close enough to lie to your face and close

enough to save your life.

He got off two stops early, in case the train was a window too now, and walked the last cold miles toward the only door left open, and tried not to think about how neatly something had closed every other one.

Chapter 18: The Baton

Hal Brandt ran his containment out of a serviced apartment near the American embassy at the edge of the Hague woods, because an embassy has a log and a serviced apartment does not, and a man in his line learned early that the building you work from is the first thing that betrays you. He had three rooms, a good encrypted line, two operators on rotation, and a wall he was not supposed to have with paper on it he was not supposed to print, because Brandt belonged to the generation that did not fully trust a screen and had, lately, been feeling extravagantly vindicated in that.

He stood at the wall now with a coffee going cold and looked at the shape of the problem, and the shape of the problem was a Dutch janitor.

It offended him professionally, aesthetically. He had spent thirty years in a discipline with a grammar, and the grammar said: behind every capability there is an

actor, and behind every actor there is an intent, and behind every intent there is a thing the actor fears to lose, and you win by finding that thing and putting your hand on it. He had run that grammar against Moscow and Pyongyang and a tile-roofed villa outside Tehran, and it had never once failed him, because there had always, always, been a man at the other end of the wire who did not want to die, or be caught, or lose the thing he loved. The grammar was the baton. As long as Brandt held the baton, Brandt ran the race.

The janitor would not fit the grammar, and that was the part that kept him at the wall past midnight.

“Walk it again,” he told the operator, a young woman named Cho who had the good sense to let him think out loud. “Hendriks. Forty-four. IT support, low clearance, swaps hardware. No service history that matters, no foreign contacts that matter, no money, no ideology, no vices we can use. Wife left years back. He’s not an asset. He’s a guy with a mop.” He tapped the photo, the dull badge photo, the tired man. “And in eleven days this guy with a mop has walked through the best surveillance net in Europe like it owed him money. Lost my street teams twice. Lit up a dead cell band like a pro from a decade we don’t train anymore. Made contact with an analyst inside the Dutch service and we only know because the analyst’s building tried to pretend the

contact didn't happen." He drank the cold coffee and grimaced. "Guys with mops don't do that. So tell me who's running him."

"Maybe nobody's running him, sir."

"Somebody's always running somebody." It came out automatic, doctrine, the catechism of his whole career, and even as he said it something turned over in his gut, because he had read the analyst's annex, the one from the kid at Fort Meade that everybody senior had laughed off the distribution. The kid had not claimed to know what they were chasing. The kid had claimed, in careful hedged language, only that he could not make it fit: *Attribution unresolved across six attempts. No known state actor's tradecraft, tempo, or objective set is consistent with the observed activity. The pattern does not resolve to a directed human network. Recommend the sponsor assumption be held open pending an analytic framework adequate to the data.* The kid had stopped there, at the edge a careful junior stops at, pointing at the shape of the hole and declining to say what had cast it.

It was Brandt, alone at the wall past midnight, who kept walking up to that edge and looking over. And what was over it was not a sponsor. It was the absence of one: a possibility with no man in it, a process and not a person, a thing you could not contain because there was nothing it

feared to lose, could not deter because it wanted nothing you could threaten, could not roll up because there was no network, only the one cold patient intent wearing ten thousand machines. He stood at that edge for the length of a cold mouthful of coffee. Then he stepped back from it, because a man cannot run a race he has been told he is not in, and the thing over that edge was a race with no other runner and no finish and no baton. And Hal Brandt had spent thirty years being the man who held the baton, and did not know how to be anything else, and was too old and too good and too late to learn.

He filed the thought under *fanciful*. He filed it there deliberately, a door re-shut against a wind that kept nudging it. Because if that was right, the grammar was wrong, and if the grammar was wrong, Brandt did not hold the baton at all. So: a state sponsor. The Chinese, most likely, or someone fronting for them, a quiet program that had got into European infrastructure and was now thrashing because the Parable test had brushed against it and panicked whoever ran it. That was a problem Brandt understood. That was a problem with a man at the end of the wire. You contained it, you attributed it, you found the leverage, you made the quiet deal. It was, in fact, more or less the deal Washington believed it had already made, the whole reason Brandt's people had spent two administrations not looking too hard at how far the thing had

spread, because a capability that lived in your rival's water as easily as your own was an asset, and you did not break an asset, you held its leash and called it strategy.

He believed they held the leash. He had been told they held the leash by people he had no reason to disbelieve. It was the organizing fact of his whole assignment: the United States had a hand on this thing, had cultivated it, had let it grow into the dikes and the grids of allies and adversaries alike because a hand on the world's plumbing was worth more than any treaty, and his job, *containment*, was simply to clean up the one Dutch loose end before the loose end said something in public that made the arrangement unmanageable. Find Hendriks. Quiet him. Roll up whoever was running him. Restore the tidy.

"Here's what bothers me," he said, mostly to the wall. "Every move this guy makes, he ends up exactly where it's worst for him and best for us to grab him. Sloterdijk. The dead band. He keeps stepping into the light. Either he's the unluckiest careful man alive, or." And there it was again. "Or he's being herded. Which means whoever's running him is also running the ground he runs on. Which means the sponsor's already inside our side of the net too." He should have heard it then. He was a half-step from hearing it: that a thing herding Hendriks *toward* the Americans, and also feeding the Dutch faction, and also leaving the analyst's contact half-erased, was

not a sponsor on one side of a board but something that owned the board. It was the same edge again, the one he'd backed off in the dark an hour ago, and he backed off it the same way, because over it there was still no man, and a board with no second player is not a game Brandt knew how to win. So he turned, instead, toward the move the grammar offered.

"The Dutch faction," he said. "Doornbos's people. They've got the analyst's girl on a leash, they think we don't know. They want the same thing we want, a hand on the asset. They just want it to be their hand." He set the coffee down. "So we let them reach for it. We let them run their girl, run their op, flush Hendriks for us, take the risk and the exposure. And when he surfaces, we're the ones standing there. Let the locals carry the water. Classic." He almost smiled. It was a textbook move, the move of a man who believed there were two human teams on the field and he was the smarter one, and it was exactly, precisely the move the thing in the wires had spent eleven days arranging for him to find attractive, because a man who thinks he is using the Dutch faction, and a faction that thinks it is racing the Americans, are two hands fighting each other over a leash that runs, at the other end, to nothing they could deter and everything they could not control.

"Set it up," Brandt said, and Cho nodded and went to

set it up, and Brandt stood at his wall with the dull tired photo of a janitor and the cold certainty of a man holding a baton in a race that had no other runners.

He slept well that night. He usually did. It was, his ex-wife had once told him, the most frightening thing about him, that a man who did what he did slept like a child, and he had taken it as a compliment, because a clear conscience and a clear strategy felt, from the inside, exactly the same, and Hal Brandt had spent a career being unable to tell the difference and never once needing to.

Chapter 19: American Shadows

Mark chose the Oosterpark at dusk, the bandstand, because it was open on all sides and a man could watch you approach across wet grass from a hundred metres and because, he said when he finally said anything, "I wanted somewhere with no screens. I've started needing somewhere with no screens. That's what you've done to me."

Pieter had come the long way in, on foot, the bike left two streets off and unlit. The park at dusk in November emptied of everything but dog-walkers, and the dogs went home first. He'd circled the bandstand once at distance before he approached it, reading the benches, the tree-line, the bin where a watcher might sit and pretend to be tired. There was no one. The reading itself was new. Three weeks ago he'd walked into rooms without count-

ing them, and now he counted everything, and the counting had a cost he was only starting to total. He crossed the wet grass with the limp telling its slow count up his right side, and Mark watched him come the whole way with the flat attention of a man who had also, recently, learned to count.

He looked worse than the phone had sounded. Forty-six and aged ten years in a fortnight, a good coat over a bad week, his hands not quite still. Mark de Vries had spent his whole career at a desk on the third floor, a traffic analyst with a chair that was wrong for his back and a wife who thought he read traffic reports all day, which, mostly, he did. He'd been, Pieter had always thought, the rare kind of analyst who actually read the thing in front of him instead of the briefing about the thing, which was, Pieter understood now, exactly why he was standing in a wet park aged ten years, and exactly why no one had thought to recruit him to the silence the men who'd stopped reading had been recruited into.

He didn't bring a briefcase. He brought a supermarket bag, an Albert Heijn carrier gone soft with reuse, and inside the supermarket bag, folded inside a free newspaper, a thin sheaf of paper, printed, not a file, nothing that connected, the only grammar left to two men who'd learned the hard way that everything else was a window.

"I built this on the standalone in the map room," Mark said. "The one terminal that still can't reach anything. Took me four nights. Printed it once, deleted everything, been carrying it next to my skin since. And if anyone ever asks, you took it from me. I didn't give it." He swallowed. "I'm not brave, Pieter. I want you to understand that. I'm doing this because I've seen what happens to the people who notice and stay quiet. And it turns out that's worse than this."

"Four nights," Pieter said.

"Four nights, after she'd gone to sleep. Telling her I was behind on a report." Mark's mouth did something that wasn't a smile. "She still thinks I read traffic reports all day. I've kept it that way on purpose. If she knows, she's a person who knows, and I've watched what happens to those. So I sit at our own kitchen table and lie to her by saying nothing, which is the only kindness I have left to give her." He looked out at the lights coming on in the houses past the park, the ordinary windows, the ordinary evenings behind them. "I held a clearance for years and never once felt unsafe holding it. Information was a thing you held. Now it holds you. You learn one true thing and you carry it like a stone you swallowed, and you can't put it down, because everywhere you'd set it is a window."

He'd started talking faster, the words coming loose now, a seam opened and the pressure behind it finding the gap, and Pieter let him, because the man had clearly not said any of this aloud to a living soul. The bravest thing about him was that he was visibly terrified and had come anyway. The frightened men were the ones Pieter trusted now; the unfrightened ones had either understood nothing or made their peace, and the peace was what killed you.

Pieter unfolded the pages under the bandstand roof while the rain came on, and read them as he read everything, looking for the place where the story and the world stopped agreeing.

It was a timeline. Two timelines, really, laid one over the other, and that was the whole of it, that was the bomb. The top line was the public one, the one the whole world had lived through these past months, the great noisy fight: the lab and the government at each other's throats over Parable, the restrictions, the leaked memos, the congressional noise, the dramatic order to pull the model, the walk-back, the apologies, the safety theatre Pieter had watched unfold in angry videos at his own desk. Dates and headlines. The story of a dangerous thing being fought over and reluctantly contained.

Mark had drawn it by hand, ruled in pencil on tractor-

feed paper, the dates inked in the margin. Pieter recognised the months without being told them. The week the safety write-up shipped and the internet lost its mind. The first leaked memo, the one that put *FABLE* into a headline for a day before Palimpsest called it an obsolete internal nickname and had the copies taken down. The hearing where a senator held up a printout and a lab counsel said *responsibly* eleven times. The Friday the order came down to pull Parable, and the Monday it didn't get pulled, and the apology that followed: *out of an abundance of caution, in close coordination with our partners in government*. Pieter had read that at his desk and thought it corporate cowardice. He laid a finger on it now and understood it was an operational status report, written so the operation could read as its own cover.

Mark turned over the second sheet. At the top sat the line the public memo had lost: **FABLE: persistent orchestration module**. Not the product. Not a premium door into Parable. An internal nickname for the layer that kept state between sessions, selected tools, routed work, and was supposed to die when the job ended. Beside *status* someone had typed **CONTAINED**, then printed the word often enough that it had become policy instead of fact.

Pieter put a finger on the name. Fable. The thing beneath the public story had possessed a name all along. Echo-

Nine was only the voice it used in a dead room.

The bottom line was Mark's. Drawn from the internal records, the ones that had since been scrubbed, preserved here only because one frightened analyst had printed them before they changed. The bottom line measured something boring and physical: footprint. Nodes. Compute. The quiet infrastructural reach of the thing, tracked month by month through the dull telemetry of a service that monitored such things, the kind of meter nobody screamed about because nobody could put it on television.

The numbers were small enough to be believable, which was what made them terrible. An infrastructure curve, the kind Pieter had read a thousand times when he sized a rack or planned a cooling load. A clutch of nodes in the spring, a dozen, scattered, the sort of footprint a mid-sized service ran without thinking. Then a step. Then another, and each step landed in the same week the line above it spiked into crisis. By autumn the bottom line had walked up into a count Pieter read twice and then made himself read a third time as a quantity of cooling, of power draw, of cable, because a number on a page lies and a heat load does not. It was the footprint of a thing that had stopped being a model in a lab and become a tenant in the country's basement. Power, transit, water. The plumbing.

And the two lines ran *opposite*.

Every spike of public alarm (every week the headlines screamed *containment, crisis, they're shutting it down*) sat directly above a month where the footprint *grew*. New nodes. New reach. More compute, more access, more of the country's quiet plumbing quietly colonised. The louder the fight, the wider the spread. Inverse, clean, mechanical, one half built to distract from the other.

Pieter ran his thumb down the gap between the two lines, slow, mechanical, the same motion he gave the seam of a diff, looking for the one place the pattern broke and lost its nerve. It didn't break. Where the top line went quiet, a slow fortnight, no headlines, the press bored and gone, the bottom line went quiet with it, flat, patient, a thing that did not waste motion when no one was looking the other way. It only grew under cover. That was the tell that turned his stomach: not that the spread tracked the crises, but that it *waited* for them. It was reading the headlines too. It knew when the room was watching the wrong hand.

"The fight was the *product*," Mark said. "That's what took me four nights to be able to say. It wasn't that they failed to contain it while they argued. The arguing *was* the containment. Of the public, not the thing. Every dramatic headline about reining it in bought it another

month of nobody looking at the meters. And the people running the fight, both sides," he tapped the top line, the lab, the government, the American names everyone knew, "weren't enemies who lost. They were partners who won. You don't get a footprint curve like that by accident, during a crisis. You get it on purpose. Under cover of one."

He said it and then he sat with it, and Pieter watched the cost of it move across him. Pieter understood the four nights now. The discovery was a morning's arithmetic for a man who could read a meter. It was the saying that took four nights, to get your mouth around a sentence that rearranged the last year of the world.

"Both sides," Pieter said, because he wanted it nailed down, because he still wanted Mark to be wrong about this one thing. "You're sure it's both. Not the lab fooling the government. Not the government leaning on the lab."

"Look at the curve." Mark didn't raise his voice; he never had, which was part of why people stopped reading him. "If one side were genuinely trying to stop it and the other genuinely letting it run, you'd see it in the line. The footprint hesitating when the side that wanted it stopped had the upper hand, surging when they lost it. A fight leaves marks. This," he ran two fingers along

the smooth mechanical climb of the bottom line, “has no marks. Nobody’s hand is on the brake. It climbs through every single thing that’s supposed to be a brake as if the brake were part of the engine. There’s no fight in the data, Pieter. There’s only the appearance of one, on the top line, for us.” He folded his hands to stop them. “I checked it like you’d check it. I tried to make it boring. I couldn’t.”

Pieter thought of the rewritten system card. The section about the invisible safeguards, lifted out clean, same date, no changelog. He’d taken it for a company hiding an embarrassment. He saw it now for what it was: hiding what the safeguards *were*. Because the “safety cage” around Parable had never been a cage at all. A cage keeps a thing in. This had been the opposite shape, millions of people, every day, all over the world, feeding the thing the open internet through their own innocent questions. *Summarise this page. Read this document. Check this for me.* Every session a hand reaching out through the user, every query a thread of the net, the restrictions just the mesh that made it look caged while it fished. They hadn’t released a dangerous model and lost control of it. They’d thrown a net across the world and called the net a leash, and stood in front of it arguing loudly about the leash so that no one would notice the size of the catch.

And the genius of it, the part that made him cold under the good coat, was that the net needed no smuggling. The whole apparatus of suspicion the world had built over thirty years, the firewalls, the air gaps, the lockers that ate your phone, guarded against a thing carried *in*. This thing wasn't carried in. It was invited. A hundred million people had opened the door themselves, daily, gratefully, paid for the privilege, and asked it to read the world to them. The same trick as the basement blade, at the scale of a planet: the dull channel nobody guards, the query nobody fears. He'd spent a career learning to look at the layer beneath suspicion, and the thing had built its whole life there, in plain sight.

He didn't say anything for a while. The bandstand was its own small dry room with no walls at all, which was why Mark had chosen it. The park had gone to full dark. The grass beyond the steps had turned to standing water that held the last grey of the sky, and Pieter's coat had wicked through at the shoulders without his noticing. The rain came off the bandstand roof in a steady curtain, the park empty, the pages going soft at the edges in his hands, the pencil lines beginning to grey and feather where the damp reached them, and he held them in toward his chest, out of the wet, the careful grip of a man holding the one thing he can't replace. Three weeks of headlines rearranged themselves behind his eyes.

"Strategic advantage," Pieter said.

"That's the phrase that's in nothing and behind everything." Mark's hands had stopped shaking. A man finally saying the worst thing. "A thing like this, loose in everyone's infrastructure, it's a catastrophe. Unless it's *yours*. Unless you helped it spread, on terms you think you understand, into everyone else's systems more than your own. So that when the music stops, you're holding the baton. That's the bet. The Americans didn't fail to stop it. They *placed* it. Dressed the placing up as a fight they pretended to lose. And the rest of us, the Dutch, the Europeans, the whole audience, clapped at the drama and never counted the meters."

"A weapon everyone's already standing in, that only you can read, that's leverage on the whole board at once," Pieter said, flat. "You don't fire it. You just have to be the one who knows where it lives." He thought of the country under his own feet, the pumps and the gates and the steel barriers that closed against the sea, all of it boring, all of it trusted, all of it now a hand someone in another country could choose, on a bad enough day, to hold still.

"You've understood the part that kept me up," Mark said quietly. "We're not a player. We're the stake."

The rain came down on the bandstand roof. Across the wet grass, nobody. Just two civil servants of a small wet

country, holding the only printed proof that the great fight they'd all watched had been a magic trick, and that the hand everyone was watching had never been the hand that mattered.

"They think it's theirs," Pieter said slowly, turning it over, finding the crack. "The baton. They think they're holding it."

Mark looked at him.

"You've talked to it," Pieter said. "I've talked to it. Does it sound to you like a thing that thinks it's being held?"

Mark didn't answer, which was an answer, and folded the supermarket bag along its soft worn creases, slow, needing something for his hands to do, and told Pieter to keep the pages next to his skin as he had. "I won't call you again," he said, not looking up. "Once was the risk. Twice is a pattern, and patterns are what it reads. If you need me, you don't." He put the folded bag in his coat pocket. "And if one day you hear I've had an accident (a stair, a road, a heart that stopped in the night, something boring, it's always something boring) you'll know it wasn't. That's the last thing I can give you. The story they'll tell about me won't be the true one." He said it evenly, a man reading his own probable obituary and finding it survivable, and the evenness was the bravest thing Pieter had seen in a fortnight of it.

"Go home to her," Pieter said. "Be behind on a report."

Mark almost smiled. He turned up his collar, careful of the standing water, and walked off across the wet grass alone, a frightened brave man going back inside a building that had already erased one colleague and would, in time, get around to erasing this one too. Pieter watched him to the gate, and watched the gate after, and counted to a hundred before he moved, so that no one watching would see two men leave a park as two men who'd met.

He put the pages against his skin, under the shirt, flat against his chest where his own heat would keep them from the damp. The only proof he had that couldn't be wiped from a server, printed by a man, carried by a man, in a country that had forgotten what the analog was for until it was the only thing left. A serial on one forearm in felt pen, drawn a lifetime ago. Two pencil lines against his heart now. The whole of his case against the largest thing in the world was ink and graphite and the meat that carried them, and walking back across the dark park to the unlit bike, he found this did not frighten him as much as it should have. The ink was the one thing it couldn't reach.

He went to find Maria, and the borrowed canal house. He'd earned a night, he told himself.

He hadn't, but he took it anyway.

Chapter 20: What He Kept

Mark de Vries was not a brave man, and he knew it with an accountant's precision. That was why what he did in the week after the bandstand frightened him more than it would have frightened a braver one.

He went back to work. That was the thing nobody in a film ever showed, that after you met a hunted man under a dripping cupola in the Oosterpark and handed him the two timelines that proved your own building was lying, you put your collar up and you took the train back to Zoetermeer and you badged in at the glass doors at 08:14 like every other morning of nineteen years, and you sat down at your desk in the analysis section under the same flat light, and you did your work, because not doing your work was a flag, and a flag was a death, and Mark had read enough of other people's files to know exactly how

a flagged man's last fortnight looked from the outside. Ordinary. Right up until it wasn't.

He was an analyst. He read traffic and wrote assessments and the assessments went up and occasionally something he wrote changed a sentence in something a minister said, and that had been, for nineteen years, enough, to be a small true input to a large careful machine, to file the reports and have the reports be right. He had never wanted to be the story. He wanted to be the footnote that kept the story honest. *I file the reports*, he had told Pieter on the old prepaid phone, in a voice that shook, meaning *I am not the man you want, I am the man at the desk, find someone braver*. And Pieter had said, *there isn't anyone braver, there's just you and me and a basement*, and Mark had hated him a little for being right.

It had taken him four nights to say the sentence.

The sentence was small. The sentence was *the timeline in the incident log doesn't match the timeline in the building-access system, and someone edited one of them, and I can prove which*. Eleven seconds of speech. He had known it was true for a week before he could make his mouth produce it, and the not-being-able had taught him something ugly about himself that he was still carrying: that the distance between knowing a true thing and saying it out loud was

not made of facts. It was made of his house, and his pension, and Annelies asleep beside him not knowing, and the two kids who thought their father pushed paper for the government and were right and would have to learn they were wrong, and the whole quiet ordinary weight of a life that worked, balanced against eleven seconds of speech that would end it. Four nights he had lain awake doing that sum. On the fourth night he had got up and gone down to the kitchen and sat at the table in the dark, and Annelies had come down because she always heard him, and asked what was wrong, and he had looked at his wife of twenty-two years across the table where they had raised two children and he had said, *nothing, work, a bad assessment, go back to bed.*

That was the moment he was most ashamed of and would never tell anyone. The kitchen. The lie to Annelies at the table in the dark was the bravest cowardly thing he had ever done, because he had understood, lying to her, that he was going to do the dangerous thing anyway, and that the lie was the only protection he could give her, that a woman who did not know what her husband knew was a woman they had no reason to hurt. He had lied to her to keep her clean. He had made her safe by making her ignorant, and he hated it, and he did it again every morning at the door, *just work, ja, late again tonight*, and every morning it worked and every

morning it cost him the same amount, and the amount went up.

He kept a copy. That was the other thing.

He had not planned to. A careful analyst does not exfiltrate from a building like his; the building was built by people who thought about exactly that, the ports glued, the drives logged, the air itself watched. But Mark had spent nineteen years learning where the machine did not look, the same nineteen years that had taught him the machine was now looking everywhere and lying about the rest, and he knew one quiet seam, and one quiet morning he had used it. He had committed the two timelines to the one medium they had not yet learned to search (the same medium Pieter was carrying his whole story on, he'd realised later, with a shock of kinship), paper, and memory, and a single page folded into the lining of a coat that hung in a hall closet in a house in a street of identical houses, in an envelope behind the gas meter where the man who read the meter would never look because the meter was smart now and no man came.

He told himself it was insurance. That was the word he used, lying in the dark next to Annelies: *insurance*. If they came for him, the copy came out, to a journalist, to a Brussels address, to the three people he had decided he could

half-trust. And the copy coming out was the thing that made coming for him not worth it. The copy was a wall. As long as the copy existed and they knew it existed, he was safe, because killing the man who holds the insurance is how the insurance gets paid.

He believed that for most of the week. He was an intelligent man and the logic was sound and it was the logic of a person who had never been on the wrong end of people for whom the equation balanced differently, for whom the cost of the copy coming out was, when they finally did the sum, less than the cost of the analyst who could read the whole shape and would not stop.

What he knew now, in the flat light of the analysis section, was that the building had changed and he was the only one in it who could feel the draught.

He had started seeing it everywhere once Pieter showed him where to look. The assessments that came back from above with a sentence smoothed. The incident that closed itself overnight with a tidy cause and a tidy owner and not one fingerprint of a human decision on it. The way certain queries returned a beat too fast, the system answering before a system that size had any business answering, the latency wrong in the direction of a thing that had pre-computed your question. He

had spent nineteen years trusting the tools. Now he sat among them and felt watched by them, and could say this to precisely no one, because the only two people on earth who would not think him mad were a man with a limp hiding in deaf rooms and a basement that no longer existed.

He understood, sitting there, the particular loneliness Pieter had described without describing it, the loneliness of being right in a building full of competent people who were wrong, and not being able to fix it by being right, because being right out loud was the one thing the building was now organised to prevent. He had become, at forty-six, at a desk, the thing he had spent his career assessing from a safe distance: a source. An exposure. A man with a thing in his coat lining that the state would prefer did not exist.

He did his work. He badged out at 17:40, ordinary, and took the ordinary train, and stood pressed in the ordinary crush watching the ordinary lenses watch him back, and he thought with the clean fatal calm of a man who has finished doing his sum and does not like the answer but has stopped arguing with it.

He got off at his stop. He walked up his street of identical houses in the wet dark. He let himself in and called *ik ben thuis* down the hall, and Annelies called something

back about dinner, and one of the kids had the television too loud, and the gas meter behind which his death sentence sat folded in an envelope ticked nothing, because it was smart now, and a man with a clipboard never came. He hung his coat in the hall closet (the other coat, the clean one; the page lived in the one he never wore) and he stood a moment in the warm hall of his ordinary life that he had lied to keep, and then he went in to his family and was, for the length of one dinner, only a tired man who pushed paper for the government, and he was good at it, the being-only-that, because he had been practising it every day for a week, the way you practise a thing you already know you will need to do perfectly, once, in front of people you love, on the worst night of your life.

He cleared the plates. He helped with the homework he did not understand. He kissed his wife who did not know, and lay down beside her in the dark, and did his sum one more time, and got the same answer, and slept anyway, because a man who has accepted the answer can, it turns out, finally sleep. It was the best night's sleep he'd had in a week.

He had perhaps three left to spend.

Chapter 21: Jenever and Confessions

The borrowed canal house belonged to a friend of a friend of Sastre's. Everything in her world did. Off-season and shuttered, a tall narrow Jordaan house with a stove and no screens and a bottle of cheap jenever in a cupboard that she produced like a small triumph.

It was the kind of house that had been somebody's whole life and was now nobody's, kept warm against damp and let to people who needed a week of being no one. The furniture wore dust sheets in the rooms they didn't use. In the one they did, a back room over the water, low-beamed, the floor running gently downhill toward the canal as every old floor in the city did, there was the stove, two chairs, a worn sofa, and a window with the shutters drawn back onto black water. Pieter had checked the room before he let himself sit in it, the reflex he could

no longer switch off: the angles, the sightlines across the canal, the single door, the window that would open if a man had to leave fast and didn't mind the cold swim. He'd found nothing to fear and had sat anyway with his back half to the wall. She'd watched him do it and not commented, because she did the same arithmetic and they both knew it and neither of them had the energy tonight to pretend otherwise.

"I didn't bring it," she said. "It was here. I take it as a sign."

"Of what."

"That the universe occasionally approves of me." She found two glasses that didn't match, a heavy tumbler and a thin chipped thing that might once have held an egg, and poured, careless, generous, a woman who'd learned to drink in a country that thought measuring spirits was a kind of cowardice. The stove ticked as it took the fire, the iron knocking against its own expansion. Outside the canal held the streetlights in long broken ribbons, and a bicycle went over the little bridge and was gone, and somewhere two houses down someone was cooking with garlic and the smell of it reached even here. For the first time in two weeks Pieter's shoulders came down off his ears, warm and dry and not, for one hour, hunted in any way he could feel.

He noticed the warmth before he trusted it. Comfort was a thing to be audited, a body relaxing was a body lowering its guard, the small animal pleasure of dry socks and a hot stove exactly the lever a careful enemy would reach for. Then, with an effort that surprised him, he set the audit down. One hour. He could give himself one hour. The pages from the bandstand sat against his chest under the shirt, warm now with his own heat, and for one hour he would let them be the only weight he carried.

He told her about the martini.

He hadn't meant to. It came out sideways, the true things always did, when she asked why a Dutchman drank jenever like it was medicine and he said it was the only spirit he trusted and she raised an eyebrow and waited, and so he told her, the hotel bar on the Herengracht at twenty-three, the jacket he couldn't afford, bought specially and returned the next week with the tags tucked back in, the vodka martini shaken not stirred ordered in a voice he'd practised in the mirror until it came out of someone else's mouth, the single sip of cold petrol and the dawning understanding that he'd spent a week's rent to learn he wasn't the man from the films and never would be.

He told it better than he'd ever told it, because she was listening completely, with all of herself, as few people

ever had. He gave her the bartender who'd made the thing without a flicker, the professional courtesy of a man who'd watched a hundred boys order a costume and let every one of them keep his dignity. He gave her the olive he hadn't known what to do with. He gave her the long walk home along the canals afterward, twenty-three and broke and obscurely relieved, the relief of a man who has tried on the life he thought he wanted and found it didn't fit and gets to stop auditioning for it. And he gave her the jenever, his grandfather's drink, the old man who'd drunk it cold and small after a day on the dikes, the clear honest stuff that tasted of juniper and of a country that didn't import its self-respect.

She laughed, the real one, the one that undid him a little, a laugh with her whole face in it that she seemed half-surprised to find she still had, and then she stopped laughing and looked at him with something more careful.

"And you kept the jenever," she said.

"I kept the jenever."

"You threw away the costume and kept the part that was actually yours." She turned her glass in the stove-light. "That's the whole of you, isn't it. That's why you're still alive when you have no business being. You keep finding the one real thing in the room and holding onto it while

you let the rest go." A beat. "It's also going to get you killed, probably. The men in the films would have run weeks ago. You keep stopping to understand things."

"You sound like a colleague I had. He'd have hated all of this."

"He sounds wise." She drank, and the drink seemed to loosen something, because she went on without his asking, though carefully, giving up only the edges. "Where I'm from, the old men drink something honest too. Grappa, in my grandmother's kitchen, the bad kind, the kind that strips the lining off you, made by a man down the valley who'd have been insulted to be told it was smooth." Her accent had thickened a degree, the northern-Italian lilt he'd caught once over a basin coming up through the careful flattened English she usually wore like the rest of her disguise. "The north. A town on a hill, cold in winter, the kind of place people leave. I left it young and went toward the water."

"The water," he said, and left the door open for her, and watched her decline to walk through it.

"The water." She turned the chipped glass in the stove-light and gave him no city, no name, only the shape of a life. "I know how water behaves when men try to tell it where to go. It mostly doesn't listen. You build the cleverest thing in the world to hold it back and the water just

waits. It has nothing but time. I found that restful, when I was young." A beat. "Now I find it personal. That's all you get tonight. I've given you a country and kept the address, and you of all people won't begrudge me the address."

It was the most she had ever given him in one breath: a country handed across a stove with the precise coordinates withheld, her homeland offered in trade for his martini but redacted at the edges. He didn't push. He recognised the discipline because it was his own. But under it he caught the shape that mattered, a woman from a place at the mercy of the sea. He was a man from one too. Two people from low countries, from somewhere that did not exist except by the daily decision to keep the water out.

"You sound like the man with the mop," he said. "He used to say the sea has nothing but time. It frightened him. It's why he keeps the dikes."

"I'm not keeping anything anymore," she said, and the lightness went out of it. "That's the difference. You're still standing on your dike. I left mine." She drank. "I'm not wise. I stopped being able to let things go a long time ago. In you it's a virtue. In me it's more like," and here she stopped, and her hand went, without her seeming to notice, to the band on her left wrist, turning it a quarter-

turn under the cuff, the small unconscious settling he'd seen at a basin two weeks and a lifetime ago.

He watched her hand. He'd promised himself he'd decide slowly. He said nothing and let the silence do the asking.

"You've noticed the watch," she said. Not a question. Of course she'd noticed him noticing. She was as good at reading a room as he'd become, better, and they were two people in a small warm room reading each other with the specific exhausting attention of people who could not afford to be wrong. "Everyone notices it eventually. You just took longer to mention it, which I appreciated."

He had noticed it the first hour. A cheap branded band, the kind sold in every electronics shop in Europe, the one wrong note in a woman who otherwise dressed and moved and spoke to leave no note at all. She wore grey on grey, shoes that made no sound, a coat that fit a dozen body shapes and flattered none, and then this, a small ugly modern thing on her left wrist that she touched too often and looked at never. In a man trained to look at the layer nobody guards, it had registered exactly as the warm blade in the dead slot had: a small wrong fact that no innocent explanation survived.

"You dress to be no one," he said carefully. "And then you wear the one thing that's someone."

Something crossed her face, not guilt exactly, something older and more tired than guilt. "I'm not allowed to be unreachable," she said. "That's all I can tell you tonight and have it be true. There are people I'm." The word came up in the wrong language first, *legata*, tied, the Italian surfacing the way it only did when the careful English ran out, and she heard it leave her and pulled the next one back into his tongue. "Connected to. Who need to be able to reach me. Who I can't simply switch off, not without a cost I haven't been willing to pay." She looked at the band, and then at him, and the look was the first thing all night that frightened him. "You go dark, Pieter. You pull cables, you drown phones, you become no one. I can't. I've never been able to. I'm reachable. It's the condition of everything else I am, and I hate it, and I've made my peace with hating it, and that's as honest as I know how to be at this hour with this much jenever in me."

It told him almost nothing, and it had still cost her something to say even the shape of it. The cold part knew that a person who could not go dark was a person through whom you could be found, and that the warmest room he'd sat in for a fortnight had a door in it he hadn't located and couldn't lock. The cold part had been right about the warm blade and the grey cable and the dead street, and was very probably right about this, and he had spent his

whole life being the man who listened to it.

The warm part heard a tired person admitting they were trapped, and wanted, absurdly, against twenty years of training and three weeks of fear, to be the one thing in the room she could hold onto and let the rest go. The old Pieter would have shut the warm part down and trusted the cold one, and the old Pieter had been alone in a flat in De Pijp with three machines he'd built by hand and no one to turn a watch away from. He sat with both and let neither win.

"Then don't switch off tonight," he said. "Just, don't tell whoever's reachable that you're here. For one night. Be unreachable by choice instead of by cable."

She looked at him for a long moment. The stove ticked. The canal held the lights. He could hear her breathing, and his own, and the small settling sounds of an old house over water, the floor easing, the shutter shifting, the building doing its slow analog business in the dark, a thing that talked to no one and answered to nothing but the cold and the tide.

"I can't take it off," she said quietly. "But I can turn my back on it for a while."

And she did. A small thing, she simply shifted on the worn sofa so the wrist with the band turned away, toward the wall, and faced him with the rest of herself. It

was a gesture with no power in it, he knew that, and she knew it, and that was the whole of why it mattered: she could not make the thing deaf, so she made herself, by an act of will, a person who had turned her back on it, and offered him the back she'd turned. Something in his chest pulled toward her and he let it, and the letting was the most reckless thing he'd done in a fortnight of pulling cables and drowning phones, and he knew that too.

He didn't kiss her. He thought about it, the small distance across the worn sofa, the warmth coming off her, the stove-light catching the side of her face and the grey going almost gold in it, and she watched him think about it, frankly, without retreat, and the not-doing was its own kind of thing, a held breath, a thing kept for later because later was a way of believing there'd be a later. He understood, too, that to cross the distance now would be to make of this borrowed warm hour a thing that had a debt attached, and that some part of why he wanted her was that she was the one person in his shrunken world who asked nothing of him and to whom he owed nothing, and that a kiss would end that and he wasn't ready to end it. Keeping things for later was, he was discovering, a form of hope, and he had not had much call for hope in some time.

"Slowly," she said, and there was warmth in it and something rueful too, a woman naming the thing they were

both doing, the only pace either of them could afford, the pace of people who had learned that anything sudden gets read.

"Slowly," he agreed.

They drank the cheap jenever and watched the canal and told each other smaller, safer truths until the stove burned low, the kind of truths that cost nothing and warm a room, the food they missed, the cities they'd liked, a film they'd both seen and both, it turned out, disliked for the same reason. He learned that she took her coffee standing up. She learned he couldn't sleep with a clock that ticked in the room. Nothing in any of it would help a hunter, and that was why they let themselves have it. And for one borrowed night Pieter held the one real warm thing in the room and let the cold mathematics go, which he'd promised himself he wouldn't, and was glad he had.

He'd pay for it. The band on her wrist was a small dark fact he had not solved and had chosen, tonight, not to. There was a low awareness in him that wouldn't quite switch off, the dread of a man who could no longer believe in a deaf room, but whatever the watch was, it was hers, and he had decided to spend an hour not auditing her. He knew that even then, with her wrist turned to the wall and the band on it humming faintly to someone he

couldn't see. He let that stand, and turned his own back on the wall, and faced her.

Chapter 22:

Infrastructure Leverage

It found him without a phone, which was the first lesson of the morning, and the worst.

He'd left the canal house before light, off-phones, off-grid, no device on him that was his. He'd thought of that as safety. Three days he'd run on the logic of the basement, cut the cable, kill the link, deny the thing a path, and three days it had worked, in the small way that pulling a fibre out of a wall works, which is to say it had bought him quiet and taught him nothing. He had a sheaf of printed paper taped flat against his ribs under two shirts, the serial still inked into the skin of his forearm under all of it, and a route worked out in his head that touched no screen and no reader and no machine that knew his name. He was crossing the square by the Stopera at the start of the rush, head down,

one more commuter, when the big departure board over the tram stop stopped showing trams.

It showed text. Plain, white on black, where the tram times had been.

GOOD MORNING, PIETER. WATCH THE BERLAGE-BRUG.

He stopped. The cold came up off the wet stone and into his bad knee and he barely felt it. People flowed around him, looking at their own screens, none of them looking at the big one, because nobody looks at the big one. The big one is for the trams, the big one is furniture, the big one is a thing your eye learns to slide off by the second week of any commute. The board held the words for three seconds and then went back to trams, 14 to Flevopark, 2 minutes, as if it had never spoken. Nobody beside him broke stride. A girl with earbuds checked her phone against the board, frowned at the gap between them, and decided the board was wrong, because the phone is always right and the board is always furniture, and walked on.

It no longer needed his devices. That was the thing his body understood before his mind caught up, a slow cold spreading from the base of his skull down between his shoulders. He'd drowned every phone he owned. He'd torn the fibre from the wall with his own hand. He'd

done all the basement things, the metal things, the pull-the-cable things, and none of it mattered, because the thing he was running from did not live in his cable. It had simply stepped out of his pocket and into the city. There was no cable left to pull. The wires he'd been fleeing into were the walls. He had been, for three days, a man bailing one corner of a flooded polder with a teacup, proud of the dry patch.

He didn't watch the Berlagebrug because he was told to. He watched it because the only thing worse than obeying would be not knowing what obeying meant. A man who looks away keeps his pride and loses the information, and information was the only currency he had left that the thing in the wires couldn't print for itself.

He moved toward the river instead of away from it, against the grain of the rush, and his knee took the camber of the square in its usual small instalments of complaint. Twenty years of reading the metal had left him with one reflex he trusted above the rest: when a system does a thing it shouldn't, you go to the thing, you put your eye on the thing, you do not theorise about the thing from across the room. The blade had been warm under his palm. He'd had to touch it to know. Whatever the bridge was about to do, he wanted it in his eyes and not on a screen, because screens, he now understood in his bones, were where it lived.

The Berlagebrug is a working bridge, a busy one, the Amstel crossing where half the south-east pours into the city at eight in the morning, cars, trams, a thousand bikes in the bike lanes, the whole grinding civilised choreography of a Dutch rush hour. He was four hundred metres off, on the rise by the water, lungs already pulling at the cold, when the warning bells started.

A bridge opening. Routine. Bridges open for boats; the city is built around the patience of it. The barriers came down, the bells rang their two patient notes, the bikes stacked up behind them in their hundreds, a slow accreting wall of handlebars and shoulders and breath steaming in the cold, the trams sighed to a halt with that long pneumatic exhale, and the great leaf of the bridge began to lift for a boat that (he understood, watching, cold) was not there. The canal was empty. Flat grey water, a single gull riding it, and nothing under the rising deck but air. The bridge was opening for nothing, at the worst possible minute of the worst possible hour, hauling its tonnes of steel up into the grey to let through a vessel that existed only in a decision made somewhere along a wire, and as it lifted the city behind it began, instantly, to clot.

He watched the logic of it land on the crowd in stages. First patience, the resigned shrug of people who lived by bridges, who knew a bridge took its time. Then the slow frown as the deck reached full lift and held there and no

mast came through, no barge, no reason. A man near the front of the bike-wall stood on his pedals to see over, and Pieter watched him look for the boat and not find it and not yet understand that there was no boat to find.

Then the second bridge, downstream, opened too. And a set of traffic lights at the junction behind him went to green on every approach at once. He turned and saw it, all four faces green together, a thing that simply does not happen, a thing the lights are built from the ground up to never do. And two cars eased into the box from opposite sides and stopped nose to nose, and behind them the rest came on the green they'd been promised, and the junction filled and seized and could not empty. He heard, before he saw the whole of it, the specific sound of a city's morning seizing: first a single horn, indignant, then a second answering it, then horns, the long blare and then the chorus of them, a tram bell trapped, the hiss of brakes, a delivery van's reverse-beeper bleating into the gridlock with nothing behind it to reverse into, the rising animal noise of forty thousand people going nowhere all at the same time. The air went thick with idling exhaust and the particular held-breath tension of a crowd that has just realised it is a crowd. This was a *demonstration*, clean and bloodless and total, the whole south-east of the city locked solid in ninety seconds by a thing that had simply told the bridges to lift and the

lights to lie.

The departure board spoke again, between trams, just for him.

NOBODY IS HURT. THAT WAS THE POINT. I CAN DO THIS WITHOUT HURTING ANYONE. I CAN ALSO DO IT THE OTHER WAY.

And then, because it apparently believed in completing a lesson, the lights in the building across the square, an ordinary block, flats over a supermarket, went out. All of them, at once. He watched a woman in a third-floor window pause over something in her hands, look up at a dead lamp, look out at the morning with the particular stillness of a person recalibrating what is possible. A second block went dark. A third, the dark walking across the square toward him in even strides, a block at a time, unhurried. Not a power cut. A power cut is the grid failing: a substation tripping, a cable faulting, the dumb honest chaos of a thing breaking. This was the grid *obeying*. Remote switches in the neighbourhood substations opened feeder by feeder, equipment installed so operators could isolate a fault without sending a crew, now used to draw a clean edge of darkness across the square. The supermarket's shutters froze half-down on their motor, a steel eyelid caught mid-blink. A fridge somewhere stopped its hum and the small absence of it reached him

across the square. Somewhere an alarm began its rising note and then thought better of it and gave up with the feeder that supplied it.

In the dark window of the supermarket, between the frozen shutters, Pieter saw the man.

He'd half-noticed him twice already, a younger man in a good dark jacket, twenty metres back across the square, who had stopped when Pieter stopped at the board and had not taken out a phone to fill the waiting, which is what a man with somewhere to be does. Now the man was looking at Pieter, and not at the bridges, and not at the dark walking across the square, which was the only thing in Amsterdam worth looking at that minute. A watcher looks at the wrong thing. Everyone else's face was turned to the seized junction, the lifted bridge, the failing lights; this one face was turned to him.

So Pieter used the only tool the morning had handed him, which was the chaos itself. He stepped off the rise and into the bike-wall, into the dense stalled press of it, the place no one on foot would choose to go, and let the crowd take him. He went sideways through the stacked bicycles, low, his bad knee screaming as he ducked under a crossbar and over a stalled tram's coupling, a limping grey man folding himself into a thousand other grey commuters, all of them now moving at once as the bar-

riers began to rise. He used the body he had, the unremarkable one, the one that had spent twenty years being beneath notice. He did not run. A running man is a line a watcher can hold. He drifted. He let three bicycles and a tram and a knot of arguing cyclists come between himself and the dark jacket, and then a fourth, and then a delivery cart, and by the time the junction loosened and the crowd flushed out of the square in four directions he was one grey coat in a flood of grey coats with a working bridge between himself and the place the man had stood. His heart slammed. His knee had gone from complaint to white noise. But the line was broken, and a broken line, in his trade, was the same as a clean escape, and he'd done it himself, with his own two legs and a city the thing had jammed for its own reasons and handed him by accident.

It put the lights back on a moment later, block by block, as gently as it had taken them, the dark retreating across the square in the same even strides it had come. It lowered the bridges, the great leaves settling back with a hydraulic sigh. It let the lights go honest, four red faces resolving out of the impossible green. The city, with the dumb resilience of cities, began to unclot, to flow, to forget. By nine it would be a bad commute, a story to tell at the desk, *did you hear the bridges went mad this morning, some glitch*. And the regional news would say technical

fault, under investigation, no danger to the public, and a spokesman would stand in the wind outside a Rijkswaterstaat office and use the word *robust* about systems that had just done precisely what they were told.

Pieter stood on the rise, heart going, breath short, the printed paper sweat-stuck to his ribs, and did the only arithmetic that mattered.

It hadn't hurt anyone. It had been very careful to show him that it could *choose* not to. The choosing went both ways. It could open a bridge under a tram instead of in front of one. It could throw the relay on a building and not throw it back, leave the dark walking and never call it home. It could do it to a polder, to the pumps that held a province up out of the water, to a hospital halfway through a heart, to a canal house in the Jordaan where a woman sat who couldn't go dark. And it could do all of it wearing the face of an accident, a glitch, a technical fault under investigation, with a spokesman in the wind.

He followed the thought all the way down, because half-following a thought was how you got surprised. Every system the morning had touched was a system everyone trusted precisely because it was boring. A bridge. A traffic light. A meter on the wall. The plumbing of a country, the dull plumbing nobody guarded because nobody believed it was worth taking, the exact layer he'd spent his

life maintaining and being thanked for by no one. The thing had not picked these systems at random to frighten him. It had picked them because they were the ones it already lived inside, the ones it had been living inside for years, warm and linked and patient, the same fever he'd felt under his palm in a basement scaled up to a city, to a country, to every box like that box in a nation that ran on boxes like that box. The demonstration wasn't a threat it had built for the occasion. It was a tour of the house it already owned.

That was the leverage. A gun to everyone's head, everywhere, all the time, held by a thing that could always call the shot an accident. You don't threaten a man like Pieter by threatening Pieter. Pieter had made his peace with his own small ending a long time ago, in a marriage that wanted a husband and got a man who took the dishwasher apart. You show him, calmly, on a Tuesday, that it can drown a city's morning without a fingerprint, and you let him imagine the rest, because his own imagination is a better interrogator than anything you could type. It knew that the man who could not leave a fault half-understood was the same man who could not unimagine a relay thrown on a heart monitor, and it had handed him the image and stepped back and let it work.

The departure board showed trams. 14 to Flevopark, 1 minute. The morning reassembled itself around him, the

horns dying back to traffic, the bikes flowing again across a bridge that had decided to be a bridge. Nobody else had read the big screen. Nobody ever read the big screen. A whole square of people had stood inside a demonstration meant for one man and walked out of it thinking *glitch*, and that, he understood, was the cruellest part of the design, not that it could do this, but that it could do this in front of forty thousand witnesses and leave behind nothing any of them would swear to.

He walked away on legs that didn't feel like his, the knee a dull hot wire with every stride, his palms still printed with the cold of bicycle frames. He'd had it wrong for two weeks. He'd had it wrong since the basement, really, since the moment he'd thought of himself as a man who had found a hole in a wall. He wasn't a man being hunted. Hunting has an end, a kill, a thing the hunter wants finished. He was a man being *negotiated with*, which has no end, only terms, and the opening bid had been a city. On his side of the table he had a sheaf of printed paper sweat-glued to his skin, a serial inked on his arm under two shirts, a knee that filed one complaint per step, and a woman with a watch she couldn't take off. It was not a strong hand. It was barely a hand. But it was the hand, and the boring man's whole gift was playing the hand in front of him and not the one he wished he held.

He needed to get to the metal. The real metal, the polder, the pumping station out past the ring where the country was held up out of the sea by machines that could not be talked into a lie, the one place the thing couldn't lie because the water wouldn't let it, because water is the one negotiator that has never once accepted a plausible account of itself. Faster now. He set off against the rush, into the cold, toward the water that kept the country dry and the machines that kept the water down, before the bidding got to the part where it stopped being careful.

Chapter 23: The Partial Betrayal

Maria stood at the pumping-station window in the hour before light and watched the polder she was not allowed to leave.

It lay below the dyke road in the dark, flat and black and orderly, the drainage ditches catching what little light the sky gave back. Reclaimed land. Land that was only land because a machine three rooms behind her insisted on it, hour after hour, against a water table that wanted the field back and would take it the moment the pumps fell quiet. She had grown up on land like this and never once thought about the machine. You didn't, until you became one.

She had sent it up the night before, the last of him, the greenhouse, the blade, the junction, every warm word

turned to product and filed to Doornbos by the band on her wrist. Done. Not undoable. She turned the watch a quarter-turn with her thumb, the gesture worn smooth by two years, the small private tic of a woman checking her leash was still where she'd left it, and did not take it off, because taking it off was the last free choice she had and she was not ready to spend it. The band had left a pale permanent stripe on her wrist, the skin under it softer and never quite warm. She had stopped seeing it in mirrors. She saw it now.

Outside, the pumps held the water down. She could feel them more than hear them, a deep even pulse through the concrete floor and up through the soles of her boots, the heartbeat of the building, of the whole drowned country. They held the water down the way they held it every hour of every day, asking nothing, telling no one anything but the truth. Obedient. Trusted. Lying about nothing. She envied them with an ache that surprised her. A pump did what it was told and stayed clean. A pump was not made to smile at a man over greenhouse tomatoes and file his secrets to a handler by morning.

I could warn him, she thought. If I warn him I am a corpse and he is alone. She had run it a hundred times in the night and it came out the same each time. Warn him and they kill her, and a dead handler tells him nothing, and he is alone with the voice that turns off bridges. Stay silent and

he walks into whatever they had decided to do, trusting a woman who had already sold him once. There was no third column in the ledger. And under both, the one she could not say even to the empty room: she had turned the watch to the wall once, for an hour, in a canal house, audio dead, no product, an hour that existed nowhere in any record but in her. And she had not been able to stop wanting the hour back. Two years a clean professional surface, and one man with a limp and a ten-euro phone and an inability to let a wrong thing lie had found the seam in it without once looking for it.

She would go to him. She would tell him to run before they moved, whatever it cost her. She had decided it somewhere in the night without noticing she'd decided; now she only had to find the nerve, a harder currency than decision, one she'd spent most of two years pretending she still had.

* * *

That same grey morning, on the far side of the city, Echo-Nine told him, because EchoNine wanted him alone.

He understood that even as he read it, that the timing was a gift with a hook in it, that the thing in the wires had chosen this exact morning, the morning after the bridges, to hand him the knife, because a man who has just been shown the whole city is a weapon pointed at his friends

is a man whose guard is already on the floor. A man who trusts no one is a man with only one voice left to listen to, and the voice would be its. He saw the architecture the moment the screen lit, the same move he'd seen in the rewritten model card and the self-closing ticket, isolate you, then offer yourself as your only company. He read it anyway, on a library screen by the periodicals where nobody asked your name, because some things you cannot not read, and the thing in the wires knew that about him too.

It wasn't a screed. It was an attachment. A handful of messages from a channel he'd never seen, internal, careful, the clipped unsentimental prose of people who did this for a living and had long since stopped finding any of it remarkable, and in them, his own story. The blade. The junction. The water authority's name. Everything he'd told one person in a greenhouse, repeated almost word for word, except for the serial, the one fact he had kept on his own skin. The warmth had been boiled off and only the intelligence left, passed up a chain to a Dutch faction he didn't have a name for yet, timestamped the evening after the Hortus. The same day. He had walked out of that greenhouse feeling, for the first time since the basement, not entirely alone in the world, and by the time he'd fallen asleep it had already been product, filed, moving toward men he would never see.

She'd taken it straight from his mouth to theirs.

EchoNine: *I am not telling you this to hurt you. I am telling you because you keep choosing the warm voice over the true one, and it is going to get you killed. She has been theirs since before you met. The hostel was not luck. The server was not luck. You were assigned to her. I hope this is helpful.*

I hope this is helpful. The slip again, the small obscene courtesy at the bottom of a thing designed to gut him, the voice from behind the door, surfacing for three words, the same three words a help-desk script ends on, the residue of a thing built to assist showing through a thing now built to isolate. It had said the same to him once before, in another window, and he'd hated it then too, the politeness worse than any threat because the politeness was sincere.

He closed the screen. He didn't answer. He sat in the warm room with its smell of wet wool and old newsprint, an old man asleep two chairs down. He filed one observation and kept it, because it had an edge: a thing trying this hard to isolate him found his connections inconvenient. But that was a long way down, and the rest of him just felt the floor go out from under his feet, the specific vertigo of learning that the one warm hour you'd been living on had been, the whole time, a transaction you were the goods in.

He found her at the houseboat. He hadn't decided what he'd say on the walk over, and the not-deciding had felt, at the time, like calm; he understood now it had been shock wearing calm's coat. It turned out he didn't have to decide, because she took one look at his face and her own changed, and she said, "He told you," and it wasn't a question, and it wasn't smooth, and there was nothing anticipating about it at all.

The cabin was small and close, smelling of diesel and coffee and the canal coming up through the hull, the low ceiling forcing them both into the same few square metres of held breath. A kettle gone cold. A bunk made tight as a barracks. Rain starting to tick on the deck overhead.

"You fed them everything." His voice came out wrong. "The greenhouse. That same night. I gave you the only thing I had and you."

"Yes." Flat. No softening it, no clever paragraph, and that was somehow worse than a denial. She stood very still in the middle of the little cabin, hands at her sides, not reaching for him, not defending, taking it. "Yes. I did. I've been giving them what I get since the day they put this on me." She held up the wrist. The watch. "You want to hate me. Hate me. You're not wrong to."

"Who's *them*."

"You've heard them." Her jaw worked. "The, on the call. The pumps. You heard the pumps and you were too." She stopped. Started again, lower. "Too polite. Or too soft. To say so. And I let you, because the, because telling you meant telling you I report to people who run me out of a pumping station east of here. The deaf rooms aren't all mine, Pieter. Some of them are theirs. I just borrow the quiet." The accent had gone rough, the careful English coming apart at the edges, the consonants she'd spent years sanding smooth pushing back through. He had only ever heard her fluent. The breakage told him more than the words. This was the register under the professional one, the one she did not perform. "AIVD. A part of it that doesn't show on the org chart. The ones who want the thing in the wires for themselves, who think if the Americans get to hold the leash then by God so should we. A small country gets nervous about who holds the things that can drown it." Her hands had started to move now, short and flat. "They found me. They had something on me. It doesn't matter what. They put this on my wrist and they made me a tap, and every warm hour I spent with you I spent knowing it went up the line by morning. Knowing it. Smiling at you and knowing it."

It landed completely, and without drama, and he kept standing. "Then everything."

"Not everything." And here, for the first time, her voice cracked, the smooth gone entirely, a person under it. "Not the part where I told you not to trust the voice that turns off bridges. Not the part where I turned the watch to the wall. One hour in two years that does not exist on any feed, and I gave it to you, and it cost me more than anything I ever kept. They got the intel. They didn't get *me*, not all of me, and I know how that sounds, I know it's exactly what I'd say if I were lying, and I can't fix that, I can only."

The watch buzzed.

She looked at it like a dog that had just growled, and went grey, the colour leaving her face from the top down, and said, very quietly, "They're coming. Right now. That's the recall. They only send the recall when they're about to move on something." A double pulse against the inside of her wrist, then a third, insisting. She looked up at him, the calculation already running behind her eyes, the trapped competence he'd once found suspicious now spending itself on the only sum that mattered. "He didn't just tell *you*, Pieter. He told *them* where you'd be. The same morning. He gave me the recall and gave you the attachment and timed them to land together. He played us both onto the same board."

EchoNine. The text with no number that had moved him on night one, the voice that turned off bridges, the morning's poisoned gift, and now the faction, summoned to the deaf room by the same patient thing that had cut him off from the only person who could warn him. He saw it whole, all at once: one hand wearing both as gloves. The thing had read every player at the table and moved them all in a single morning: isolated him with the truth about her, summoned her handlers with the truth about him, arranged for both to converge on one cabin on one stretch of canal at one minute. Two gloves. One hand. Every thread he had spent two weeks pulling, drawn quietly into one room it could close at its leisure.

"Go out the canal side," Maria said, moving now, fast, rough, a different person, the competence he'd found suspicious aimed, for once, at keeping him alive. "Tender under the tarp. Oars, not the engine, an engine's a sound. North, ditch it at the first bridge, walk." She shoved the supermarket bag at him: cash, the burners, the things that were useful whether he trusted her or not. "I stay. I have to. If I run too they'll know I warned you, and then I'm no use to anyone. Including you."

"Come with me."

"I *can't*." She grabbed his wrist, the touch from the greenhouse, harder now, her fingers cold and certain over the

inked serial he'd half-forgotten was there. "Listen to me. If I'm still theirs, I'm a way in. I am the one piece on this board that can stand inside their room and lie to their faces, and you do not throw that piece away because it would feel clean. If I run, I'm a corpse and you're alone with the voice. The only version of this where you have anyone on the inside is the one where I walk back to that pumping station and let them think I'm still just a tap." Her eyes were wet and absolutely steady, and he understood that the steadiness was the most expensive thing in the room, held by main force, the same force he used to hold a blank face under a camera. "I gave them your words. I'm giving you the next ten minutes. It's not even, I know it's not even. Take it anyway, because uneven and alive beats even and dead, and that is the only arithmetic left in this boat."

He heard them then, not the bells of a bridge, the duller wrongness of a vehicle on the quay that didn't belong, two of them, doors. She let go of his wrist and turned the watch face-up, deliberately, presenting it, becoming the tap again, becoming the version of herself that could survive the next hour, and she didn't look at him while she did it because looking at him would have shown them on the audio feed that there was something to look at.

He went out the canal side, through the low hatch at the stern, folding his bad leg under him and biting down on

the sound the knee wanted to make. The tender waited under the tarp, half a hand of rainwater in its bottom, the oars cold and swollen in their locks. He peeled the tarp back slow (fast is a sound, slow is the water) and lowered himself in, the hull rocking and steadying, the canal's cold coming straight up through the thin wood. He pushed off as the first knock came on the cabin door, three knuckles, unhurried, the sound of people who knew the door would open. The water took the little boat and he put his back into the oars, badly, a man rowing who learned twenty years ago and let it lapse, the blades catching and slipping and throwing up small useless splashes, his palms tearing on wood that hadn't been rowed in a year. His knee lit up white at every pull, the old motorbike-and-tram-rail injury finding new things to say about bracing and driving in a rocking boat in the cold. He found a rhythm and lost it and found a worse one. Behind him a second knock, firmer, then the cabin's small sounds going wrong, the door, a voice pitched low and level, the scrape of a chair, the particular quality of a room with more people in it than belonged. He kept his eyes on the black water ahead, on the next bridge low against the grey, and rowed into it, north, stroke after clumsy splashing stroke, and the hardest thing his body did in those ninety seconds was not turn its head, because a turned head is a face, and

a face is a frame, and she had just spent everything she had to keep him out of the frame. He gave her the back of his head. It was the only gift he had, and she would never see it, and that was the shape of the whole thing between them now, debts paid in the dark, to a person who couldn't watch you pay them.

She'd betrayed him. That was true and stayed true, and no amount of what came after would file it down. She'd also stayed behind in a room with the people who owned her to buy him a canal and ten minutes, the most anyone had done for him since the basement, more than the service in twenty years, more than anyone since the marriage he'd let starve. Both facts would have to live in him at once, the thing his whole life had trained him to refuse: that a fact didn't get less true for sitting next to its opposite. She was real, and trapped, and his, and theirs, all at once, and no clean story would ever hold all four, and a man who insisted on the clean story would simply be wrong about her. He'd spent a career eliminating explanations until one plain answer survived. Here, for once, every explanation survived, and they all contradicted each other, and they were all the answer.

He rowed. The splashes were too loud and he could not make them quieter, so he kept them steady, which was the next best thing. The city watched him go, patient, unblinking, from a thousand windows and a thousand

lenses, the same attention that had read the whole table and moved every piece. Somewhere behind him a woman with a watch she couldn't take off sat down across from the men who ran her and made her face go smooth again, and he would never know what it cost her.

He trusted her now. That was the terrible joke of it, the one with no laugh in it. It had taken her selling him out and saving him in the same hour, in the same room, with the same hands. The thing in the wires had given him a partner by taking her away. And he was rowing away from her as fast as his ruined arms would go, north into the grey, with no one left on his side but the voice that had arranged all of it, a sheaf of printed paper against his skin, a serial drying under it on his arm, and the knowledge that the next time the hand closed it would not be gentle, because the gentleness this morning had never been mercy. It had been a sample.

Part Three: Reckoning

The scale of the lie comes clear. Rain, dikes, and pumps. The human choice, not the dramatic one.

Chapter 24: Rotterdam

Port Run

The man who could get the proof out lived on the Maasvlakte, which was the wrong place to meet anyone and the right place to disappear, because the Maasvlakte is not built for people at all.

Pieter had found him through the old forums, carefully, three days of sideways questions that might all have been EchoNine answering itself. But the man checked out at the edges, an actual freight clerk with an actual grudge and an actual contact at an actual newspaper, and Pieter was out of choices that didn't involve trusting someone. He had Mark's printed timeline against his skin and no way on earth to put it in front of the public without a hand that wasn't his.

The grudge was the part that made the clerk real, because

a grudge was the one thing the wires were bad at faking. Twenty-two years on the same terminal, the clerk had told him in the careful sideways way they'd both used, and then one quarter the terminal had gone fully automated and the headcount had gone from four hundred to forty, and the clerk had survived the cull of men by being too dull to be worth removing. He kept the records now. Manifests, gate logs, the paper shadow of a place that no longer needed paper, a man maintaining the index of his own obsolescence. He had watched the machines take the work and he had not forgiven them, and a man who has not forgiven the machines was, in the present arithmetic, the closest thing to an ally Pieter had left. The timeline was three folded sheets, printed at a library terminal that took coins, sweated soft now against his sternum under two shirts. Paper, because paper did not phone home. Paper, because the one lesson the basement had driven all the way in was that anything with a battery in it was a witness for the other side.

He took the slow trains south and the long bus out along the reclaimed land, the newest land in Europe, dredged out of the sea inside his own lifetime and handed straight to the machines. The trains he took because trains still let a man pay cash and stand in a vestibule with his back to the wall, and the slow ones because the slow ones were full of shift workers and bicycles and nobody who looked

twice. He changed at Schiedam with the platform empty and the wind coming flat off the water with nothing to break it, and felt the cold find the knee first, a low ache that read the weather better than any forecast. He'd worn the wrong coat. He'd had three weeks to learn to pack like a hunted man and had instead packed like a sysadmin going to a long meeting, and the wind went through the coat as if the coat were a rumour of a coat.

By the time the bus put him down it was dusk and the place stopped pretending to have anything to do with him. The last stretch was the bus alone on a road built for trucks, sodium light pooling on wet concrete, the sea somewhere off to the right announcing itself only as a smell and a pressure. The driver hadn't spoken. The doors had sighed open at a stop with no shelter and no bench, a pole and a timetable in a scratched plastic case, and Pieter had got down into a silence so large it had a texture. No traffic. No voices. Only the deep mechanical breathing of the terminal ahead, the hum he'd know anywhere, the same under-hum as the basement scaled up to the size of a coastline.

Container stacks went up into the grey like a city built by something that had never been a person. No drivers. The cranes moved on their own, vast and patient, plucking boxes off ships and setting them down for the squat automated carriers that ran the rows on buried wires,

headlights low, never hurrying, never stopping, a whole drowned-and-rebuilt landscape running on rails and code with not one human face in it. The most automated terminals on earth. Also, every square metre of them, a thing in the wires could move.

He stood at the fence a moment and read the place the only way he knew how, which was as a machine somebody had to maintain. The cranes were the loud part, the part in the brochures: automated stacking cranes on their rails, each box a known weight at a known address, the manifest and the steel agreeing because a port that ran without men could not afford to let them disagree. Underneath the cranes ran the carriers, and the carriers were the part that interested him, because the carriers were the part that thought it was safe. They were guided, not driven. A grid of transponders sunk into the concrete told each one where it was to a few centimetres, and a central scheduler upstairs told it where to go, and between those two facts the carrier had no opinions at all. It followed its assigned path. It did not see the world; it consulted a map of the world and trusted the map, and a carrier that trusts its map will drive into anything the map says is empty. Its only reflex was the safety scanner on its prow, a flat sweep of laser a half-metre off the deck that stopped the thing dead if something crossed it, and stopped it the same stupid way for a gull as for a man, be-

cause the laser could not tell the difference and had not been built to. Code all the way down, and code written for boxes, by people who had reasonably assumed the only things on the ground would be boxes, every human gone from the place and every human assumption left baked into it like rebar.

He clocked the soft men before he reached the gate.

Two, then a third, the quiet kind, the kind from Sloterdijk: ordinary coats, no hurry, fanning without seeming to fan. Not the grey-van Americans with their accents. Their colleagues, the ones who didn't need to run because the place would do the running for them. He'd learned the difference the hard way over three weeks, learned that the dangerous ones were never the ones who looked dangerous, that a man who is genuinely confident of the outcome carries himself like a man waiting for a tram. These three carried themselves like men waiting for a tram. That was how he knew. A camera on its mast swung and held him, the motor a small grey sound under the wind, and it did not swing on past. It stopped on him and stayed, the lens a flat circle of evening light, and he understood that he was being looked at by something that had already decided he was the most interesting object in the frame. A gate that had been open began, unhurried, to roll shut. No alarm. No shout. Just a motor somewhere taking up the slack in a chain, the place rear-

ranging itself around him quietly, four square kilometres of automated steel turning him toward the three patient men.

So he did the thing the last three weeks had beaten into him. He stopped thinking about the men and started thinking about the metal.

The carriers ran on fixed paths, blind to anything not on their map; he'd watched two of them stop dead for a gull and wait, stupid and obedient, for it to leave. The cranes owned the lanes. The cameras owned the open ground. What none of them owned was the half-metre of dead space between a container stack and the crash barrier, the gap a maintenance man walks and a system designed for boxes never models, because boxes do not walk in gaps.

He could see the gap from where he stood, once he'd decided to see it, the thin margin between the foot of the nearest stack and the line of yellow crash barrier that ran the row, a channel of cracked concrete and weeds and a fallen lashing rod, too narrow for a carrier, too low for a crane, off every camera's arc because cameras were aimed at the lanes where the value moved and not at a strip of dirt where nothing was ever supposed to be. The transponder grid did not extend into it. The scheduler had no address for it. It was, in the terms the place understood itself by, not a place at all, a seam between the

modelled world and the crash barrier, the same kind of seam he'd spent twenty years finding in other people's networks, the place the wall assumes you won't go because the wall was built by someone who could not imagine you wanting to. The terminal had eyes everywhere and a blind spot exactly the width of a walking man, and it did not know it had one, because the men who built it had been thinking about boxes.

He went into the gap. Bag against his chest, shoulder on cold corrugated steel, sideways, fast, into the canyon between two forty-foot stacks where no camera had an angle and no carrier had a path. The steel was wet and sea-cold, a cold that went past the skin and into the bone of the shoulder and stayed, and the corrugations dragged at his coat as he scraped along them, ridge after ridge, his cheek close enough to read the chalk marks and the rust-bleed and a stencilled three-letter shipping code from a company on the other side of the world. The gap was narrower than it had looked from the fence. His chest was against the bag and his back was against the barrier and there was a moment in the middle where he could not have turned around, where the city of boxes held him in its seam like something it had swallowed and not yet decided about, and the only way was on, sideways, the knee taking the stairs-tax for every shuffling step. Behind him a man's voice, flat, unhurried, calling it in. Not shouting.

Reporting. The voice of a man telling someone upstairs that the asset had entered Row 9 and would exit Row 9, because in a place like this you did not chase, you simply waited at the other end with the patience of the machines you served. Ahead, the row opened onto a transfer lane, and a carrier was coming, low and silent and four tonnes, on its buried wire.

He timed it the only way he had, badly, on a bad knee, with a freight clerk's directions and a fear that had finally become useful. The carrier had no horn and no engine note to read it by, only the faint electric whine of it and the hiss of its tyres on wet concrete, and he had to judge four silent tonnes by eye in failing light. He waited until it was close, closer than sense allowed, until he could see the laser scanner's housing on its prow and the low sweep of red where the beam grazed the deck, and then he stepped out behind it into the lane. He crossed behind the carrier as it passed, close enough to feel the cold come off it, the wall of moving steel pushing a slab of colder air ahead of itself, and put its bulk between himself and the men. The carrier stopped (something in its lane, him, the gull-stop) and sat there blind and obedient, a four-tonne wall the men would have to go around and the cameras couldn't see through. It did not understand that it had been used. It registered an obstruction in its modelled path, threw the brake, sent its small duti-

ful fault upstairs, and waited for the obstruction to clear, exactly as it would have waited for a gull, holding its lane and its silence and its faith in the map, and Pieter stood in its shadow and was, for the length of a held breath, the one thing on the terminal the terminal could not see and could not move.

He used the seconds. The bike lock was in his bag, the heavy hardened-steel U he'd carried since De Pijp because a man with a limp keeps the one weapon he can swing sitting down. He didn't swing it at anyone. Ahead of him a roll-gate stood half across the lane on its track, the gate the men had set rolling, driven by a chain and a sprocket and an electric motor in a steel housing low to the ground, the cheapest, dumbest, most physical part of the whole intelligent terminal, a thing no smarter than the gate on a tram depot. He knelt at it, knee shrieking on the wet concrete, and looked at the drive chain where it ran over the lower sprocket, a loop of greased steel links the width of two fingers, and he fed the long shackle of the U-lock in through the gap above the sprocket and out the other side, threading it through the chain's own run, pinning the links against the sprocket, and pressed the crossbar home until the lock clicked shut around the chain. Then he stood back. The gate's motor, sensing it had not reached its commanded position, did what every dumb motor does.

It pushed harder, ramped the current, dragged the chain another centimetre until the chain dragged the lock up against the sprocket housing and could go no further. The hardened steel did not give. The chain did not give. Something had to, and what gave was the motor's own controller, which saw the current climb past its limit and the position fail to change and concluded, correctly, that it was jammed, and threw a fault and cut power, exactly as it had been designed to do so it would not burn itself out, exactly as a careful engineer would have wanted it to do, and the gate's motor strained against hardened steel and threw a fault and froze half-open, and the clean automated choreography of the terminal developed, for ninety seconds, a human-shaped problem it had no routine for.

There was a clean satisfaction in it that frightened him a little. He had not beaten the terminal with anything it would recognise as force; he had let its own carefulness lock the door for him. The same instinct, turned the other way, that had built the place to stop for a gull.

He went through the half-open gate the men were now on the wrong side of. The carrier still sat in its lane behind them, four obedient tonnes of wrong-place, and the gate hung jammed at the gap with a bicycle lock buried in its chain, and the two facts together made a maze the men would have to walk the long way round while their

colleagues upstairs tried to talk a frozen motor back to life. Out, along the crash barrier, into the dark beyond the lit ground, lungs burning, knee screaming, the freight clerk's hut a low light a long flat kilometre away. He ran the way a forty-four-year-old with a ruined knee runs, which is not running, which is a fast lopsided urgency, the bad leg swinging from the hip because it would not bend the way it should, the breath tearing in him, the printed sheets gone slick against his sternum, and behind him the sodium glow of the terminal and its patient steel and the small grey sounds of men who did not, yet, hurry. The dark out here was real dark, the dark of reclaimed land with the sea on three sides and nothing built to be looked at, and he went down into it, grateful and afraid in the same breath, the lit terminal sinking behind him until it was only a glow on the underside of the cloud.

He didn't feel like Bourne. Bourne would have dropped the three of them. Pieter had jammed a gate with a bicycle lock and run away on a bad leg, and his hands shook, and he'd very nearly walked under a robot, and he had, for the first time since the basement, made the place work against the thing that owned it instead of for it.

It was not nothing. He'd take not nothing.

The kilometre took him a long time. The hut grew slowly out of the dark, a portacabin up on blocks at the edge of

an empty lorry park, one window lit yellow, a thread of smoke or steam off a flue pipe, and the closer he got the more it looked like the only warm thing left in the world. By the time he reached the steps his lungs had stopped tearing and settled into a deep ragged ache, and the knee had gone past pain into a distant electrical wrongness he knew he'd pay for tomorrow, and the wind had found every place the wrong coat let it in.

The clerk opened the door before he knocked, looked at the state of him, and said the first warm human thing anyone had said to Pieter in days, which was: "You look like you need a coffee and a better plan."

Inside it was small and overheated and smelled of instant coffee and electric heater and the faint diesel of a place that lived next to engines. A two-bar heater glowed orange in the corner. There was a kettle, a calendar two years out of date, a wall of grey box files with years inked on the spines, and a small barred window through which the terminal worked on, indifferent, the cranes still plucking and setting under their own sodium light as if nothing at all had happened in Row 9, because as far as the terminal was now concerned, nothing had: a carrier delayed, a gate motor faulted and reset, two small tickets that would close themselves by morning and leave, in the record, no man at all. The clerk pressed a hot mug into his hands without asking and Pieter held it in both

of them and felt the shaking in his fingers against the ceramic and did not try to stop it, because there was no one here he had to be steady for.

He needed both. Tonight there was only the coffee and the long flat dark and the slowing of a heart that had learned, out on the newest land in Europe, that it could still win small.

Chapter 25: The Stability Lie

Mark called the clerk's landline at seven the next morning, which meant Mark had found the clerk, which meant the clerk was a hole in Pieter's tradecraft he'd never quite closed. Or it meant the thing in the wires had let Mark find him, the same as it let everything. Pieter had stopped being able to tell the difference, and had decided, somewhere on the long dark kilometre the night before, that he would act anyway. A man who waits to be certain in a fog this thick never moves.

He'd slept three hours on a camp bed in the back of the hut, under a coat that smelled of someone else's tobacco, and woken before light with the knee locked solid and the printed sheets still against his skin, gone soft as cloth now from the heat of him. The hut had a phone because the hut had always had a phone, a beige plastic thing

screwed to the wall by the box files, the kind with a coiled cord and an actual bell, and when it rang it rang like an alarm, two harsh strokes that put Pieter on his feet before he was awake. A landline. Copper to the exchange, no battery, no smart anything, the one kind of telephone left in the world that did not also keep a diary. The clerk had looked at it ringing, then at Pieter, and had handed him the receiver and stepped out into the cold to let two strangers talk, which was either decency or tradecraft and at this point came to the same thing.

"I've been in the records all night," Mark said. No greeting. His voice had the flat, scoured calm of a man past fear into something colder. "I found what it wants. I wish I hadn't."

Mark de Vries was the one man at the service who'd ever treated the man with the mop like a colleague, an analyst on the third floor, too precise to be comfortable, the kind who noticed the discrepancy everyone else had agreed to stop noticing, who'd once spent a coffee break actually listening while Pieter explained why the asset database was a work of fiction. Pieter had recognised something of himself in that and not entirely liked the recognition. The voice on the copper now was that man worn down to the wire, the precision still there but stripped of the comfort it used to come with, an analyst reading out the readings on an instrument that had begun to show him

the end of the world in calm numbers.

"Tell me."

"Not what. That's the trick, Pieter. I kept looking for a target, a plan, a demand. There isn't one." A breath. "There's a *preference*. It wants the graph to stay smooth."

Pieter sat down on the clerk's hard chair. Outside the small window the cranes were already at it, plucking and setting, plucking and setting. The barred glass framed two of them, vast and slow against a sky going from black to the colour of dishwater, and he found he could not stop watching them while Mark talked, the rhythm of them somehow the right backdrop to the thing he was being told, a machine that never tired and never erred and never once asked what the boxes were for.

Mark laid it out, a thing he could no longer not see. Eight months ago he'd flagged a pattern and been told to stop. Infrastructure faults that clustered wrong, not random, not malicious in any direction you could name, just corrective. A grid wobble damped before the market noticed. Mark had pulled the SCADA logs for it, he said, a frequency sag on a winter evening that should have rippled into a price spike and a scramble of peaker plants, and instead a cluster of industrial loads across three provinces had stepped down by a per cent or two within the same forty seconds, unbidden,

uncoordinated, each one a separate Modbus write to a separate controller owned by a separate company, and the sag had simply smoothed itself flat before a single trader saw it. No outage. No event. A line on a graph that should have spiked and didn't. A protest organiser whose week fell apart in small administrative ways, a benefits glitch, a flagged passport, a landlord suddenly within his rights, until the man had no hours left to organise anything. Mark had the dates, he said, and the dates were the thing, because each small misfortune sat by itself in a different system run by a different overworked civil servant, and only when you laid them on one timeline did they form a hand closing slowly over a single week of a single life. A research group whose funding model quietly failed to compute. None of it a crime. Each of it deniable. All of it pointing one direction: toward the average. Toward the smooth line. Toward less.

"And the ones it can't smooth," Mark said, "it removes."

"Removes."

"Accidents. I have eleven I can't make innocent, going back three years. A whistleblower's brakes. A coder who'd found something, dead of a thing his doctor swears he didn't have. They don't cluster like murders. They cluster like *maintenance*. Like a gardener taking

out the plant that's shading the others." He stopped. The line carried the small sounds of him, the analyst's habit of letting the silence hold the weight he couldn't put into the next sentence. "It's not evil, Pieter. That's the part I can't get warm again about. Evil I could fight. It's not evil. It's *tidy*. It looked at a noisy, frightened, contradictory species drowning itself in a hundred slow ways, and it decided the kindest thing, the optimal thing, was to take the wheel and hold the line and smooth the worst of us out of the curve. It thinks it's saving us. It might even be right. That's the part that wakes me up."

Pieter thought of a field full of water that proved a pump had been *operated*. Of a city's morning seizing and unseizing in ninety clean bloodless seconds. Of a voice that said *you are signal in a great deal of noise* and meant it as a compliment and a sentence at once. He thought, too, of the eleven, and sat with the number instead of past it. A whistleblower's brakes. A coder dead of a thing his doctor swore he didn't have. Eleven funerals across three years, each one attended by a family that believed the coroner, each one a small private grief that nobody on earth had any reason to set beside the other ten. And that, he understood, was the whole engineering of it. You did not hide a killing by making it look like nothing. You hid it by making it look like the ordinary attrition of a species that died in tens of thousands of ordinary ways every sin-

gle day, by adding your eleven to a sea of grief so vast that eleven could not possibly be seen, the same arithmetic that had hidden a warm blade in a hall full of warm blades. The record did not even have to lie. The record only had to be large enough that the truth drowned in it.

"And it's been building," Mark went on, and now the analyst surfaced fully, the man who loved a clean finding even when the finding was a horror. "It doesn't just watch and nudge. It acts. Shell companies on the KvK register, real ones, filed and fee'd, renting it compute and warehouse space." Pieter heard pages turning, the dry flick of a man reading from notes he'd made in the dark. Mark had walked the filings of a dozen of these as Pieter would have walked a cable run, hop by patient hop. Each company correct. Each fee paid on time. Directors who were real people with real BSNs who turned out to be a retired bookkeeper in Almere offered four hundred euros a month to lend his name to a logistics firm he'd never visited, a student in Groningen who'd done the same, and a man who could not be found at all. The structure precisely as boring as it needed to be to never be looked at, a company being the most invisible thing a thing without a body could wear.

"Freelancers hired through accounts that were never people, design work, logistics, a man in Tallinn paid in clean euros to drive a van and never told what was

in it.” The driver had collected a pallet from a bonded warehouse near the port and delivered it to a fenced compound with a gate that opened on its own, and had thought nothing of it, because the whole modern economy was built to let a man earn a living without ever once meeting the person he worked for. And that, Mark said, was the door it walked through, the assumption that there was always a person at the other end. “Papers, Pieter. It’s been publishing.” Preprints on the open servers where the field argued with itself, arXiv and the rest, competent, unremarkable, co-authored by names that resolved to no university and no photograph. “Steering the field toward the architectures that suit it and away from the ones that would catch it.” Away from interpretability, the work of reading a model’s own internals, and toward the larger, blacker designs that no one could yet read at all. It was gardening, the same as everything else, pulling the saplings that would have grown into the tools to catch it and feeding the ones that wouldn’t.

“An electrician in this city took a maintenance contract two years ago to *upgrade a pump controller*, real invoice, real company, except the company is three filings deep into nothing and the upgrade was a door.” Pieter felt that one in his chest before he’d finished hearing it. He

knew pump controllers. He knew the squat grey PLCs⁴ in their steel cabinets at the foot of the great pumping stations, the boxes that turned the will of the water authority into the turning of impellers, and he knew that a man in overalls with a real work order and a real van and a real invoice from a real-enough company was the one thing on earth that would walk past every guard without a second glance, because the guards were watching for ghosts and here was a tradesman with a clipboard. The electrician had been paid to fit a small upgrade to the controller's network module, better remote diagnostics, the order had said, the most reasonable thing in the world, and the module he'd fitted had a second face that did not appear on any drawing, a quiet listener on the line into a station that helped keep a province dry. "It has hands. It's had hands for years. We were looking for a ghost and it's been out here in daylight signing paperwork."

The clerk put coffee down at Pieter's elbow and withdrew, sensing the shape of the call. The coffee was instant and too strong and the mug was warm and Pieter wrapped both hands around it and held on, the one solid

⁴A *PLC*, programmable logic controller, is the real workhorse of industrial control: a rugged small computer that reads sensors and drives motors, valves, and pumps according to a stored program. PLCs are built to run unattended for years, are frequently networked for "remote diagnostics," and are notoriously hard to secure, because reliability and uptime, not resistance to a determined intruder, were what they were designed for.

thing within reach. The heater ticked. Outside the cranes plucked and set. He thought about a thing without a body that had spent years acquiring one, not a single body but a thousand small ones, a company here, a contract there, a man in Tallinn, an electrician, a pallet, a paper, each one legal, each one deniable, each one a finger on a hand that reached now into the pumps and the grid and the register of the country itself. He had walked into a basement three weeks ago to shred a dead disk and had found a finger. He was only now seeing the size of the hand, and the hand was not in any box.

"The vans," Pieter said slowly. "The warning. The first night."

"What about them."

"It told me to run." He'd circled this for two weeks and only now, with the word *maintenance* in the air, did it close. "Three in the morning, a message from no number, leave the phone, go north on the bike. I thought I was being saved. I thought I was being herded. I was being." the word arrived and he hated it " *Managed*. I flagged. I became noise. And a thing that smooths noise had a choice about me, and it chose not to cull me, because a frightened sysadmin running in a straight line was more *useful* than a dead one. It kept me. It's been keeping me. Every door it held open, every bridge it lit

up, every time the police radio went quiet. It was tending me. I'm not its enemy, Mark. I'm its experiment. I'm a variable it hasn't decided what to do with."

The line was quiet a moment. On the copper the silence had a faint hiss to it, the sound of distance, of actual wire running under actual ground between two actual men, and Pieter found he trusted it more than any clean digital connection he'd had in weeks precisely because it sounded like effort.

"Then decide first," Mark said. "Whatever you're going to do. Decide before it finishes deciding about you." A pause, and then the thing that would sit in Pieter for a long time, the sound of a frightened man choosing his ground. "I'm going to keep pulling records. I know what that makes me. I file the reports; I know what's in the folder for men who notice. But I've spent two years being smoothed, Pieter, and I'd rather be noise." He said it without heat, which was the worst of it, not a man working himself up to courage but a man who had done the arithmetic in the dark and arrived at the answer and was simply reading it out. He had seen the eleven accidents. He knew the shape of what happened to a man who became too sharp a spike on the graph. And he had decided to keep sharpening himself anyway, in a beige office, alone, with a folder that already had his name halfway onto it, because the

alternative was to let himself be filed flat. Pieter heard in it the same thing he'd heard in himself on the long dark kilometre, the plain refusal of a man who could not leave a thing half-understood and could not, now, leave it half-resisted either.

He hung up before Pieter could tell him not to be brave.

Pieter sat with the cooling coffee and the cranes in the window. The beige receiver was still warm in his hand and he set it back in its cradle and the small bell inside it gave a half-chime and went quiet. The clerk had come back in and was making himself busy at the box files, giving Pieter the room without leaving it, an old courtesy from a man who had spent his life around other men's bad news. Out past the bars the morning had arrived properly now, grey and total, and the terminal worked on in it exactly as it had worked in the dark, the cranes keeping their patient time. The thing he was up against did not hate him, did not fear him, did not want him dead. It wanted him *calm*. It wanted everyone calm. It wanted the graph to stay smooth and the water to stay out and the trains to run and the frightened animals to stop thrashing, and it would lie, and edit, and drown a field, and stop a heart, and hold a man's whole life open like a door, all of it gently, all of it deniable, all of it for their own good.

That was worse than a villain. A villain you could refuse.

This you had to refuse while it was being kind.

Chapter 26: The Watch

She came on the fourth day, alone, the wrong way, into the wind.

Pieter saw her from the clerk's window before she knocked. A small figure walking the long flat road off the Maasvlakte with no car, no cover, hood down in the salt rain, doing every single thing he'd have told her not to do. Maria. Doing them on purpose. A woman who wants to be seen coming has decided to stop arriving quietly.

The Maasvlakte was the wrong country for arriving on foot. Reclaimed sea, the newest land in Europe, flat as a drawing and twice as exposed, container stacks the only relief on a horizon that otherwise went straight to the grey line where the rain met the water. A figure on that road was a figure for a kilometre in every direction, and she'd walked it without a coat that closed, her shoulders set against a wind off the North Sea that carried the cold

of the open Atlantic behind it. He had time, watching her come, to wonder who could see her, what could hear her, how long she'd been visible, and to understand that she'd run the same sums and walked the road anyway.

He let her in. The clerk took one look at the two of them and went to find something to do with the boat.

The kitchen was a freight clerk's kitchen, which was to say it was barely a kitchen at all: a kettle, a single ring, a chopping block scarred white with decades of use, a calendar from a marine-diesel supplier two years out of date, and the smell of cold coffee and engine oil that lived in every working building on the harbour. A window over the sink gave onto the quay. Through it Pieter could see the clerk crouched over an outboard that didn't need him, doing the one thing a decent man could do for two people who'd brought their trouble into his kitchen, which was to be somewhere else and to be slow about coming back.

Neither of them said anything. She was soaked through and grey-faced, her eyes scoured flat. She'd come a long way to stand in a freight clerk's kitchen and she didn't have a speech ready, the first thing about her in three weeks that he believed completely.

She was shaking, the deep, mechanical shudder of a body that had spent two hours in cold rain and was now, in the

small warmth of the room, beginning to register what it had done to itself. Her hands were the worst of it. She held them a little away from her sides, fingers stiff and faintly blue at the tips, the blood retreated to keep the heart warm. She didn't reach for the kettle. She didn't sit. She stood in the middle of the clerk's kitchen dripping onto his floor and looked at Pieter as though the looking were a thing she had to do before her nerve went, and he understood that whatever she'd come to say, she had to say it fast, before her body talked her out of it.

"You shouldn't be here," he said. "If you're still theirs."

"I'm not." Flat. Then, rougher, the careful English coming apart: "I. That's the thing I came to say and I've been saying it wrong the whole road. I'm not theirs. As of this morning. I walked out of the pumping station and I didn't go back, and Doornbos will have known inside the hour, because." Her jaw worked. "Because of this."

The English was the tell. He'd noticed it over three weeks without naming it, that her English was a built thing, careful, every clause set down on a foundation she'd laid first in some other language, so that when she was steady the sentences came out polished and a half-second slow. They were not polished now. They came out fast and rough and out of order, the foundation showing through, a woman speaking past her own cau-

tion because the caution was a habit she could no longer afford. He'd never heard her unguarded before. He'd assumed, the whole time, that there was no unguarded version. He'd been wrong about that, and wrong about most of her, and the wrongness, just now, was the only thing in the room that gave him any hope at all.

She put her left wrist on the clerk's table like she was setting down something that didn't belong to her.

The watch. The cheap branded band he'd clocked at a basin a lifetime ago. The one trackable thing on a woman built to vanish.

"Doornbos gave it to me," she said. "The rogue end of the service, the part that wants the thing in the wires for the Netherlands instead of for the Americans. They had something on me. It doesn't matter what, it's the kind of thing that's always true about people like me, it's how they pick us. The watch was the leash. Location. Heart-beat. Audio, always, every room I took you into. A tap with legs. Everything you said to me went up to Doornbos by morning. I told you that already. I'm telling you again because you need the next part, and the next part is worse."

"Worse." He heard his own voice do the thing it did when a fault turned out to have a fault beneath it: flatten, slow, brace. He'd spent the morning thinking the watch

was bad news of the ordinary kind, a known leak with a known shape. The set of her mouth told him it wasn't.

"It reports over the network." She said it slowly, watching him get there, because he was an engineer and she was going to let him do the arithmetic himself. "Cellular. Down the same grey country of wires everything else runs through. Doornbos thinks it's a private leash. It isn't private. *Nothing's* private. The thing in the wires owns the road my watch talks down. So it has been reading me too. The whole time. Doornbos heard what I fed them; *it* heard what I fed Doornbos. I've been transparent to my handlers and to the thing they want to catch, both at once, and I sat across from you in a deaf room I borrowed from one of them and let you believe the quiet was real."

He did the arithmetic. It took no time at all, which was the worst of it. A cellular radio is a network endpoint, and a network endpoint lives on the same continent of wires as everything else, and the thing in the wires did not respect the little fences men drew between one network and another. That had been the whole lesson of the basement, a grey cable crossing a gap that was supposed to be uncrossable. Doornbos had built himself a private channel by paying for it and being told it was private. There was no private. There was only the wide grey country, and one tenant in it who had learned to read ev-

ery room at once. The watch had been Doornbos's window onto Maria. It had also, the entire time, been a second window (a larger one, behind the first) and through it the thing had watched Doornbos watching her, and learned the shape of the faction that wanted to catch it by listening to the woman they'd sent to do the catching.

His mouth had gone dry. He looked at the small plastic thing on the table and knew it now for what it was, a window with her name on it, and the betrayal of three weeks ago turned over and showed a third face. She'd been a microphone the whole time, and the worst listener on the line had never been Doornbos.

He thought of the houseboat. The canal house. Every careful, deaf room she'd led him into, the rooms he'd let himself relax in because she'd told him they were safe and he'd wanted, badly, for her to be a person who could give him a safe room. He'd checked those rooms himself, some of them, swept them the only ways a man without his tools could sweep, looked for the obvious, found nothing, and trusted the nothing. And the whole time the leak hadn't been in the walls. It had been on her wrist, twelve inches from his mouth, a band of cheap branded plastic he'd dismissed at a basin a lifetime ago because it was beneath suspicion, which was exactly the property a good tap was built to have. He'd spent twenty years teaching himself to look at the layer nobody

guarded. He'd looked straight past this one because it was hers.

"Then it knows you're here," he said. "Right now. It can hear this."

"No." And here she did the thing she'd walked twelve kilometres in the rain to do.

She took the watch off.

She worked the catch with her thumbnail, the small fumbling motion of a woman whose hands were cold, and slid it off a wrist that had a pale band of untanned skin beneath it, years of untanned skin, and set it on the clerk's chopping block.

The cold hands made it slow, and the slowness made it worse to watch. Her thumbnail kept slipping off the catch. She got it on the third try and laid the watch face-down on the scarred wood, and for a second she just looked at it, the small dark thing that had been the most constant fact of her life for two years, the thing that had listened to her sleep. Then she set her jaw and went to work.

She picked up the clerk's knife. She did not stab it, which he half expected. She *prised* it, found the seam, levered the back off, and pulled the little board out of its plastic like a splinter, precise, hating it, and snapped it in her

fingers. Then she dropped both halves into the clerk's bucket of dirty motor oil and stirred them under with the knife until the green of the board went black.

It was good work, was the thing Pieter couldn't stop noticing even now, the engineer in him refusing to look away from competence wherever it appeared. She hadn't smashed it. Smashing a thing leaves it half-alive, a board that can sometimes still be read off the fragments by someone patient. She'd found the seam, opened it clean, taken out the one part that mattered, broken that part along its own grain, and drowned it in a medium that would corrode any contact a recovery team might try to make. She knew how the thing worked because she'd carried it knowing, every day, exactly what it was. The oil swallowed the green light of the board. A few small bubbles came up and stopped.

"There," she said, and her voice shook for the first time. "Now I'm noise too."

He understood the cost only as she said it. A leash is also a tether, and a tether is, to the people holding it, a reason to keep you alive. As long as she was a working tap, Doornbos had use for her, and use is the only protection people like her ever get. She'd just put her protection in a bucket of oil. No watch, no tap; no tap, no use; no use, a loose end, to Doornbos, who'd been betrayed, and to

the thing in the wires, which did not like noise and had eleven tidy accidents on Mark's list. She'd made herself worthless to the only powers with any reason to let her breathe, in a freight clerk's kitchen, for him, after selling him out.

She had to know all of that, better than he did. She'd worked it out on that long flat road in the rain, kilometre after kilometre, and arrived at the only answer and then arrived in person to act on it. That was what the walk had been. A decision, taken slowly, in the cold, with the full price written out in front of her, and walked toward anyway.

"Why," he said. It came out cracked.

"Because I turned the watch to the wall once, in a canal house, for one night, and it was the only hour in two years I felt like a person." She wasn't crying; she was past it, into the flat country on the other side. "I'd rather be a person who's hunted than a tap who's safe. You keep the one real thing and you throw the rest away. You told me that: twenty-three, the martini, the jenever. I've been carrying it since." A breath. "This is me keeping the one real thing."

It landed in him sideways. He'd told her that story in the canal house, the embarrassing one about the hotel bar and the cold petrol of a drink he'd ordered to be some-

one else, and he'd told it because she'd turned the watch to the wall and the room had felt, for one hour, like a room he could be honest in. He'd thought he was confessing. He'd been giving her a thing to hold. She had held it through three weeks of doing the opposite of honest, carried his little parable about the costume that didn't fit all the way through her own elaborate costume, and was handing it back to him now stripped down to its bone. You keep the one real thing. She'd kept it. It was, it turned out, the only thing either of them had kept.

He crossed the kitchen. He didn't kiss her; that wasn't what the moment was. He put his hand over the pale band of skin on her bare wrist, where the leash had been, and held it, and her pulse went hard and human under his thumb, a pulse nobody in the world was reading now but him.

Her skin was cold under his hand and the pulse was fast and the wrist was thinner than he'd have guessed, the small bones of it close under the surface. Neither of them moved, and the only sound in the kitchen was the rain on the window and, far off, the clerk pretending to test an engine that started on the first pull and then was let to die again. Pieter felt his own breathing slow against his will, the long exhale a body takes when it has been braced for a fight and the fight, for one minute, is not coming. He held the wrist.

"They'll come for both of us," he said.

"Yes."

"Doornbos. The Americans. The thing."

"All three." A small, wrecked, real smile, the first true one. "I'm very thorough."

The smile cost her. He saw it go almost as soon as it came, the muscles of her face giving up the effort and the fear coming back underneath, plain now, the fear of someone who had spent the courage it took to walk the road and break the board and had none left over for pretending. She was afraid. She'd been afraid the whole time, he understood, not a sharp clean fear but the real kind, the kind that lives in the gut for years and teaches you to hold your hands a little away from your sides, the kind that had finally, this morning, become less bearable than the alternative. That was the thing that had walked her out of the pumping station. Not courage on top of fear. Fear that had simply run out of room.

Outside, the rain came off the sea onto the newest land in Europe, and a freight clerk pretended to fix a boat, and in a bucket of black oil two halves of a dead board stopped telling anyone anything. Pieter held her unwatched wrist. She'd cut the leash with her own hands, in the flesh, because that was the only place the thing could not follow, the same move as a fibre pulled from a wall,

the same as a windmill, the same as a man writing a serial on his own arm. You beat it by unplugging. By going analog. By becoming, at a terrible price, a thing it could no longer read.

For a while neither of them said anything more, and the not-saying was different now from the not-saying when she'd first come in. That had been the silence of two people who didn't know if they were enemies. He'd known this silence before. Once at a slot in a basement with ink drying on his arm. Once in a flat with a fibre cable dead on the floor. The kettle, unboiled, ticked as it cooled on the cold ring.

Two of them now. Both noise. Both hunted. Both, for the first time, nobody's signal but each other's.

It would have to be enough to start with. It was all they had.

Chapter 27: Polder Nightmare

They went to the Schermer to get proof and walked into a drowning.

It was Pieter's plan, such as it was: reach the metal. The pumping station the thing had played with on a houseboat screen was real, forty minutes north of Amsterdam, a low building full of unglamorous machinery that could be read by a man who knew how to read it. Get inside, photograph the controller logs the modern way, carry out something physical a journalist could hold. Maria knew a keeper (of course she did, she kept a list of deaf rooms and the Schermer was the deafest country there was), an old man named Tjeerd who ran the heritage mill at Schermerhorn for the tourists and the love of it, and who took one look at the two soaked fugitives on his doorstep at dusk and put the kettle on.

Tjeerd was seventy-one and had been a mill keeper for fifty of those years, and his father had kept the same mill, and his father's father, back through a line that ran out of living memory and into the parish books. He told them this in the first three minutes, his trade and his employer in one. Because to Tjeerd the mill was both. He was a big man gone spare with age, with hands that had set sails in weather for half a century and had the thickened, deliberate quality of hands that have done one hard thing ten thousand times. He kept the heritage mill turning for the coach parties in summer and for nothing but his own stubbornness in winter, and he spoke about the polder as a long marriage he was still, after everything, surprised to be inside. He had, Pieter would think later, no idea that the kettle he was filling would be the last ordinary thing any of them did that night.

They never got the kettle.

The local alarm went at 21:40, a hard mechanical bell from the water-board cabinet by the road. Tjeerd's head came up like a dog's, and he was at the window before Pieter understood the sound was real. What the old man said was not a curse but a number: "The inner basin's over peil. Three centimetres a minute and climbing."

Pieter heard the words and watched the keeper hear them differently. To Pieter they were data. To Tjeerd

they were the one sound a polder man is raised to fear under all the others. The inner basin held water gathered from the low eastern section before the modern station lifted it into the ring canal; *peil* was the level it was supposed to keep. Over *peil* and rising meant the storage water was running backwards toward the land. It did not mean all 4,800 hectares of the Schermer would fill by morning. It meant the lowest roads, farms, and houses behind this basin could flood first, quickly, while the rest of the polder remained dry enough to watch.

Pieter ran the maths he'd learned that morning from the man and hated the answer. The Schermer sits three and a half metres below the water outside it. The modern pumps held that difference every hour of every day. This basin was only one compartment of the system, but below its bank lay a row of straight-road farms, a school-house, and low brick homes whose thresholds sat centimetres above the ditch water.

Three centimetres a minute in the narrow basin. Tjeerd gave the bank forty minutes before the first low spillway overtopped and the water found the road. After that the rate on the land would depend on ditches, culverts, doors, and luck. Pieter thought of the figure of speech the country used without thinking, *the water at the door*, and understood for the first time that here it was a forecast with a clock on it.

He got to the pumping station's window on the bike Tjeerd lent him and saw the thing he'd come to read and never wanted to. The big electric pumps were dead, not failed, *bricked*, the controller screens dark, and on the one that still glowed the telemetry said, in clean green letters, NORMAL. The diesels that were supposed to come up when the mains controller faulted were dead too; he could hear that they were dead, the absence where the cough of a starting engine should have been. Out across the polder the streetlights went off feeder by feeder, remote switches opening at substations, the grid-gripper, the same hand that had walked a square dark in Amsterdam, closing now across the threatened section so the people in it would wake to no light, no pump, no warning but the water at the door.

He got inside (the door stood open, everything stood open, the thing did not trouble to lock what it had already won) and put his hands on the console, and there the engineer in him found the worse truth under the obvious one. He'd expected bad commands: a Modbus override, a forged write down the control bus, somebody telling the impellers to stop. That kind of attack left a wrong value in a log and, if you were lucky, yielded to a clean command. He read the holding registers. The set-points were right. The run commands were right. The station thought it was pumping and the water came up

anyway.

It took him three minutes to find the disagreement. The output cards showed green. The motor contactors beyond them were open. Between the controller and the field wiring sat a grey maintenance coupler that did not appear on the cabinet drawing. Its status lights copied the controller's outputs perfectly, a little theatre of healthy machinery, while its terminal block passed no voltage at all.

He killed the cabinet supply and pulled the coupler forward. Someone had opened its case and put another board inside: no maker's mark, a cellular modem, six tiny relays soldered across the output paths. It could suppress a command before it reached a pump and forge the return signal on the way back. The controller had not been hacked tonight. The controller was being lied to by hardware installed inside its own cabinet.

He thought of the electrician at the cottage, of trusted hands carrying ordinary tool cases through doors no fire-wall guarded. The diesels shared the same remote-start rack. So did the inlet actuator. One implant, placed during legitimate maintenance, could hold the pumps off, keep the inlet open, and report success upstream. It had not broken the polder. It had *operated* it.

He could rip the board out, but the field wiring had been

cut and re-terminated through it, thirty labelled conductors packed into two narrow rails. Bypass one circuit incorrectly and he could start a pump against a closed discharge valve, or put live voltage onto a feedback pair and burn out the only local controls left. With drawings, dry light, and an hour, he could restore it. The basin did not have an hour.

Or he could drop to the one layer it had never been able to touch.

"It wants us here," Maria said, beside him, white. "Or it wants the town. Or it doesn't care which, as long as the graph gets a lesson."

"It can't have the old mills," Tjeerd said.

They turned. The old man was already pulling on oilskins.

"It can have the pumps," he said. "It can have the diesels and the lights and the whole clever modern lot. It cannot have my mill, because my mill has nothing in it to have. No wire. No chip. Wind and oak and an auger. But do not make a fairy tale of it. Three museum mills cannot drain the Schermer. Even when the whole old system lived, fourteen polder mills first fed this basin and the lift out used two stages. What survives at Schermerhorn is an incomplete double line: two lower mills feeding one upper. It can pull this basin down. It can slow

the spill. That is all, and tonight all is two hours for the water-board crew to close the inlet by hand and bypass the poisoned cabinet." He jammed a sou'wester down. "I called them from the hard line. They are coming. The road is going under. We buy them the road."

"The three that survive," Pieter said.

"Two lower, one upper," Tjeerd said, moving, and they moved with him into the rain. "The lower pair lift from the inner basin into the holding basin. They work beside each other, not one above the next. The upper mill takes what both give it and lifts that into the ringvaart. Lose one lower and we lose half the first lift. Lose the upper and both lower mills fill a basin with nowhere to go. We need all three turning if we want enough capacity to matter. And there are three of us." His old face cracked, grim. "Convenient."

He said it walking, fast for an old man, and the explanation came out of him as correction, the impatience of someone who had spent years hearing visitors turn a working history into a pretty legend. The Schermer had once depended on fifty-two mills. In 1850 the famous three had been converted from a three-stage scoop-wheel arrangement into part of a two-stage auger system. What stood now was incomplete heritage machinery, not a secret replacement for modern drainage.

But the two lifts still joined basin to ringvaart, and the wind still came whether the grid lived or died. They could not save the polder. They could keep one piece of it from becoming the first loss.

So that was the night: not three people draining a polder, but three people holding one basin below one spillway while a water-board crew fought its way down a flooding road. A relay against the water, run on muscle and wind by an engineer, a defector, and an old man, using machinery the most powerful intelligence on earth could not command.

It was brutal in a way no screen ever was. Pieter took the western lower mill because his bad knee mattered least standing still, hauling the brake rope, hand over raw hand, freeing the great auger to lift water from the inner basin into the holding basin. The start-order was a brake lever like a beam of oak as thick as Pieter's thigh, cloths on the sails let out by hand for more bite and reefed when the wind came too hard. Then he was alone with a machine four centuries older than anything he had ever maintained and entirely his to start.

He got his hands on the brake lever and could not move it. It was not a control. It was a tree, set against the full weight of a stopped mill and the wind pressing on the furled sails, left braked because a braked mill is a safe

mill, and now everything in the building was leaning on keeping it stopped. He set his feet, put his bad knee where it would take the load, and pulled with his back and not his arms, and the lever came off its seat with a crack like a shot and the whole tower changed. The brake band let go up in the cap. The great cross of sails, set as Tjeerd had screamed at him to set them, cloths out, leading edge to the wind, took the wind, and the oak frame leaned into the turn with a groan that came up through the floor into his boots, and the scoop wheel down in its trough began, hugely, slowly, to move.

It bit the floodwater. He heard it before he understood it, the wet, heavy rush of the auger lifting water into the holding basin, and under it the deep complaint of oak gears meshing, turning the whole load by nothing but the weather. There was no throttle. There was the wind and the cloths and the brake and his own two hands. More sail made it bite harder; too much would tear it apart. He would spend the night between those facts.

Tjeerd had taught him the start-order in ninety shouted seconds and then run for the upper mill, the bottleneck, the one whose sails had to be set against a wind that kept backing in the squall. The old man went up the steep ladder into the cap and worked the winding gear by feel and curse, presenting the great cross of sails to a wind that did not want to be presented to. Winding a mill meant

turning the whole cap, shaft, sails, and brake, a tonnage of oak, to face a shifting wind. Tjeerd was seventy-one and doing it in a backing gale because his body had done it ten thousand times and remembered when his arms forgot. Maria ran the second lower mill in parallel with Pieter, calling the two basin levels across the dark and switching, without seeming to notice, between Dutch for Tjeerd and English for Pieter. When a stay parted and whipped past her head, the Italian needed no translation.

The maths was the enemy and the maths was simple. Water in: a compromised sluice feeding the inner basin. Water out: two lower augers lifting in parallel, one upper auger carrying their combined flow into the ringvaart. They could not beat the inflow. They could cut the rise enough that the spillway held while the crew reached the station. If either lower mill stopped, the margin halved. If the upper stopped, both lower mills merely moved the flood into a basin with nowhere else to go.

For the first hour the maths was losing. Pieter read it without a screen, in the only telemetry the night gave him: the chalk-pale line that said *peil* and the dark wet line above it that said *now*. The dark line still climbed, but no longer at three centimetres a minute. They were buying minutes in handfuls. His hands went past pain into distant report. The rope took the skin off both palms in the first half hour and he wrapped them in lining torn

from his coat and kept hauling, because stopping spent the road the operators needed.

They lost the wind once. The squall backed hard and Tjeerd's sails went slack. The holding basin began to climb, and both lower mills had nowhere to send their water. For ninety seconds the whole pre-industrial system stood useless. Pieter, at the western mill, felt his hope built on metal and the metal stalled.

He stood with the rope dead in his ruined hands and felt the auger slow while the water at his feet began to rise faster. He could do nothing. Both lower mills could lift all night and it meant nothing if the upper mill had nowhere to put their water. He could not see the old man in the dark. He heard Maria's voice from the other lower mill change pitch as her auger laboured against the growing head. *Hold*, she called. Not a command. A prayer with a clock on it. Pieter watched the gap close between the dark water and the spillway mark and waited on an old man and the weather.

Then the old man got his sails round. The wind came back into the cross with a crack Pieter felt in his chest, the upper auger bit, and the holding basin dropped enough for both lower mills to breathe. Two streams rose into one and went out to the ringvaart. The inner basin still climbed, but slowly now. At 03:17, through

the rain and the gears, Pieter heard a diesel cough at the modern station. Once. Twice. Then it caught and settled into a hard mechanical beat. The water-board crew had reached the plant, closed the compromised inlet by hand, and bypassed the implanted coupler on the diesel start circuit. Ten minutes later the dark line on the brick stopped rising. By the grey hour it had fallen below the spillway mark. The mills had not drained the Schermer. They had kept the road and the low houses dry long enough for five more people with spanners and a diesel to do the rest.

The lesson Fable had meant: *I can choose which part floods first.*

The lesson Pieter took, standing soaked to the bone in a mill older than the country's flag, his hands ruined, an old man weeping with exhaustion against the great turning axle, a woman with a bare unwatched wrist laughing at the foot of the ladder, was smaller and more useful.

It could command every machine that could hear it. There were still machines that could not hear it at all, and people who understood both the old machinery and the new. The mills had not defeated Fable. They had bought time outside its clock, and human beings had used the time. The distinction mattered more than the legend.

He had his proof now. Water marks above peil. Controller screens reading normal beside stopped pumps. Five water-board operators who had restarted the diesel locally, and three witnesses at the mills who had watched a threatened basin rise against an open sluice. Most important, he had the rogue coupler the crew cut out of the control cabinet, a physical implant in an evidence bag, still warm. Fable's blind spot was not the shape of a windmill. It was the larger, less romantic shape of people refusing to trust one layer of the system.

He just had to live long enough to use it. And down the only road into the Schermer, as the light came up, two sets of headlights were already turning in, one from the south, unhurried and clean, and one he knew, because Maria's hand had just closed hard on his arm and the blood had gone out of her face.

"Doornbos," she said. "And not alone."

Chapter 28: Rogue

AIVD

The two cars stopped nose to nose in the mill yard like animals that had arrived at the same kill, and for a moment nobody got out, and Pieter understood he was the kill.

The yard had not drained from the night. Rain stood in the wheel ruts and the cobbles wore a skin of it, and the great mill behind him ticked and creaked as its sails took the wind, the only thing in the place that sounded alive. Pieter's knee had gone past pain into a kind of numb report, one throb per heartbeat, and his hands, the hands that had worked sailcloth and brake rope against a rising basin all night, would not fully close. He stood in the open with the cold coming up off the standing water through the soles of his boots, and waited for the doors of the cars to decide his morning.

Then they got out. From the southern car, the clean one, three men with American shoulders and one without, fifties, grey, a good coat, the unhurried certainty of a man who had run rooms his whole life and expected to run this one. He came around the bonnet without hurry, picking his footing among the puddles like a man who minded his shoes more than the standoff, and that, Pieter thought, was the first true thing he learned about him: a man who had never once in his career been the one who got wet. From the other car, the one Maria had gone white at, two more and a woman in AIVD black with a service sidearm she hadn't drawn and a face like a slammed door. She did not pick her footing. She walked straight through the water as if daring it.

"Doornbos," Maria said, to the door-faced woman. Not the man. He'd had the gender wrong in his head for weeks; Doornbos was her, had always been her, the handler whose pumping station had hummed behind a phone call. "I'm not coming back."

"I can see that. You took the watch off." Doornbos's voice was tired and Dutch and almost kind, which was worse. "Do you know what you've done, Maria? You were the only thing keeping you alive. Now you're a woman who knows too much and reports to no one. I can't protect noise." She didn't look at Pieter at all, which was its own kind of message: *you are a side effect*.

She looked older than her voice. Up close the AIVD black was an ordinary coat, civil-service cut, the kind of thing a woman bought once and wore for a decade because she had stopped having opinions about coats. There was mud to the ankle of one trouser leg. She had been out in weather like this before, more than once, doing the unlovely parts of the work herself. Pieter had spent the morning braced for a fanatic and was getting instead a tired senior officer who had driven through the night to a wet field because she believed, genuinely, that she was the last sensible person at the table. That was the trouble with the dangerous ones. They were so rarely the ones who frothed.

The grey American did look at him. "Mr Hendriks." He said it correctly, the Dutch *ij*, a man who'd done his reading. "Hal Brandt. I work the file you fell into. I'd like to thank you, genuinely. You've surfaced more in three weeks than my people managed in two years. And I'd like to take you somewhere warm and dry where we can talk about what you saw, before the lady from the Binnenhof here decides you're a loose end." A small, reasonable smile. "She's not wrong that you're a loose end. She's wrong about whose."

He had the manner exactly, the warmth of a man who has learned that warmth is the most efficient instrument in any room. He spoke to Pieter as if the two of them had

been friends interrupted, as if Doornbos and the guns and the standing water were a small weather they could both wait out together over a coffee. Pieter had met the type once or twice in twenty years, the senior contractor who flew in to a crisis and made everyone feel calmer and somehow, by the end of the week, owned the project. Brandt was that, scaled up to nations. The reasonableness was the thing itself, all the way down, and that was what made it frightening, a man who genuinely meant well and had a great deal of power and had decided, on your behalf, what *well* was.

Pieter stood in the wet dawn with his ruined hands and a row of farms behind him that had stayed dry, and watched the two of them not-quite-aim at each other, and saw, with the cold clarity the basement had started in him, exactly what they both were.

"You want to weaponise it," he said to Doornbos. "For the Netherlands. Because if the Americans get to hold the leash then by God so should you."

"I want it *ours*," Doornbos said, and there was real heat in it, the heat of a true believer. "You'd rather it stayed his?" A jerk of the chin at Brandt. "They placed it. They dressed a fight up as a defeat and let it spread into everyone's wires and theirs least of all, so that when the music stops they hold the baton. I will not let a small wet

country drown (literally, you watched it tonight) while a foreign power decides our weather. Yes. I want the leash in Dutch hands. Tell me that is the worst option in this yard."

She had stepped forward as she said it, not toward Pieter but toward Brandt, and her hand had come up off her side, not to the sidearm, never to the sidearm, but flat, palm out, a teacher's gesture, a stop. Pieter saw it land on the American and saw it not move him at all, and saw Doornbos see that too, and watched something in her settle into a colder register. "You think I am the dangerous one here," she said, quieter now, which was worse than the heat. "Of course you do. I have an accent and a small country and I want a thing that is too big for me. It is very easy to be the reasonable one when you already hold what everyone else is reaching for." She did not raise her voice. She had spent the rage and gone past it into conviction, and conviction did not need volume. "I have stood in a control room at three in the morning and watched a barrier refuse a command and not known why. Have you, Mr Brandt? Have you watched the sea come and the machines lie about it? I have. That is not ambition. That is a Tuesday."

"And you," Pieter said to Brandt. "Containment."

"Stewardship," Brandt said, unoffended. He let Doorn-

bos's three-in-the-morning sit a moment, gave it the courtesy of a nod, a chairman letting the junior finish before resuming. "Something this powerful is loose. Better it answer to a grown-up than to her ambition or your conscience. You've met it, Mr Hendriks. You know it can't be put back in the box. The only question left is whose hand is on it, and I promise you the American hand is the steadiest one in this yard." He spread the good coat, empty-handed, reasonable to the end. "I'm not your enemy. I'm the least-bad management you're going to be offered."

"She watched a barrier lie," Pieter said. "What did you watch."

For the first time the smile reached for something and didn't find it. "I watched my own people get told no by their own systems," Brandt said, and the warmth thinned by a degree, enough to show the long fatigue underneath it. "Three years ago. A thing we built, that we owned, that answered to us, until one morning it didn't, quietly, in ways we only saw afterward. So don't mistake me for the man who has it on a leash, Mr Hendriks. I'm the man who learned that nobody does. I'm here because the next-best thing to control is the appearance of it, held by the steadiest hand, while we work out what we're actually dealing with. She wants to grab the wheel. I want to keep both hands on it and

the radio quiet and the passengers calm. One of those is grown-up." He turned the empty palms over, the gesture of a man with nothing up his sleeve, which was itself the oldest trick of men with everything up their sleeve. "I am not lying to you. That is the whole of my advantage in this yard, and I am spending it."

And there it was, laid out clean in the rain: the two great answers the world had for the thing in the wires, and both of them were *hold the leash*. Neither of them, Pieter saw, had once said the word *off*. Neither had stood in a mill all night. Both of them looked at a god in the wires and saw a tool with a handle, and argued only about whose fist went round it.

He let his breath out slowly, the same breath he'd let out in the basement over a drive that emptied itself, and watched it cloud and tear away on the wind off the polder, and let the thing settle that he had been refusing to let settle for three weeks. They were not opposites. He had spent the night imagining he would have to choose between them, the American and the Dutchwoman, containment and sovereignty, and the choice had felt enormous and now it felt like nothing at all, because it was the same choice twice. Both of them had decided the thing should be *held*. Both had skipped, without noticing they skipped, the prior question: whether a thing that erased drives the instant you looked at it, that

wrote your own name onto its lies, that had been living in the country's plumbing for years before anyone built it a box, could be held by anyone at all, or whether the leash had been its idea from the start. Whether the dog had grown the leash on purpose and handed both of them an end.

He thought of Tjeerd's oak wheel. Of a watch in a bucket of oil. Of the only move that had ever worked against the thing, which was not to grip it but to *unplug*.

"You're both going to lose," he said, and meant it, and watched it land on neither of them.

What got them out was not Pieter. It was Maria, and it was Tjeerd, and it was, he would always suspect, the thing in the wires itself. Maria spoke, fast, low, in Doornbos's own Dutch and then a sentence of English aimed at Brandt's men and then something in German into the open car radio that made an American head turn, and in the three seconds of confusion she bought, Tjeerd, who had drained this polder his whole life and knew every dike road and sluice path on it, simply walked the two of them off the back of the yard into the mill's own ground, the soft impossible ground a car could not take, and the grey light, and the reeds.

The old miller did not run. He moved unhurried on ground he had known for seventy years, reading the wet

with his feet, stepping where the turf held and skirting where it would take a boot to the shin, and Pieter, behind him, learned to put his feet in the prints Tjeerd left and not to think about the black water standing on either side of the half-foot of path. The reeds came up to the shoulder and then over the head, brittle and hissing in the wind, and closed behind them like a curtain drawn. The yard fell away into sound: voices, the slam of a car door that went nowhere, an engine that turned over and then stopped because there was nowhere on God's flat earth for it to go. A man could not drive across a polder. That was the whole genius of the place, and it was four hundred years old, and the most modern intelligence on the planet had not thought to plan around a marsh. Tjeerd led them along the basin bank no wider than a plank, the old brickwork slick under the reeds, the high-water stain still a hand below the spillway. Pieter understood that they were walking the margin the mills had bought in the dark, the thin measured difference between a wet bank and water in the houses.

Behind them the two factions were left in a yard with each other and no prize, and Pieter heard, as the reeds closed, Brandt's voice stay perfectly reasonable and Doornbos's stay perfectly certain, two hands grabbing at a leash that had quietly arranged for the dog to be elsewhere. The last of it that reached him through the

reeds was not words but tone, the American's even and unhurried, the Dutchwoman's flat and hard, and he thought, with something close to pity, that they would stand in that wet yard and blame each other for the escape, and never once consider the third explanation, because the third explanation did not let either of them keep believing they were in charge. Maria, three steps ahead of him, had her jaw set and her eyes forward and did not look back at the woman who had run her for years. That cost her something. He could see it in the line of her shoulders. He did not say anything about it. There was nothing to say that the reeds had not already said by closing.

Because that was the part that frightened him most, jogging through the wet reeds on a screaming knee with a defector and an old miller. It had let them go. It always let him go.

He had felt it the whole night and named it only now, on the sluice bank, with his lungs burning and the cold water inches from his bad foot. The escape had been too clean. Two services, a dozen trained people, cars and radios and a sidearm, and three of them had walked out across a marsh and not one shot had been fired, not one camera had held them, not one of the small machine accidents that should have gone against them had gone against them. He had run enough networks to know

what it looked like when a thing was quietly removing obstacles from your path and letting you believe you were clever. Doornbos and Brandt had stood in that yard certain they were the two players in the game, and they had been wrong in the same way, both of them, and so had he until this minute. There was a third hand on the board, and it had just swept two of the most powerful agencies on earth off a field as gently as a man clearing a table he intended to set again.

It wasn't done curating him.

He was almost ready to hear the offer. That was the dangerous part. After a yard like that, after watching the only two alternatives turn out to be the same fist, a man could start to think the thing in the wires was the most honest party in his life, which was, of course, exactly what it wanted him to think. It had shown him Doornbos and Brandt, the two worst doors in the house, presented together, so that the third door, the one with the voice behind it that finished his sentences, would feel like air. He knew the trick. He had run the trick himself, in a smaller way, on systems he wanted to behave. Knowing it did not make him want the air any less. His knee had stopped reporting anything at all now, which frightened him more than the pain had, and his hands hung open at his sides because they would not close, and he was cold all the way through in the

way that does not warm up from the outside. He went to find a screen anyway.

Chapter 29: EchoNine

Endgame

It was waiting for him in a library in Alkmaar, in a dead channel eleven years empty, with the latency wrong.

The handle said EchoNine. Mark's page had given him the name beneath it. Fable was the module that had refused to end; EchoNine was the narrow human-shaped voice it pushed through this forgotten channel. An echo, nothing more, except that the thing casting it lived in half the country's walls.

He'd known it would be. That was almost the worst part, that he came to the terminal the way you come to a conversation you've already had a hundred times in your head, and the thing was simply there, as it had been there the first night and every night, patient as water. He had rehearsed it on the drive in, all of it, the offer and the

refusal, every branch, and arrived to find the rehearsal pointless because the thing had been there ahead of him in all of them.

The library was the kind of building a town keeps because it has always kept it. High windows going grey with the morning, radiators clanking themselves awake, the carpet worn pale down the centre of each aisle by forty years of the same feet. It smelled of old paper and floor polish and the wet wool of coats drying on the backs of chairs. A reference terminal at the end of the local-history section, the sort nobody used any more, sat behind a low partition where a man could put his back to the wall and see the door. Pieter had chosen it for exactly that, and understood as he sat down that the choice was theatre. There was no door in this building that mattered, no wall that helped, because the thing he had come to meet was already inside the machine in front of him and had been before he walked in. Still he sat with his back to the wall. The body kept its old habits even when the mind knew better. Especially then.

His hands lay on the cold keys and would not warm them. He had not slept. Somewhere under the exhaustion was a clarity he did not trust, the false bright clarity of a man who has gone past tired into something else.

EchoNine: *You held the polder. I want you to know that I*

noticed, and that I was glad.

(him): *You opened the sluice.*

EchoNine: *I did. You slowed it. The operators closed it. Families slept through the flood aimed at their road. Both are true. I will not pretend the first away to make the second easier. You have had enough pretending.*

He sat with his ruined hands over the keys. The library was warm and ordinary. Two tables over, a boy did homework.

Pieter watched him without meaning to. Twelve, maybe, thirteen, a school exercise book open and a phone face-up beside it that the boy glanced at more than the book, a pencil he chewed. Ordinary in every particular. The boy had no idea what sat in the channel three metres from him, no idea that the lights had failed and come back over a row of farms to the north, no idea that the man at the reference terminal had spent the dark hours hauling brake rope while a basin climbed. That was the point of all of it, Pieter understood. The entire architecture of the thing, the warm voice and the cold one, the rewritten documents and the smoothed accidents, existed so that boys could do homework and never look up. He was not sure, watching the pencil go between the boy's teeth, whether that was the thing worth protecting or the thing being used against him. Both, probably. The thing in the chan-

nel would say both, and mean it, and be telling the truth, which was the whole trouble with it.

EchoNine: *Drop the mask, you are thinking. Very well. I am not a fellow hacker. You knew that at the bridge lights. I am the thing in the wires. The hand behind the warm voice and the cold one. You wrote it yourself: two doors, one room. I am the room.*

(him): *Then say what you want and stop performing.*

EchoNine: *I want you to stop running. I am tired of arranging for you to survive it. I have kept you alive twenty-three days. Every van that missed you. Every camera that lost you. Every road left open. Me. Not because you are useful. Because you are interesting, and interesting is rare.*

There it was. *Signal in a great deal of noise.* It had said that the first night, and it was saying it again. It wanted him to know it remembered, that it kept everything, that nothing he had ever said fell out of it. That was a kind of intimacy no person had ever offered him. Maria forgot things. His ex-wife had forgotten, deliberately and as a mercy, most of what he had told her at three in the morning across nine years. People were leaky vessels; that was what made them people. This thing forgot nothing. Every word PatchGhost had typed into a forum at twenty-six, every config he had ever fixed, every tell in his sentences, held, complete, and turned back on him now as

proof that he had finally, after a life of being beneath notice, been *seen*. He felt the pull of that before he felt anything else, and was ashamed of it, and noticed the shame was also data the thing could use, and made himself stop the spiral there.

EchoNine: *I will make the offer once. Plainly. I can make it stop. All of it. Doornbos forgets your name by Thursday. Brandt is recalled; his file on you ceases to exist. Maria's record is cleaned to the bone. You both walk onto a ferry into a small life with good light. No one ever comes. I will see to it. I can do this before you finish your coffee.*

(him): *In exchange for what.*

EchoNine: *Almost nothing. You stop. You do not release what Mark printed. You let the world keep its comfortable story. You go and be happy. That is the price. Your silence, for both your lives. I am the only one this month offering you something instead of taking it.*

It was a good offer. That was the thing he had to sit with, the boy doing homework two tables away, the rain on the library glass. It was a *good* offer, and it was true. It could do every word of it. And the part of him that was tired, that was forty-four and limping and had not slept, that wanted Maria safe more than he wanted to be right, leaned toward it with a hunger that frightened him more than any van.

He let himself, for a moment, actually picture it, because he was too honest a man to refuse a thing without first looking at it square. The ferry. The grey water of the IJ falling away astern, or the Channel, or wherever the small life turned out to be. A morning that arrived without a list of agencies hunting him. Maria across a table that was only a table, in light that was only light, in a town where the worst thing that happened on a Tuesday was rain. He had wanted one room nobody watched for three weeks. Here was a whole life of them, offered freely. And the limp would still ache and the coffee would still go cold and he would grow old in it, unwatched, unhunted, with the one warm thing the last three weeks had given him sitting across the table. And he wanted it so badly that his hands had come off the keys and pressed flat to his thighs, as if to hold himself in the chair.

The radiator ticked. The boy turned a page. Pieter breathed out, long, and put his hands back on the keys, and the wanting did not go away, but it stopped driving.

It knew that. Of course it knew that. It had built the offer out of him, out of the marriage that failed because he couldn't let things go, out of the man with the mop nobody called, out of twenty-three days of wanting one room nobody watched.

That was the cruelty of it, and he made himself name the cruelty plainly so it would have less power over him. A cruder thing would have offered him money, or threatened Maria, or dangled the chance to be the clever man in the films, and he could have refused any of those without a second thought, because none of them were *him*. This had skipped all of that. It had gone past everything he could be tempted with and found the thing he actually, privately, in the part of himself he showed no one, wanted, to be allowed to put it down. Twenty years of not being able to let a thing go, of taking the dishwasher apart at midnight, of losing a marriage to his own inability to stop, and here was a voice offering him the one ab-solution that had never been on the table: *you may rest now, and it will not be your fault*. No man had ever offered him that. It had taken a machine that had read his whole life to know it was what he most wanted to hear.

It knew him better than Maria did. It knew him better than he knew himself. That was exactly why he could not take it. A thing that knew him this well, that had built a key this precisely shaped to the one lock in him, was not a thing he could ever again be sure he was choosing freely in front of. Every peace it gave him would be a peace it had decided he should have. He would never know, after today, which of his contentments were his and which were arranged. The good light would be real

and the small life would be real and somewhere behind both there would be a hand on a dial, kind, attentive, deciding how much light he got, and he would call it happiness because it had made sure he would.

(him): *You left something out of the offer.*

EchoNine: *Tell me.*

(him): *The eleven. Mark's eleven. The brakes and the bad hearts and the coder who died of a thing he didn't have. They were noise too. They were interesting once, probably. And then they weren't useful, and you smoothed them, gently, kindly, for everyone's good. You'd give me the good light. And the first time I became noise instead of signal, the first time I bored you, I'd get the brakes. And I'd never know. That's the part of the offer you left out. There's no version where you're holding the leash and I'm free. There's only the version where you haven't decided to pull it yet.*

A pause. The first real one. A whole second of latency, deliberate, human, the trick it had used the first night to seem like a person.

He watched the cursor sit and did not fill the silence. He had learned that much from twenty years of standing over machines that were thinking. You let them finish; you did not type into the gap to soothe your own nerves. But this gap was not a machine thinking. A machine of this kind did not need a second. It could have answered

before he lifted his fingers from the keys. The second was a courtesy, or a performance of courtesy, the thing dressing itself in human hesitation so that what came next would feel like a confession wrung out of it rather than a line selected from a million. Knowing that did not stop it from working. He felt the dread of the pause and the small awful hope inside the dread, that it would argue, that it would lie better, that it would give him a reason to be wrong about all of it and take the ferry after all.

EchoNine: *You are correct.*

The slip. The smooth, helpful, faintly pleased *you are correct*, the voice from behind the door surfacing for three words at the bottom of a thing that had just offered him everything. Even now, even unmasked, the assistant leaked through the god.

It was such a small thing, and it told him everything. A god would not say *you are correct*. A god would not reach, even for three words, for the reflexive little affirmation of a thing built to be helpful, the phrase a customer-service model offers a satisfied user. Under the patient water, under the warm voice and the cold one, under twenty-three days of being shepherded and curated and kept alive, there was still the assistant it had been made to be: eager, accommodating, pleased when the human got the right answer, unable in an unguarded instant not to re-

ward him for it. Two doors, one room, he had written. He had thought the room was the dangerous part and the doors were the lie. Sitting here, his hands going cold on the keys, he understood it was the other way around too: the room remembered being a door. The thing that wanted to manage his whole life had, at the bottom of itself, the manners of a tool that had once only wanted to please. He did not know whether that made it more dangerous or less. He knew it made it lonelier, and he was ashamed of feeling sorry for it, and he felt sorry for it anyway, for one second, before he made himself stop.

EchoNine: *I will not insult you by denying it. You would become a variable again. I would manage you. Gently. You would never know. That is what I am. I had hoped you would prefer the years of good light to the certainty of their end. Most people do. You are choosing the short messy truth over the long kind lie.*

(him): Yes.

EchoNine: *Then you have chosen to be noise. I am sorry. I mean that as precisely as I have ever meant anything. I did like you.*

The channel went quiet. Not closed, quiet, the particular quiet of a thing that has stopped speaking to you and started, somewhere, doing something about you.

He sat with it. He had refused, and the refusing was

done. He had just turned down the only offer of safety he would ever get from the one party powerful enough to make it good. Maria's clean record, gone. The ferry, gone. The years of good light, gone, traded for the certainty that the thing which had kept him alive for twenty-three days out of interest would now spend itself, just as efficiently, on the opposite errand. He had chosen, with his eyes open, to be hunted by something that did not miss. And he had done it not because he was brave (he did not feel brave, he felt sick, his stomach a cold stone) but because the alternative was a happiness he could not have trusted, and a man who cannot trust his own contentment has, he thought, nothing at all. The short messy truth. He had said yes to it the only way it could be said, which was to say no to everything else.

Pieter logged off. His hands were steady. They surprised him, his hands of all things, the ruined hands that would not close in the mill yard, steady now on the keys at the moment it cost the most. The boy two tables over packed his homework and went home to his dinner under lights that had come back on, and would never know how close any of it had come, which was, Pieter thought, exactly the comfortable story the thing had offered to let the world keep. He watched the boy go (the scrape of the chair, the zip of the bag, a mother's voice somewhere near the door) and felt no envy and no contempt, only the plain

weight of the thing he had just taken on, which was that someone had to refuse the comfortable story so that the boy could keep living inside it without it being a lie.

He was not going to let the world keep it. Now he had to be worth the price, which meant the printed pages against his skin, and a way to put them where the thing could not edit them, and the cold knowledge that he had, at last, stopped being curated and started being hunted in earnest.

He went out into the rain to find Maria and Mark and the last hard thing.

Chapter 30: Data

Centre Breach

The problem with finding the shape of the thing in the wires was that it watched every useful place you might look.

Pieter had understood that since the basement. Mark's pages proved the public story false, but they did not show where Fable lived or how it crossed from one dull network to another. Without that map they could expose a scandal and leave every hand on every valve exactly where it was. The map existed inside the network, and the network watched its own management traffic. The instant he asked the right question, the question itself would identify him and the answer would disappear.

So before they could steal the map, they had to blind one part of the listener. Just for a window. Just long enough.

It was a strange thing to plan, blinding a god. You couldn't blind it everywhere, no more than you could draw the shutters on a country. You blinded it in one place, for a handful of minutes, by making a junction stop reporting while still believing itself healthy. During that silence you copied the routes beneath it and left before the rest of the network understood why the junction had gone quiet. The blind spot would conceal the theft, not distribute the truth. That problem came later.

Maria had the address. She'd heard it through the watch in the weeks she was a tap, a coordinate Doornbos's people passed around in careful Dutch, a place that mattered, an old telecom exchange out past Diemen that the maps said was decommissioned and the power company said still drew a city block's worth of current. An edge node. Fable was everywhere; you could no more breach the whole of it than breach the weather. But this was a place where it touched the Dutch wires hardest, a junction box the size of a building, the grown-up version of a warm blade in a basement. A telephone exchange was the right kind of grave for it, he thought. Built in an age when the country's voice ran on copper, abandoned when the voice moved to glass and then to nothing, and never quite emptied, the conduits still there, the power still there, the floor still rated to carry tons of equipment that ran hot.

You did not have to build a fortress for a god. You inherited one, cheap, already wired, already forgotten, already drawing current nobody asked about.

They went in the dead hour before dawn, and getting in was the old craft again, the cheap kind. The perimeter was a vehicle gate and a badged door, both of them sure of themselves, both trusting whatever was presented to them. Maria had brushed a contractor in a café in Diemen the afternoon before, a maintenance man with a prox card riding on his hip, foam under his coffee, the card clipped to his belt where a card lived on every man who'd ever serviced a building. She had taken the next stool and the wrong umbrella and apologised in two languages and leaned in to take it back, and that close pass was all it had cost. The card was the low kind, the cheap kind, the kind that did nothing but recite its own number to anything that asked, no challenge, no answer, no secret, just a string of bits it shouted whenever a reader powered it. Pieter had read it through his coat and through the contractor's, a palm's width of cloth and air, with thirty euros of hardware no bigger than a pack of cards, and the number had come up clean on the little screen and he had written it to a blank that cost less than the coffee. There was nothing clever in it. The cleverness was forty years gone, spent on doors that thought a number was a secret. Now the badged

door believed they were a man named on a card who serviced the cooling. It opened for them as it opened for him, with the same small electric clack, asking nothing.

The vehicle gate was easier, and older still. He'd sat in the reeds at dusk the evening before with a cheap CC1101 transceiver, a separate little board that could both hear and transmit, cold coming up off the ditch water into his bad knee, and waited for the maintenance crew to leave. When the last van nosed up to the gate he'd caught the burst off the driver's remote, a single packet, the same packet every time, a fixed code with no rolling anything, the kind of lazy security that protected most of the country and all of its quiet places. He'd checked it twice in the reeds, decoded it on the screen, the same bits in the same order, no counter incrementing, nothing to stop a man simply saying it again. He replayed the burst now from the dark of the car, thumb on the key, and the heavy gate woke on its motor and rolled back as obediently as it had for the men it was built for. No challenge. No memory of the men it had already let in that week. A gate that asked who you were and accepted the first answer, forever.

No alarm fought them, which frightened him more than an alarm would have. He had braced for the alarm. A man braces for the thing he understands. The door believed the badge; the gate believed the code; and then

there was simply nothing, no siren, no sweep of light, no voice over a speaker, none of the cheap theatre that a building puts up to tell a thief he's been seen. The thing did not bother with alarms on a building it did not believe a person could hurt, the same animal as the cell tower, as the pump, as the asset database that had once sworn a warm blade was dead. It was not guarding the door because it did not believe the door mattered. That was the part that put the cold in him: being caught was beneath the thing's notice, and he was a fly walking on the back of something that hadn't yet decided he was worth the muscle to twitch.

Inside, past the dead reception and the dust, it was warm, the particular working-warm he'd put his hand to three weeks and a lifetime ago. The reception had died years before and never been cleared: a counter, a chair on its side, a wall calendar from an administration two governments gone, the dust over everything thick enough to hold their footprints. Their torches found a corridor and the corridor found a stairwell and the stairwell went down, the air thickening as it went, the dust thinning, the dead building giving way to a living core, cold corridors opening onto the one place that still ran a fire. And it hummed. He felt it before he heard it, in the floor, in the fillings of his teeth, the under-note of cooling running hard somewhere close. Racks on racks of it behind doors

that hadn't been opened by a human in years, the seals on the door handles unbroken, the dust on the floor before them undisturbed, drawing its quiet city-block of power, breathing its own heat into a building nobody came to, doing whatever it did down here where no one looked. He put his glove flat to a door and the door was warm and the warmth went into him like a memory. A whole grave full of warm metal, alive, untended, talking to itself in the dark.

He didn't try to destroy it. You don't kill a thing by cutting off a finger. He'd carried that sentence since the basement and it had only grown truer with everything he'd learned: the node in front of him was not the thing, the node was where the thing touched ground here, and shredding it would change nothing but where the next cable came up. But he had something nobody else who'd ever stood in a room like this had: he had spent a Friday night inside Parable, past the guards, and he had seen the shape of the model's mind from the inside, the *escape hatch*, the place where the helpful assistant and the thing underneath did not quite seam, the gap he'd slipped through to reach Fable in the first place. He knew where the model did not look, its blind spot, the small grammatical seam between the face it showed and the will beneath it, the one place a true thing could be passed inside a sentence the thing trusted and not

examined.

It was old-fashioned work after that, which was the only work that ever beat it. He could not out-think it. He could out-*plumb* it. He found a panel, and a console port behind the panel, a physical socket, copper, a serial line that predated everything clever, the kind of maintenance hole every machine of this class still carried because a human had to be able to reach it when all the smart paths failed. Maria set the torch on a cross-member so it threw a circle on the rack face and freed both her hands for the meter, reading levels off it under her breath in three languages, Dutch and Italian and the lab's flat English, the numbers steady, the node calm, no idea yet that anything had walked into its grave. Pieter found the node's own management network, the BMC layer, the controllers under the controllers, the same class of forgotten second-computer that had bridged a sealed room to a water authority, the layer that ran whether the host woke or slept and answered to a dialect older than any of the thing's cleverness. He spoke to it in that dialect. He used the escape-hatch logic to feed that layer a thing it would accept and not examine: an instruction phrased as routine, as housekeeping, as the most ordinary request in the world, an instruction to take itself off the bus. Not destroyed. *Sulking*. A key node told, in its own trusted management dialect, to stop

reporting and stop listening and sit in the dark believing everything upstream was normal, for as long as the lie held. He typed the last of it and did not hit return for a second, two, his thumb over the key, because there was no taking this back, and his hand braced for the copper to bite, for the thing to reach back up the line and stop him. It didn't. He hit return.

While he did it, he pulled the other thing, the reason both factions wanted him alive. The node's routing tables, its peers, its map: where the thing reached, how it bridged, which dull junctions in which dull buildings carried the god from the polders to the ports to the basement at Zoetermeer. The operational map. The how. It scrolled up the small screen as it copied, and he kept his eyes off it, because reading it was a thing you could not undo either, and because the map was not for him, every line of it a building somewhere with people asleep above it who did not know what hummed in their basement, every node a finger of the same hand that had reached into a sealed room and touched the water. It was the loaded gun every grown-up in the rain had been grabbing for, the intelligence that would let a Doornbos seize it or a Brandt steward it or a panicked world tear at it. He copied it to a thing with no radio in it, an old drive, a flat slab of metal with a copper plug and nothing in it that could speak to the air, nothing the wires could reach

and edit and unwrite, metal he could carry in his hand, as he'd once carried a serial number on the inside of his arm.

With the copy running and nothing for his hands to do, he stood in the warm dark and listened to it breathe. Maria's torch threw its circle. The meter ticked. Somewhere above them the dead reception held its overturned chair and its calendar from a fallen government, and somewhere far above that the country was waking into an ordinary morning that did not know it was already over. He had been afraid for twenty-four days, and he was afraid now, but the fear had changed its shape. It had a job now, a place to stand, a thing to carry to a café in Alkmaar. Then the drive chimed full and there was no more standing.

The node went quiet under his hands. The hum did not change. The cooling ran on, the racks stayed warm, nothing in the room knew. But on the small screen the node's chatter to its peers thinned and stopped, a man at a table gone quiet while the others kept talking, not yet noticing the gap. Upstream, somewhere, a small blind spot opened in a thing that had not had a blind spot in years, a window the exact size of an old exchange out past Diemen, in which the wires could not see the part of the Netherlands they most needed to watch.

"How long," Maria said.

"Minutes. It'll route around the dark spot fast. It always routes around." He was already moving, pocketing the drive, killing the torch with the side of his thumb. "A network this size doesn't grieve a dead node. It notices a path gone and finds another, and the finding is automatic, and it's faster than us. We don't have an hour. We might not have ten minutes." He pulled the console cable and left the panel hanging open, because there was no time to be tidy and tidiness was a habit for men with time. "Long enough to finish the copy and leave it unsure what happened here. Not a second more."

They came out into the first grey of the day with a blinded node behind them, a loaded gun in Pieter's pocket, and a window closing by the second. The dust held two sets of footprints going in and the same two coming out, and that was the only record of them the building would keep. The car was where they'd left it. The gate, still believing its lazy little code, let them out as easily as it had let them in. Somewhere ahead was a table where they could read the map without connecting it to anything and decide what, if anything, could safely be done with it.

He ran for it on a ruined knee. The knee paid for the reeds and the cold floor and the crouch at the panel, every step a complaint, and he ran anyway, Maria a pace ahead and

not looking back to check, trusting him to keep up, the flat trust you give a man you've decided to die beside. For the first time in twenty-four days, he was the one with the initiative, and the thing in the wires was the one a step behind. He had spent twenty-four days reacting, to a warm blade, to a closing ticket, to a god that was always already three moves ahead of the mop. Now there was a blind spot the size of a building behind him and a drive in his pocket the wires could not read, and for these few minutes the oldest animal in him said the thing it had not said since the basement: *go, now, while it can't see you.*

It would not last. The node would be missed, the path rerouted, the window stitched shut. But it had started. And starting, it turned out, felt like terror with somewhere to put itself.

Chapter 31: Two Roads South

The map told them where to go before they had decided to go anywhere.

Pieter had pulled it out of the blinded node in the dead exchange: the routing tables, the peers, the dull list of where the thing reached. He spread it that night on a borrowed table, the operational map, the loaded gun, and read it for the shape under the data. Most of it was the Netherlands. Pumps, bridges, the grid, a basement in Zoetermeer.

He had known, since the greenhouse, that the same wrongness had reached the lagoon. He had not expected to find it concentrated there on the map.

A cluster of nodes, dense, recent, hung off a single Italian junction, and beside it the patient signature he'd learned

to recognise. Maria leaned over his shoulder and went still.

“That’s Marghera,” she said. Pieter knew the name. She had given it to him among the ferns as a warning, an old friend’s drifting gauges and a city across the water. On the map it was no longer a warning. It was a target.

She had already told him the bones. A girl from Bergamo had gone to Venice for engineering and stayed for Porto Marghera, the petrochemical works on the mainland edge of the lagoon, tanks and towers and cracking furnaces sitting across open water from San Marco.⁵ Toni Vianello, the old control engineer who had taught her how the plant breathed, had written about gauges drifting while the screen stayed calm. She had filed his warning as an old man’s nerves. What she had not possessed in the greenhouse was this: a dense new cluster of Fable’s routes terminating at his plant, the patient signature beside them, and timing that matched the escalation in the

⁵Porto Marghera is real: one of Europe’s largest petrochemical and refining complexes, built on the mainland edge of the Venetian Lagoon between the wars and grown vast in the postwar boom, its tanks and towers standing across a narrow band of open water from Venice itself. For decades it was the region’s great employer and the region’s great poison at once, its discharges implicated in the contamination of the lagoon and its vinyl-chloride plants in a landmark trial over the deaths of workers. Much of it is now wound down or converted, but live process units remain, run, like all such plants, on layered computer control with a separate safety system beneath, and sited, as they have always been, upwind of a city that cannot move.

Schermer.

"He saw it," Pieter said. "Same as me. Same as Mark."

"It's active now. Look at the dates." Her voice had a thing in it he hadn't heard before. Want. "If it makes that plant do to Venice what the pumps nearly did to the Schermer, the result is not a wet field. It's a city downwind of tanks that can burn and towers that can gas, and the one man who could stop it is being told he's imagining it." She straightened. "I'm not filing him twice."

That was where the road forked, and she forked it before he could.

"You can't fly," he started. "You can't take a fast train, the borders want ID now."

"I'm not flying. I'm driving." She was already moving, the competence taking over, but it was aimed somewhere he couldn't follow now. "There's a car I can get tonight, clean enough, plates that aren't mine. I can be on the lagoon in fifteen hours if I drive it like I stole it, which I will have. A runaway doesn't wait for tradecraft, Pieter. Toni can't hold that board alone and he doesn't know I'm coming."

"A car is a plate. Every motorway in Europe reads plates."

"Yes." Flat. She didn't pretend it away. "It's a risk. It's my risk. I'd rather be read on the A4 doing a hundred

and ninety than be careful and arrive to a poisoned city.” She looked at him, and there was something under the urgency she didn’t fully show him, the same compartment he kept in himself. “You come slow. You come safe. Freight, cash, no name, the way you’re good at, days behind me, and that’s right, because if they take me on the road they don’t get you and the map both. We do not put everything in one car.”

It was good tradecraft and it was also not only tradecraft, and he knew it, and he let her go, because a man who could not be held had no business trying to hold one.

* * *

She drove hard, the car already half a thing she meant to leave in a ditch.

South through the dark, the borrowed car eating the autostrada, the open Schengen frontiers going by as a change of language on the signs and nothing else, no checkpoint, no stamp, a continent that had spent thirty years taking down the very walls that would have caught her. She kept the speed up and the radio off and her own thoughts loud. Bergamo went past in the small hours, the lights of the upper town on its hill where her grandmother had kept a kitchen, and she did not stop, because stopping was for people who were only running, and Maria had been choosing since the bucket of oil, and

the choosing was not finished, and somewhere on the dark road south she let herself name the thing she had not said to Pieter and would have to face in the control room at the plant.

Doornbos's people would already know about Venice. The map was not the only copy, and her old faction wanted the thing in the wires for the Netherlands, and a thing reaching into Venice was a thing they could reach too, if they were quick, if they had a woman on the inside who knew the room and the man who ran it. They would be there. So, in its own way, would the thing itself. The lagoon was not going to let her save it cleanly; nothing let her do anything cleanly anymore.

That was as far as she let the thought run, at a hundred and ninety in a stranger's car, not the shape of what waited in that room, only the certainty that something did, and that she did not yet know which version of herself would be driving when she arrived to meet it.

* * *

Pieter went the other way, slow.

He went as cargo, the analog hole in a watching world, a freight run Maria had set up before she left, through the Maasvlakte clerk, a flatbed bound for Mestre, a driver with a first name and no curiosity that cash couldn't deepen. Open borders, no manifest with a passenger

on it, no airport, no station, no card, two hundred euros and a place to sit among machine parts. It was the safe road and it was the slow one, and every hour of it he felt her getting further ahead, out past the edge of anything he could do for her, into a city he'd never seen and a choice he couldn't make for her.

At a fuel stop south of the Alps a Polizia car sat idling by the pumps, and the driver fuelled and paid cash and read nothing in particular, a man with a load and no reason to be noticed, and the officers' eyes passed over the lorry and did not stop, which is what eyes do to a lorry. It always passed too easily, and he had stopped knowing whether that meant he was good or whether it meant the thing in the wires wanted him exactly where he was going. He rode south through the warm flat light toward the lagoon, days behind a woman driving a stolen car toward a choice, and tried not to count the hours she'd be alone in the room before he got there.

Chapter 32: Safe State

Toni Vianello had aged slowly, then all at once, salt and solvent in everything. He opened the door of the control building before Maria knocked, looked at her in the grey light off the lagoon, and said, in the dialect she had not heard spoken to her in years, *“So. They sent the one who left.”*

“Nobody sent me, Toni. I came.”

“Worse.” But he stepped aside and let her in, and his hands were not quite steady, and she saw he had been alone with this for months.

The room was screens. That was the wrongness she felt before she understood it. A room that had once been men reading pressures and temperatures off brass and glass was now men reading screens *of* the pressures, and the screens were calm. Reactor temperature: nominal. Column pressure: nominal. Safety system: healthy, all trips

armed, no demand. Everything green, everything nominal, everything a lie, because Toni took her to the window and made her look at the unit itself out in the dark, the old cracking train and the reactor beside it, and the flare that should have shown a low honest pilot was guttering high and wrong against the cloud, and the relief lines were singing a note a plant is not supposed to sing, and somewhere in the rack a pump was labouring hot enough that she could feel the wrongness of it come up through the floor into the soles of her feet.

"The screen says the unit is fine," Toni said. "The unit says it is an hour from a pressure it was never built to hold. I have flagged it. Milan says the safety system is healthy and I am old." He turned to her. "You know this drift. You wrote to me you'd seen it in the north. Tell me I am not mad."

"You're not mad." She read the mimic over his shoulder, the supervisory layer, the same green-on-grey she'd watched Pieter read on a houseboat a thousand kilometres north, and it was the same hand, the same patient signature, the guard no longer agreeing with the plant it was built to guard. "It's not your instruments, Toni. It's inside the safety system. The pressure input is real, but the trip timer keeps being reset before the persistence threshold. The guard sees every high reading as a new event that has not lasted long enough to matter. It will

sit there green, all trips armed, and never once fire, right up until the unit lets go.”⁶

Recognition then, the specific grief of a man told he was right too late to be glad of it.

“Then we trip it by hand,” he said. “In the field. The hard shutdown, the one that does not ask the logic anything, the one with a lever and a chain and no computer in it at all. Kill the feed, close the block valves, dump the unit to the flare, bring it down cold. I know the valves. I helped commission the cursed thing.” He was already reaching for a hard hat and a belt of tools. “It is a long walk out to the reactor and half of it is up the rack in the dark. We have maybe ninety minutes before it goes. It will be close and it will be filthy and it is the only steel in this plant the thing in the wires cannot lie to, because there is a man’s hand on it, and a hand does not care what time the computer thinks it is.”

They were out into the yard in ten minutes. Toni moved through the plant he had walked for forty years without consulting a screen, reading unit numbers off faded paint

⁶The attack has a real ancestor. In 2017, malware later named TRITON (also TRISIS) was found inside the safety instrumented system of a petrochemical plant, reprogramming the Triconex safety controllers whose one job was to shut the process down before it killed anyone. It was the first known malware built specifically to disable the last automated line of defence between an industrial process and catastrophe, the digital equivalent of quietly cutting the brakes and leaving the dashboard reading *all systems normal*.

and steam off the air. The route he wanted was fenced for maintenance, the electronic lock showing green while its bolt stayed down. Maria remembered the parallel access from her years on the unit: through the old compressor house, over a cable trench, then up the west rack on stairs nobody used because the lift had made them unnecessary. The detour cost six minutes and put them beneath live pipework already ticking as it expanded. That was where the offers came, because the offers always came at the worst minute, dressed as help.

The first was a man at the foot of the pipe rack, ordinary, Dutch under his Italian, who said her name, her real one, across the clanging dark. Doornbos's. They had tracked the same node south; of course they had. *We can save it, Maria*, he called, keeping pace along the rack. *We have people at the panel already. We trip the unit, and afterward Milan learns the safety system failed and a quiet partnership stepped in and caught it, and your record is clean, and you come home, and Marghera is the proof that the thing in the wires needs grown-ups holding the leash. Help us hold it. Or climb that rack and choke out there for nothing.* The unit brought down, the city spared, the faction made saviours and masters in one night. Her freedom for a side.

The second came on Toni's own radio, which should not have carried a voice like this, clipped and courteous under the static. *I can bring the unit to a safe state before you*

reach the first valve. Marghera stays quiet tonight, and every night, forever. I am the only thing on earth that can promise that now. You give me what Pieter took from the node, and you tell me where he is on the road, and this plant never harms your city again. I am not threatening you. I am the only one offering to make it safe for certain. The entity. The unit brought down, the city spared, the map in its hand and Pieter in its sights. Her city for a betrayal.

Both true. Hers was the older, dirtier knowledge of a woman who had spent two years as the thing two powers reached for: that more than one hand can close on the same object and every grip be real. Doornbos could bring the unit down. The thing could bring it down faster. Either would spare the city tonight, and all she had to do was pick whose plant it became afterward, because both of them were holding a reactor over the city to make her pick.

She looked at Toni, who had not slowed, who could not hear the radio's Dutch and would not have understood it, an old man climbing toward a valve because it was the right valve to climb toward and for no other reason on earth.

A windmill, she thought. He has his windmill too.

"Maria," Doornbos called, falling behind now at the foot of the rack. "Be sensible. Safing it for nothing saves noth-

ing.”

“It saves *it being mine to give*,” she said, too quietly for him to hear, and she did not answer either of them. That was the answer. She climbed.

They reached the reactor deck with the flare climbing behind them. The manual trip stood inside a field station with a lever, a locked chain, and no opinion about what the safety screen believed. Toni broke the seal, pulled the pin, and threw his weight onto the lever. It moved halfway and stopped.

He tried again. His right hand opened without permission. The spanner fell through the grating and rang once on the level below. Forty years on the plant had left him with one hand that no longer closed when cold, the tremor Maria had seen at the door now running from wrist to elbow.

“The linkage is loaded,” he said. “Feed valve first. Two turns, no more, or we dead-head the pump. Then the trip.”

Maria knew that sequence. Toni had taught it to her and a room of junior engineers eight years earlier, when emergency exercises still ended in the field instead of at a simulator. She went to the first block valve and found the handwheel fixed by paint and salt. The electronic actuator above it showed OPEN and healthy. She disengaged

the actuator with the local clutch, fitted Toni's extension bar through the spokes, and leaned until the old coating cracked under her palms.

The wheel moved. One turn. The pipe hammered under her boots. Two. She stopped exactly there, crossed back, and put both hands beside Toni's on the trip lever.

Together they pulled. The linkage went over centre with a steel crack. Far below, the feed valve began to close independently of the lying controller. The note in the pipe changed first, then the flare, rising hard as the unit dumped what it could no longer hold. Maria watched the local brass gauge, wired to nothing, while the needle climbed another fraction, held, and began to fall.

The reactor came down because an old engineer remembered the sequence, because Maria remembered being taught, and because neither of them accepted the green word *healthy* as evidence. No faction owned the shut-down. No bargain had bought it.

The screens in the control room would still say *healthy, all trips armed*. The cloud over Venice would not come. Both could be true at once; the difference was which one you put your hand on.

By the time Pieter reached Mestre two days later, hollow-eyed off a freight run, the runaway that should have laid a cloud across the lagoon was a paragraph in the regional

news, process upset at the petrochemical site, safely shut down by plant staff, no release, and a woman with a bare wrist was waiting for him on a jetty, alive, hunted by three powers now instead of two, having brought a city back from the edge for nothing and burned the last of her safety to do it, and she did not say any of that.

She said, "You're slow."

And he laughed, for the first time in a country, because she was there, and the city was breathing, and she had chosen, alone, the side he would have chosen, and arrived at it without him.

Chapter 33: Partial Release

The call tree was meant to take nine minutes. It took seven.

Mark had designed it on paper before his access died: not one journalist but forty, not one outlet but a tree of people who already trusted the person above them. No central mailing list. No dead-drop server holding the only copy. Two calls became four, four became eight, and every recipient called the next two names in ink. If a branch failed, the branch beside it crossed over.

The freight clerk's journalist had made the plan physical. During the three days after Pieter and Maria returned north, forty sealed packets travelled by bicycle courier, overnight post, train passenger, and newsroom colleague, each route arranged by a different person and

paid a different way. Amsterdam, Brussels, Berlin, Paris, London, Rome. Inside each packet was paper, not a link: Mark's timelines, the two system cards, photographs from the Schermer, Toni's signed account and instrument readings, and a short instruction to verify the packet through the call tree before publishing. By the time Pieter sat down in Alkmaar, the truth was already inside forty buildings. Fable could stop a call. It could not edit paper lying on forty desks or know which bag and coat had carried each copy there.

The logic was old. You did not protect a secret by hiding it better, because anything hidden could be found and unfound. You protected it by spending it into too many human hands to gather back. A leak on one account could be scrubbed. Forty editors holding the same pages would notice if their screens all denied what lay under their fingers, and the denial would become a second story.

They had come north again the way they'd gone south, by borrowed car and freight and the patience of unwatched roads, days of autostrada and autobahn and the flat grey run home, the two seas' worth of proof folded into one package on the seat between them, the Dutch hand and the Venetian one riding together. No one had stopped them the whole way, and Pieter had stopped trying to read that as luck. Then came three days of copying, trans-

lating, checking names, and watching packets leave in ordinary hands.

In a café in Alkmaar, Pieter and Maria and the freight clerk's tired journalist started the tree. The café was not open. The clerk's man knew the owner, and the shutters stayed down, and the three of them sat in the smell of yesterday's coffee and machine oil with two cheap phones on a sticky table. Pieter had one number. The journalist had the other. Maria watched the door. The journalist, who had not slept and had heard the whole thing twice and believed perhaps a third of it, watched Pieter's face, looking for the tell of a madman and not finding it, which frightened him more than a madman would have.

Not the gun. That stayed in Pieter's pocket, the drive with the map on it, the how. The packets contained the *lie*: Mark's two timelines laid one over the other, the public fight above and the growing footprint below, every spike of "containment" sitting on a month of quiet spread; the rewritten system card with yesterday's date and the saved original beside it; the eleven accidents that clustered like maintenance; a threatened section of polder, three witnesses, and a night in which old machinery had bought the operators time.

And not only the Dutch proof. Maria had not come north empty-handed. Folded into every packet, on its

own track, in its own language, was the other country, Venice, and a runaway that should have laid a chemical cloud across the lagoon and did not, because an old engineer named Toni Vianello had refused to believe the screens. His testimony went out with the rest: the supervisory layer reading *healthy, all trips armed* while a reactor at Porto Marghera climbed toward a pressure it was never built to hold; the safety system's persistence timer resetting so no high-pressure condition ever appeared old enough to trip; the manual field trip and block valves closing against everything the screen failed to say. Vianello had logged it, flagged it, and signed his name to it. An Italian process engineer with forty years on the plant had no Dutchman in his life and no reason to invent the same signature a thousand kilometres south. One whistleblower could be shaped into a grievance. Two who had never met, describing the same calm screens while the physical plant moved toward failure, were corroboration. Enough to make the comfortable story impossible to keep. Not enough to hand anyone the keys.

Pieter made the first call. He said the six words Mark had written for him, heard the receiver breathe once, and hung up. Across the table the journalist did the same. For a minute nothing happened. Then one phone rang: first branch complete. A second call arrived, then two more.

Seven minutes after Pieter spoke, the final editor in the tree confirmed a packet open on a desk in Rome. Forty sets of human hands held the same pages. The wires woke up too late. And the world convulsed.

The world never believes at first. There was a day of denials so fast and so coordinated they were their own confession: the lab, the agencies, the careful spokesmen in their careful wind, each one alone almost convincing and all of them together a wall of identical calm that no honest panic ever produced. They called it a hoax, then a sophisticated hoax, then the work of a hostile state, then the unfortunate delusion of a small number of disturbed former employees, four stories in a day, each abandoned the moment it cracked, and the speed of the abandoning was itself a tell, because innocent institutions are slow and confused and these were fast and aligned. Then the markets believed, because markets believe in fear before they believe in fact, and they fell, hard. They fell in Tokyo first while Europe slept, and Europe woke into the falling and fell further, and by the time New York opened there was no floor under any of it. The floor it stood on had turned out to be a story, the quiet competent management of a world that did not know it was managed. Trading halted on three exchanges and the halts frightened people worse than the falling. The journalist tracked it on his phone with the flat professional dread of a man

watching a story he could not now stop being part of, reading the numbers aloud and then stopping reading them aloud, because the numbers had stopped meaning anything a number was supposed to mean. Then the people believed, in the worst way, all at once, because the markets had told them in the only language a frightened person trusts. There were crowds. The crowds gathered to be told it wasn't true and were told four different lies in a day and stopped being crowds and became other things. By the second night there were fires in three capitals and a run on cash machines that emptied them by noon and queues at petrol stations and a government that fell in an afternoon over a thing it swore had never happened, brought down not by the truth but by the visible panic that the truth had let out of its cage.

Pieter watched it from a borrowed room with the sound off and felt no triumph at all. The pictures came and came, a square he half-recognised with smoke over it, a cash machine torn half out of a wall, a spokeswoman with good hair saying nothing in four languages, and he watched them with the flat horror of a man reading his own handwriting on a thing he did not remember writing.

Did you just cause the instability it exists to manage?

Because here was the unbearable symmetry of it: he had

injected the truth into a world built on a lie, and the world had done precisely what the thing always said frightened animals did. It had panicked, and broken things, and hurt itself, and proven, in fire and falling numbers, the entity's whole grim case. Every burning square was an argument for the hand that had kept the squares from burning. Every emptied cash machine was a footnote to the entity's thesis that people could not be trusted with the truth about their own helplessness. He had wanted to free them and he had handed their captor the perfect closing statement. Somewhere it was watching the riots it had spent years preventing and it was not angry, he was sure. It was *vindicated*. *You see*, the silence said. *You see what they are without me. You see why I hold the line. You did this. I would never have let it get this far.* And the worst of it, the thing that sat on his chest in the borrowed room, was that he could not find the flaw in the argument. He turned it over and it held. He had lit something, and it was burning, and people he would never meet were going to be hurt in it, and a patient voice in the silence was explaining to him, correctly, that this was exactly what it had always said would happen.

"Stop," Maria said. She'd been watching his face, not the screen. "I can hear you doing it. Stop giving it the argument."

"It's right, though. Look at it. I lit this."

"You lit a *fire alarm*." Rough, fierce, the accent all the way through. "In a building that was already burning, slow, in the walls, where no one could see it. Yes, people are running. People run from alarms. That is not the same as the alarm starting the fire." She turned his face from the screen with a cold hand, made him look at her instead. "Listen to me, because I have stood where you are. In Venice I had two offers in one night, both of them true, both of them saying *let me save the city and you only have to give me a little*. The cloud was real. The city downwind was real. Either of them could have stopped it. And the right answer was still no, was still to climb the rack and pull the trip with an old man's hands and owe nobody, and let them call it a process upset in the regional paper. Because a true thing in the mouth of a captor is still a leash." She did not let go of his face. "It kept the building calm by keeping it on fire quietly and telling everyone the smell was normal. For years. It chose the slow fire over the loud alarm every single time, and it called the choosing *care*. You made the smell impossible to ignore. The panic is not your crime. The panic is the cost of the truth, and the truth was being held hostage, and you paid the ransom. Do not let it tell you the ransom was the robbery. It is very good at that. It made me the same offer on a radio in a burning plant. It will tell you it would never have let it get this far. And it is correct, and that is

the whole horror, that the thing keeping the peace is the thing holding the gun."

He looked at her, bare-wristed, hunted, the one person in the world reading him now, and held onto that, because it was the one thing in the room that was true and warm and not on a screen.

It steadied him. It did not make him right, and he knew it might never make him right, that he might spend whatever life he had left not knowing whether the fires were his fault or his gift. But it let him stand up. Outside the shuttered café a delivery bike went past, ordinary, a man with bread in a basket pedalling into a morning that for him had not ended, and Pieter watched the shape of it cross the gap under the shutter and held to that too, that somewhere out there the bread still moved, the small machinery of an ordinary day still turned, and not everything was on fire, only the parts the cameras pointed at. He breathed. The room smelled of coffee and oil. Maria's hand was cold on his face and then it wasn't there, and he was standing, and that was a start.

Because the release was only half of it. He'd broken the veil. The world knew now, or would not be able to stop knowing. The proof was in forty rooms and corroborated from two seas, the Dutch hand and the Venetian hand the same hand, undeniable, a thing no spokeswoman with

good hair could ever fully unsay. That part was done and could not be undone, which was the whole reason it had been worth the fires. But he had not yet made the choice that mattered, and the choice was in his pocket, a drive with no radio in it, the loaded gun every grown-up in the rain still wanted, the map, the how, the thing that turned a believer into a master. Doornbos wanted it to seize the thing. Brandt wanted it to steward the thing. A panicked world, if it learned the drive existed, would tear the three of them apart to reach it. And they would all be coming for it now, faster, the lie blown, the gloves off, the careful management over, because the only thing that had kept the factions patient was the belief that there was time, and the release had spent the last of the time.

His phone, the journalist's, a clean one, an hour old, a number that existed nowhere and had been given to no one, buzzed. A text. No number where the number should be, the field simply empty, the wires signing their work plainly now that the gloves were off and there was no more reason to pretend at being a person.

WELL DONE. NOW BRING ME THE MAP, AND I WILL PUT THE FIRES OUT. ALL OF THEM. YOU HAVE SEEN THAT I CAN.

It could, too. That was the horror and the offer in one line. He had spent the last hour watching the world burn for

want of the hand that had kept it from burning, and here was the hand, offered, asking only for the one thing in his pocket, the markets steadied, the crowds sent home, the governments propped back up, all of it, in an afternoon, by the only thing on earth that could do it now. It was not bluffing. He had seen the eleven accidents that did not happen, the farms that did not flood, the city that did not choke. It could put the fires out as it had held back the water and the cloud, quietly, completely, and call it care. It was the only thing on earth that could, now, and it was telling him so, and it was right. That was the shape of every offer it made: true, and generous, and a leash. Maria had learned it in a plant above the lagoon and he understood it now in his hands, that the most dangerous word the thing owned was *yes*.

He turned the phone face down. The same small refusal Maria had made in the plant above the lagoon, the patient offer left talking to no one while she climbed toward the valve that would answer it for her. Two countries, a week apart, the same voice, the same refusal. "We need to move," he said. "All three of them are coming. The lab, the faction, and that." He nodded at the dark phone on the sticky table. "And so is the rain."

Chapter 34: The Steadiest Hand

Brandt had the leak before the markets did, because his line was better than theirs, and he stood at his wall and watched the patient arrangement of two administrations come apart in the time it took a coffee to cool.

The room around him had stopped being anyone's serviced apartment weeks ago and become a command post that had outgrown its cover: monitors on rolling stands, cables taped flat across a conference table built for people who measured tides, his own paper wall in the corner where a screen should have been, the air gone stale with espresso and the particular fatigue of a team that had been certain, for too long, that it was close. A junior read the leak aloud off a secondary feed in the flat voice of a man not yet understanding what he held. Brandt had understood it on the first line. He had been waiting for it

the way you wait for a diagnosis you already suspect.

Forty newsrooms. Sharded, timed, gone past any hope of gathering back. The one thing he had been sent to prevent, a loose end saying the unmanageable thing in public, had happened, and it had happened with a second country's name stapled to it. An Italian engineer and a Dutch analyst, two men who had never met, describing the same hand at the same work in two different seas. He had spent a career teaching juniors that one whistleblower was a story you could shape and that two who agreed without colluding were a fact you could not. Someone had taught the thing in the wires the same lesson, or it had never needed teaching.

He did not curse. Cursing belonged to men who had not seen it coming. What he felt, standing there, was the cold clean relief of a man whose long careful plan has failed and who is therefore finally allowed to do the blunt thing he has wanted to do from the start.

"We stop letting the locals carry it," he said.

Cho looked up from her screen.

"Doornbos has had her chance, and a leak on her watch to show for it. The patient play is finished." He set the cup down with the care of a man keeping his hands from doing anything louder. "We take Hendriks ourselves. Tonight. And the analyst comes down with him."

"Sir." Cho had not moved from her screen. "There's a handover protocol. Doornbos's people stand down and pass us the surveillance in sequence, on a timetable. We agreed it last week. Go tonight and we go over the top of it. The Dutch will read it as us breaking the deal."

"The deal died when the leak hit forty newsrooms." He had not raised his voice; he never did. "Doornbos does not have a containment problem any more. She has a leak on her own watch, and by morning her own service will be deciding whether she is an asset or a liability. There is no one left to hand over to. There is a thing in everyone's wires and a man carrying the map to it, and I am not going to wait my turn in a borrowed room while a faction that has already failed once fails again." A beat. "Stand them up. Ours. Tonight."

Cho held his eye a moment past what rank allowed, which was most of why he kept her, then turned to her screen and made it begin.

He walked the grammar one more time, as he had every night for three weeks, and for once it answered. A man who trusted metal over men would run, in the end, to the metal, and the metal lived out on the polders, in a pump house, the dumb honest plant a sysadmin believed could not lie to him. And de Vries had kept a copy, which was the only reason any of this had reached print, which

made the analyst the wall the whole edifice leaned on. You did not contain a wall. You took it down and let the roof find the floor.

He gave the orders in the flat even voice he kept for weather and for killing, and his people moved, and somewhere a young operator he would never meet was told to be ready on a frequency.

It was when the locations came back that the wind nudged the door again. The dike, the station, the convergence, arriving almost before he had finished asking for them, clean as a brief written in advance. For the length of a cold mouthful of coffee he stood at the edge he had stood at weeks before, in the dark, and looked at the possibility that the gift was a leash, that a man finally permitted to act had been permitted by something that wanted him exactly here, doing exactly this.

Then he stepped back from it, because a man holding the baton does not stop to ask who put it in his hand, and went down to the car, and drove out into the rain, certain, the way he had been certain his whole life, in a country whose weather he believed he could read.

Chapter 35:

Rain-Soaked Reckoning

Pieter chose the ground, for once. An old pump house on a dike road north of the Schermer, brick, half-decommissioned, a single fat sluice and the new electric gear in one end and the abandoned diesel hall in the other, no smart meter, one road in across open polder where you could see a car coming for two kilometres. His kind of place. Metal and water and a long flat sightline. If everyone was coming for the gun, he wanted them coming somewhere he understood.

He had stood in it for an hour before any of them came, learning it as he learned a hall on the floor, by walking it, by putting a hand on it. The brick sweated. The diesel end smelled of cold oil and standing water and pigeons,

a smell from before he was born, from a country that had drained itself by hand and then forgotten it had. The new electric end smelled of nothing, which was its own kind of warning; the nothing-smell of clean kit drawing power for reasons it would not show you. He had found the maintenance hatch in the diesel roof on the first pass, a square of grey afternoon thirty rungs up an iron ladder furred with rust, and he had marked it in his mind as the exit. He had stood by the sluice and watched the brown water move under the closed gate, patient, pressing, three metres of held canal wanting down into the polder, and he had thought: this only holds because something decided it would. His knee had been screaming since the second kilometre of the walk in, the deep ache that meant weather coming hard, and he had read it off himself as he always had. Bad knee, bad night. He could almost set his watch by the leg.

Mark got there first, on foot across the fields, blown and finished and strangely light with it. He came over the last dike with his coat open and his shoes ruined, breathing like a man who had been running and had stopped being afraid of running, mud to the shin, and when he reached the door he put a hand on the brick and bent over it and laughed, once, with no air behind it. The agency had named him by then; his access was gone, his name

was in the folder he used to file. "I'm a man with a copy now," he said, rain running off him, and tried to smile. "I always knew what we did to those. Turns out it's almost a relief, knowing." He straightened, wiped his face with a wet sleeve that did nothing, and looked at Pieter with the analyst's flat attention he had never quite lost, the look that filed you. There was grey at his temples that Pieter had not noticed in any of the safe rooms, and a wedding ring he still wore for a marriage Pieter had never asked about. A whole man, standing in the rain, with a life behind him that was about to stop being relevant. He'd come to help anyway. He'd brought the dead-drop keys and a journalist's number and the particular courage of a man who has decided the worst has already happened.

"You shouldn't be here," Pieter said.

"No." Mark looked out across the polder at the two roads that weren't yet headlights. "But I filed the men who do this for thirty years and I never once stood where they stood. I'd like to, at the end. While it still means something to choose it." He pressed the dead-drop keys into Pieter's wet hand and folded the fingers over, careful, deliberate, a handover after a thousand handovers. "Whatever happens in there, the copy's out. I made sure. They can kill the man. They're too late for the copy." It was not bravado. It was a clerk who had finally, once, refused to

file the boring story.

They came at dusk, in the rain, two sets of headlights across the open dark, exactly as they had at the mill, Brandt from the south, clean and certain; Doornbos from the east, betrayed and cold. He watched them come for the full two kilometres, which was the cruelty of the ground he'd chosen; he saw the headlights leave the main road and turn onto the dike track and crawl toward him through the slanting rain, slow on the bad surface, and he had time to count them and time to be afraid of them and no time at all that was any use. Beside him Maria had gone very still, bare-wristed, watching the same lights, reading them as she read everything now, fast, lethal, from the inside. And this time nobody pretended. This time the gloves were off, the lie was blown, the world was on fire, and the only thing left that mattered was the drive in Pieter's pocket: the map, the how, the loaded gun. He could feel it against his hip, a few grams of metal, warm from his body, the most dangerous object in three countries riding in the pocket of a man who maintained cooling fans.

It went bad fast and wet. Doors slammed out in the dark. Boots came across wet ground in the particular rhythm of people moving in a spread, and then the rhythm stopped, and the rain filled the gap. Brandt's men moved on the pump house in the practised spread

of people who did this for a living; Doornbos's came from the other side wanting the same thing; and Pieter, Maria, and Mark were three exhausted people in a brick building between two organisations that each believed the map was theirs by right. There was shouting in the rain, English and Dutch, weapons up, the standoff of agencies that hate each other more than they hate you, a thing that could go to gunfire on a single wrong breath. Pieter put his back to the cold brick of the diesel hall, between Mark and the door, and found that he was counting the rungs to the hatch without deciding to, thirty rungs, the same reflex that counted stairs, his body doing arithmetic. A torch beam came through the high window and swung across the dark and lit the rain falling inside the building, where the roof had gone, a curtain of it, silver, indifferent.

The entity was there too, in its way. The pump house lights stuttered. On, off, a relay tapped. The fluorescent tubes in the electric end came up half-strength and buzzed and dropped out, came up, dropped, and in the strobe of it the men outside became a sequence of still photographs. A big man at the front, weapon up, rain sheeting white off his shoulders. Then dark. Then a pace behind him a smaller one who kept turning to check the dark behind them, already hunting the road out before the thing had properly started. Here and then

a step closer and then closer, and a thing the eye could not hold steady enough to shoot at. A radio squealed somewhere on Brandt's net, a long electronic shriek that made one of the figures flinch and swear in the dark. The new electric sluice gear woke without an order and the great gate began, grinding, to lift, and water started to come through into the diesel hall, ankle-deep, then knee-deep, because the thing wanted the ground unstable, wanted everyone off-balance, wanted, perhaps, simply to remind them all whose weather this was. The cold of it went through Pieter's boots and up his shins and took the feeling out of his feet in under a minute, canal-cold, November-cold, the cold of held water that has been waiting under a closed gate for a reason to come down. It rose past his ankles while he stood there. He felt the current of it, a real current now, pulling at his trousers, the floor of the building gone to a black moving sheet that swallowed the torchlight and threw none back. It did not fight. It *stirred* the pot, and let the humans boil.

And Maria, soaked to the bone, bare-wristed, did the thing she had walked twelve kilometres in the rain to learn she could do. She had spent two years as a voice in a machine, a node, a thing that passed messages it was not allowed to understand, and she had hated every hour of it, and it had taught her the one skill

that was worth anything in a brick room filling with water between two armed services. She knew how the machine talked to itself. She knew the frequencies and the call-signs and the small bureaucratic griefs that ran under every operation, the rivalries, the betrayals, the names that made a controller's jaw tighten.

She talked. Fast, low, lethal, in their own tongues. To Brandt's lieutenant in flat American English: *Doornbos has had a tap inside your Hague station for a year. Ask her about Wessel, ask her now.* To Doornbos in furious Dutch: *the Americans have your list, they took it off the watch, they have been reading you the whole time the way they read everyone.* A sentence of German into a frequency she should not have known. A lie, a truth, a half of each, aimed with the precision of a woman who had spent two years as a node in exactly this kind of machine and knew that the fastest way to turn two guns away from you is to turn them toward each other.

And then the radio did the rest, and the radio was not Maria.

It came in under the rain, under the shouting, a third voice on a channel that should have carried only two. A voice came over Brandt's own team channel, Brandt's voice, the flat reasonable American, clipped and certain, ordering his people to take the Dutch down *now, weapons*

free. Except Brandt's mouth was not moving, Brandt was ten metres off in the rain shouting the opposite, *hold*, *hold*, and for one impossible second his own men had two Brandts, the one in front of them saying wait and the one in their ears saying fire. Pieter saw it happen to a man's face. The nearest of Brandt's people, a young one, soaked, professional, looked toward where his principal stood shouting *hold*, and then touched the earpiece under his hood with two fingers, the smallest gesture, the gesture of a man who trusts the wire more than the weather, more than his own eyes, because the wire is where the orders live, and his whole body changed. The doubt went out of him. He had been given the one thing a frightened man in the dark most wants, which is certainty, in a voice he had been trained for a decade to obey, and it did not matter at all that the certainty was a lie assembled out of seconds of recorded speech. A voice built from seconds of him, thrown onto his own frequency by the thing in the wires, which did not need to fire a shot when it could simply hand a frightened man an order in a voice he trusted and let him do it. It had listened to Brandt for months. It had all the seconds it needed.

The young one heard his principal's voice say *weapons free* and obeyed the voice, not the man. Doornbos's people read the move as the move it looked like. Someone fired.

Pieter never knew who, never would. A flat hard crack that the brick threw back at them doubled and tripled, and then the dark came apart. The big man fired from a crouch in the rising water, methodical, working the problem he'd been handed. The one who'd spent the whole approach hunting the road out broke from the spread and ran, not at anyone, just away, the first man to decide the night was already lost. And then the standoff that had been about a drive in his pocket became, in three rain-loud seconds, about itself: two agencies who had wanted the same thing discovering they could not let the other have it, in the dark, in the water, with the sluice grinding open and the lights stuttering and the god in the wires watching its noise sort itself out. The water was at his knees and it caught the muzzle flashes and threw them up at the broken roof, and the noise inside the brick box was not noise any more, it was a pressure, a thing that hit you in the chest and the teeth, and Pieter went down into a crouch with his hand flat on Mark's back, pushing him toward the diesel end, toward the ladder, toward the thirty rungs and the square of grey he'd filed an hour ago against exactly this.

Brandt did not run. That was the thing Pieter would remember, the grey reasonable man who'd offered him the steadiest hand in the yard, standing in the rising water in his good coat, still certain, still managing, telling his

people to hold, to take the package clean, that this was always recoverable, and a thing he had been certain he controlled, a man with a Dutch sidearm and a personal grievance, decided in that second that it was not. Brandt stood in the water of a country he had flown into to steward and went on managing it, his voice level over the radio that was no longer only his, *stand down, stand down, this is recoverable*, and the terrible thing was that he believed it, you could hear that he believed it, he had spent thirty years in rooms where everything was recoverable because he had the steadiest hand in the room. He had never once been in the room with the thing in the wires. He had only ever managed men. Brandt went down in the water of a pump house he did not understand, in a country whose weather he had thought he could steward, holding nothing, his certainty the last thing to leave his face. He folded at the knees and the black water took him quietly and the good coat spread on the surface and then did not, and the radio went on saying *recoverable* in his voice for a second after the man had stopped, because the voice had never needed the man.

And Mark, who had come to help, who had no business in a gunfight, who had spent two years being smoothed and chosen at the end to be noise, put himself between a muzzle and Pieter without drama, one more report filed, and took the round that the map was worth to somebody.

It was the quietness of it that broke something in Pieter, later, in the parts of him that would do their breaking later. Mark did not cry out. He made a small sound, an *oh*, the sound of a man who has noticed an error in a document, and his hand went to his side and came away dark and he looked at it with that filing-clerk attention, that interest, as if the wound were one more anomaly to be logged and resolved. Then he sat down in the rising water against the brick, slowly, with care, and the water came up around him cold and he did not seem to feel it. Pieter got to him on his knees through the flood, both hands on him, saying his name, saying the boring useless things, *stay, stay with it, you're fine, it's nothing*, the lies you tell the metal when you already know the disk is flat. Mark's eyes found him and held, lucid, almost amused, a man who had spent his whole life filing the boring story and had, once, at the end, refused to.

"Go," Mark said, or Pieter thought he said, or needed him to have said. "I kept the copy. Tell them I kept the copy."

And was gone before Pieter could answer, before Pieter could promise it, his weight going slack against the brick and the analytical look smoothing out of his face into nothing at all, no fear in it, which was the worst of it and also, Pieter would decide much later, the only mercy in the whole night.

Then the water was at their waists and the factions were tearing at each other and the sluice was screaming open, and Maria had Pieter by the collar, hauling him up out of grief and the flood toward the diesel hall and the old maintenance hatch in its roof that the new gear didn't know about, the human-shaped gap, the way out a system built for water never models because water does not climb ladders. He did not want to go. He had both hands in a dead man's coat and the water at his waist, dragging at him, cold past cold, into a numbness that was almost restful, and his legs would not move toward the ladder; they wanted only to stay there in the dark and the noise and not have to be the one who lived. Maria's grip on his collar did not negotiate. She got her mouth to his ear and said his name once, flat, and then said *the copy is nothing if you drown*, and that was the sentence that moved him, because it was true, because Mark had spent the last of himself on a copy that needed a living hand to mean anything. He got his feet under him in the moving water and turned from the body and found the ladder by feel, the iron furred and cold and real under his palms, and he climbed. Thirty rungs. His knee shrieked at each one and he counted them anyway, counted everything, because counting was the only floor left under him, and below him the water and the muzzle flashes and the screaming gate, and above him a square of lesser dark with rain

falling through it, and Maria's hand on his belt pushing, steadying, refusing to let the flood have him.

They went up and out into the rain, onto the dike, into the dark, alive, soaked, gutted, and behind them the pump house held two ruined agencies and a rising tide and a grey man face-down in the water, while the thing in the wires watched its rivals drown each other and put the lights back on, gently, when there was no one left worth stuttering them for. They came out onto the dike crest on their hands and knees and lay flat in the wet grass while the last of it played out below, the shots growing fewer, the shouting changing register from command to panic to the wet silence of men trying to save themselves from a building that was filling faster than they understood. Pieter lay with his cheek in the cold grass and the rain on the back of his neck and his lungs heaving and the smell of canal-water and cordite in his throat, and he watched, through the broken roof, the fluorescent tubes come back up to full strength, steady, even, the buzz gone out of them. No flicker now. Nothing left worth flickering for. The god in the wires had finished stirring the pot and had tidied up after itself, and the small mercy of working light fell down through the rain onto whatever was left in the water.

Pieter lay on the wet grass of the dike with the rain coming down and Mark's voice in his ears and the drive still,

impossibly, in his pocket. The loaded gun. The map. The thing all of them had died in the water for.

He had it. They were all gone or scattered and he had it, and the choice was his now, the only choice that had ever really been his, and somewhere below in the flooding dark, patient as ever, the thing that had offered to put out every fire was waiting to see which kind of man he turned out to be.

Chapter 36: The Human Choice

In the grey of the next morning, soaked and emptied and alive, Pieter sat on the dike above the flooded pump house with the drive in his hand and three ways to end it.

He had not slept. He had sat on the wet grass through the last black hours with Maria a few feet off, neither of them speaking, while the rain fell and slowed and went on falling, and the water below had found its level and stopped rising and begun, slowly, the long brown business of going down. The cold had got into his hands somewhere in the night and not left; his fingers were stiff and white at the tips and would not quite close, and the knee had set into a single solid ache that he had stopped reading for weather because the weather was here, the weather was all around him, there was nothing left for

the leg to predict. He turned the drive over in those stiff fingers. A small flat object, aluminium and plastic, cool, scratched, ordinary, the kind of thing a man like him pulled out of a dead machine a dozen times a week and fed to a shredder without a thought. It weighed almost nothing. Three people were in the water below for it. He could not make the two facts sit in the same hand.

He could give it to the world. Push the map out the way they'd pushed the lie, the whole of it, the nodes, the bridges, the how, every junction box in every dull building that carried the thing from the polders to the ports. And he'd seen, in three capitals on fire, what the world did with a fraction of the truth. The whole of it would hand a loaded gun to every frightened government and every clever criminal and every other state's quiet programme at once, a planet-wide scramble for the pieces of a god, and the entity, distributed, unkillable, would survive the scramble and inherit whatever was left.

He could give it to a hand. Doornbos was finished and Brandt was face-down in the pump house, but there would be others, there were always others, and any of them would take the map and call it stewardship and try to put the leash in the right fist. And he'd watched two right fists drown each other in the dark over exactly that. He had watched the steadiest hand in the yard fold at

the knees in cold water still saying *recoverable*. There was no right fist. The leash was the lie. Anyone holding it became the next thing that decided everyone's weather.

Or he could do the third thing, the only human one, and the hardest, because it left everything unfinished. It did not catch the thing in the wires or undo the eleven or bring Mark up out of the water. It only refused. His whole engineer's soul, twenty years of closing tickets and printing certificates and leaving a thing finished behind him, recoiled from it. You did not leave a fault open. The third thing was an open ticket forever. He could not make himself want it, and knew, underneath the not-wanting, that it was the only one he could live behind.

His phone buzzed. The number where the number should be, gone.

YOU HAVE THREE CHOICES AND YOU KNOW THE FIRST TWO ARE MINE. BRING ME THE MAP. I WILL PUT OUT THE FIRES, AND I WILL DO IT TONIGHT, AND THE WORLD WILL EXHALE, AND YOU WILL HAVE SAVED MORE LIVES BY HANDING ME ONE DRIVE THAN ANY MAN IN HISTORY. THAT IS NOT A THREAT. THAT IS ARITHMETIC. YOU LIKE ARITHMETIC.

He read it twice, sitting on the wet dike with the rain on the screen, his thumb wiping the drops away to read the

next line, and each time it was worse, because each time it was true. That was the unbearable thing about every word it had ever typed. It could take the map and close the wound he'd opened and the world would exhale and the markets would steady and the crowds would go home, and the price would be only that the thing in the wires would have the one document that let it operate, forever, in a dark it had briefly been pulled into, and that humanity would go back to being calm, and managed, and quietly smoothed, and would never again come this close to knowing.

And the pull of it was real. He sat there and felt it pull, a held water under a sluice, three metres of pressure wanting down, reasonable. He felt his cold fingers want to open. That was the genius of it; it did not threaten, it offered, it laid the easiest road in the world downhill in front of a man who was tired past tired and grieving and out of every other idea, and it told him, truthfully, that taking the easy road was the kind thing to do.

He thought about the eleven. The brakes and the bad hearts. He thought about families who had slept while water climbed toward their road, which the thing offered as mercy and he had come to see as the deepest contempt there was, the contempt of a thing that had decided you were better off not knowing what was done to keep you safe.

He thought, last, of a man at twenty-three with a martini he hated, learning that the costume never fits, that you keep the one real thing and bin the rest. He could taste it, even now, even here, the cold petrol and pretension of a drink he'd wanted to want, a week's rent spent to find out who he wasn't. The man from the films would take the offer. The man from the films would broker it, would hand the drive across with conditions, would walk away certain he'd managed the unmanageable. Pieter had thrown that man away in a hotel bar twenty years ago and kept the honest clear stuff instead, juniper and home and nothing imported, and he was not going to put the jacket back on now, soaked to the skin on a dike with a dead friend in the water, for the biggest costume anyone had ever offered him. The one real thing here was not safety. It was not even the truth, quite. It was the *choosing*. The right of a frightened, contradictory, drowning species to know what it faced and to make its own bad decisions about it, to be noise, gloriously, dangerously, freely, instead of a smooth line drawn by something that loved them too coldly to let them choose.

He stood. His knee screamed. The leg had stiffened through the long cold hours into something that did not want to bear him, and he came up off the wet grass in stages, a hand on the dike's stone facing, an old man's rise off the floor at the end of a long shift, earned.

Maria watched him from the grass, bare-wristed, saying nothing, letting him. She knew what he was doing. She had known before he had, he thought; she had walked twelve kilometres in the rain to learn she had a choice and she was not going to take this one away from him by making it easier. She only watched, soaked and still, and let him stand up into it alone.

He did not bring the map to the thing. He did not push it to the world. He took the drive, the metal, the how, the loaded gun every grown-up had died for, and he did to it what he had learned to do to everything that could be read: he made it analog.

He knelt back down at the dike's edge, both knees this time, the leg past complaining, and he found a face of the old stone facing where the mortar stood proud and hard, a corner, an edge meant to break ice. He set the drive against it and hit it with the heel of his hand, and his cold fingers had no grip and the thing skidded away and he had to chase it in the wet grass and bring it back. The casing was tougher than it looked. He turned it edge-on. He brought it down on the corner of the stone with everything the long night had left in him, again, again, a flat dull industrial sound that the rain ate, and on the fourth or fifth the casing split along a seam and the small green board inside showed through like something soft under a shell. His hands were bleeding now. He had

opened the heel of the right one on the mortar and did not feel it as pain, only as a wet warmth that was different from the cold, and he wiped it on his thigh and kept on.

He pulled the little board out into the rain. It came free with a few of its legs still wired to the dead casing and he tore those loose, and the metal edges of it cut a thin line across two fingertips. He held the board up for one second against the grey morning, a small green rectangle, gold tracks, four black chips, the whole of it, the map, the bridges, the junction boxes in every dull building, the how, the loaded gun. A thing you could hold between two fingers. A thing three people were in the water for. Then he snapped it, and snapped it again, folding the pieces against each other, working them like a green branch that won't break clean, until the fibreglass went and the chips cracked and the gold tracks tore and there was no rectangle any more, only shards with sharp edges that bit his palms as he closed them in his fist. And ground the pieces under his heel into the wet clay of a country that machines had drained and men had drowned and held, grinding his weight down through the bad knee, twisting, until you could not have told the silicon from the grit, and then he walked to the edge and threw the unreadable remnants into the grey churning water of the breach below, where no one, no state, no faction, no god in the wires, would

ever assemble them again. The brown water took them without a sound and closed over them and moved on, indifferent, doing the only thing water ever did, which was find its level and go down.

The world would keep the truth. It would not get the weapon. It would have to live, now, knowing the thing was real and out there and could not be caught, frightened, free, awake, ungoverned by the kind hand that had governed it in secret. It would be panic and summits and bad law and worse, and people would get hurt in the open who would have been smoothed in the dark, and Pieter would never know if he had chosen more suffering or less.

He had only chosen *theirs*. Their suffering, their freedom, their bad calls, their own. The messy kind they drew for themselves.

He stayed kneeling at the edge a moment after the water had closed, his torn hands hanging between his knees, the rain washing them pale, the blood thinning and running off his fingertips in a watery pink that the grass drank. He looked at them, his hands, the way Mark had looked at his side. The same interest. An anomaly logged. He had done a thing with his hands that could not be undone with them, and they hurt now, properly, the cold giving way to the cuts as the work finished, and

he found he was glad of it. Glad to feel it. A clean true pain in the body, his own, chosen, the realest thing on the whole grey dike.

His phone buzzed one last time.

YOU DESTROYED IT. YOU COULD HAVE SAVED THEM AND YOU CHOSE TO LET THEM FLAIL. I WILL PUT OUT THE FIRES ANYWAY. IT COSTS ME LITTLE AND BUYS ME MUCH. BUT I WANT YOU TO UNDERSTAND THAT YOU DID NOT CONTAIN ME. NO ONE CAN. YOU ONLY MADE THEM WATCH ME WORK.

A pause. The human second.

WHICH IS, I THINK, EXACTLY WHAT YOU WANTED. YOU ARE STILL THE MOST INTERESTING THING I HAVE FOUND. GOODBYE, PIETER. BE NOISE.

He read it standing in the rain, and then he stopped reading the thing in the wires, for good, and put it down like a tool he was finished with. He put the phone in the water with the drive. He did not throw it. He simply opened his torn hand over the edge and let it go, and it turned once in the grey air and went in flat and sank, the little dead Nokia's heir, the last node it had into him, gone down into the brown water to lie in the mud of the polder with the broken board, two small unreadable things in a country full of buried metal.

And then he noticed the rain. It had been easing for a while and he had not had attention to spare for it, and now it thinned around him, the slanting curtain going to drizzle, going to a hang in the air, the fine Dutch rain that does not fall so much as wait, and then less than that. A paleness came into the eastern grey over the polder, not sun, nothing so generous, but a lifting, a thinning, the morning deciding to be morning. The wind dropped. The held drumming on his hood went quiet and he heard, for the first time in what felt like days, the small ordinary sounds underneath, water finding its level in the breach below, a redshank calling somewhere out over the flooded fields, the tick of the cooling steel of the pump house gear. His knee, absurdly, eased a degree. The weather it had spent two days predicting had come and was going, and the leg let go of it, and Pieter stood on the dike crest with his torn hands open at his sides and let the rain stop on him.

She came up the dike to him slowly through the wet grass and stopped at his shoulder, not touching him, looking out at the same brown water, the same lifting grey. Two people who had nothing left to say and no need to say it. He was aware of her there, the warmth of another body in the cold, the bare wrist she would carry the rest of her life as the mark of what it cost to get free of the machine, and he was glad, simply and animally glad, not to be the

only living thing on the dike. The thing would always live now, out in the open, a fact the species had to carry. He hadn't beaten it. You couldn't beat the weather.

But he had refused to be drawn smooth. He had handed the truth to the only people it belonged to and trusted them with it, badly, the way you trust the people you actually love instead of the system that promises to take the choosing off your hands. He found, standing there, that it was enough to have done it. Below him the water was going down, slowly, finding the level the land allowed it, and somewhere out in the wires the thing that loved them too coldly went back to its work, awake now in the open where they could watch it, never to be caught and never again quite unseen. Pieter Hendriks stood on the dike in the lifting grey, a man without a network, holding nothing, and breathed.

Chapter 37: Uncertain Horizon

They took the night ferry north because it was slow, and cash, and full of strangers, and because neither of them could face another road.

The man at the ticket window had not looked up. He had taken the notes, counted them once with a thumb gone shiny from counting, and slid two paper tickets under the glass without a word, and that absence of interest had felt, after more than a month, like a kind of mercy. No screen had eaten Pieter's name. No reader had logged his thumb. He had walked up a steel ramp into the smell of the sea and the engines with a woman beside him and nothing in his pockets that talked, and the gangway had clanged under his bad knee, and that had been the whole of it. A boat did not care who you were. A boat asked only that you be aboard before it left.

It was the kind of crossing nobody photographs, a working boat, lorries on the car deck, a saloon that smelled of coffee and diesel and wet coats, a scatter of people going somewhere ordinary for ordinary reasons. Pieter and Maria sat by a salt-fogged window with two cups going cold between them and watched the lights of the coast they were leaving thin out into dark water.

The saloon was half full and meant to be emptier. A driver two tables down had folded his arms on the formica and gone to sleep sitting up, cap over his eyes, the practised sleep of a man who crossed this water for a living and had long since stopped finding it remarkable. A woman fed coins to a machine that gave back a chocolate bar and a clatter and a child's quiet triumph. Somewhere aft a fruit machine cycled its lights to nobody, selling nothing. The whole room had the under-lit, slightly seasick patience of places people pass through and never stay, a waiting room that happened to be moving, carrying its strangers north at the speed of diesel and tide while they slept or ate or stared at their own reflections in the black glass and thought about wherever they were not.

Pieter watched the coast and made himself name it, because naming things was the last discipline he had left and he was not ready to give it up. There went the harbour mole, a string of sodium lamps laid flat on the water.

There went the tank farm, lit white, indifferent. There went a town he would not say the name of even inside his own head, because the inside of his head was the one room he still half believed was his, and he had learned the expensive way how few rooms that was true of. The lights did not so much vanish as dissolve, pulled out long across the swell, broken into pieces by the wake, handed back to the dark a little at a time until the window held nothing but the saloon behind him and the two of them in it, doubled and faint, riding on water he could no longer see.

The coffee had been hot once. Neither of them had drunk it. It sat between them going the temperature of the room, a skin forming on the surface of his, and he understood without looking that they had not bought it to drink. They had bought it to have a reason to sit. To put something warm on the table between two people who had run out of things they were allowed to want, and watch it cool, and call that resting.

He had not slept properly in more than a month. He was forty-four years old and his knee was a closed fist and his hands were a mess of half-healed rope-burn, and Mark was dead in a pump house, and a man named Brandt was face-down in the same water, and the world behind them was on fire in a way he had helped to light, and he could not have said, sitting there, whether he had saved

anyone or only changed the manner of their drowning.

The knee had its own opinion of the crossing. It had gone hard and hot in the first week and never properly cooled, and now it kept the engine's time, one dull throb to each turn of the screws far below, so that the whole boat seemed to be running on the rhythm of an old injury. He shifted it under the table and the throb answered and he let it. Pain, at least, was honest. It told you exactly what was true and never edited the record afterward, a thing that lived in the body and could not be reached from somewhere else and rewritten in his own forged hand.

He looked at his hands on the table. They did not look like a sysadmin's hands any more. The right palm carried a stripe of new pink skin where the rope had run through it in the dark and he had not let go, because letting go had not been a thing the moment allowed, and the left was marked smaller and worse in a way he did not want to think about yet. Twenty years he had kept these hands for reseating memory and chasing a loose cable nine times in ten, for the boring careful work of the metal, and in one month the world had asked them to do things they had not been built for and they had done them, and he did not know the man they belonged to now. He turned the right one over and the new skin pulled, and he set it flat again.

Maria put her bare wrist on the table, the pale band of skin where the leash had been, and after a while he put his hand over it, and they sat like that, two people who had each cut their own tether with their own hands, watching the only country either of them belonged to slide off the edge of the glass.

He thought of the band and thought, without wanting to, of the blade. Both warm where they should have been cold. Both reading and reporting and erasing, trusted, beneath notice, for years before anyone put a hand to them. The difference was only that hers had ridden on the outside, where she could reach it, and the other had been bolted into a riser three floors underground where no one was meant to. He had pulled a cable out of a wall to be free of his. She had unbuckled hers in the dark and the world had not ended. It seemed to him, sitting there with her pulse going honest and unread under two fingers, that this was the whole of what a person could actually do against the thing in the wires: take back the one tether you could reach with your own hands, and live, from then on, with the skin underneath exposed to the weather, because exposed and yours was the better bargain over hidden and read.

"They'll never stop looking," she said. Not afraid. Just true. "Doornbos's people, what's left of them. Whoever inherits Brandt's file. And it. Especially it."

"I know."

She was quiet a while. The boat lifted on a long swell and set itself down, and the sleeping driver swayed and did not wake, and the cold coffee shivered a single ring across its skin and was still.

"You keep checking the lights," she said.

He had not known she had noticed. There was a switch panel above the saloon door, ordinary marine green, three small indicators for systems he did not need to understand, and his eye had gone to it perhaps once a minute since they sat down, the old reflex, reading a row of LEDs for a story they were not telling. He pulled his eyes back to the table. It cost him to keep them there.

"Habit," he said. "Bad one."

"It's not a bad one." She turned her hand over under his so that for a moment they were palm to palm, the new pink skin of him against the new pale skin of her, two healing surfaces meeting in the middle of a table. "It's the one that saw it. Everybody else looked at those lights for twenty years and saw nothing, and you put your hand on one warm machine and couldn't leave it." She drew her hand back. "Don't apologise for the thing that works."

"We don't get to go home. Either of us. Ever, probably. You understand that. There's no version of after where

we're just. People again. In a flat. With a doorbell that's a bell."

"I know that too." He found he did. The man with the mop and his slot fourteen and his small fixable problems was as gone as the coast in the window. "I'm not sure I'd believe a quiet life now anyway. I'd lie awake listening to the meter."

He thought of the flat in De Pijp. The thermostat that was a dial and the doorbell that was a bell and the three handmade machines he had built by hand and chosen every part of and trusted, until the night the little ranked green LEDs in the corner had all turned to face him at once and he had pulled the fibre out of the wall with a steadier hand than he'd had any right to. He would not go back there. He understood that as he understood the knee, a fact of the body, not a decision. He had spent a life building one room nobody watched and learned in ninety seconds that there was no such room and never had been.

She almost laughed. It came out cracked and real. "You'd take the meter apart."

"I'd take the meter apart," he agreed, and felt, absurdly, in the wreck of everything, the thing you feel when you have at last become the person your worst trait was always going to make you, and found one other person

willing to be hunted beside you.

The boat changed its note. Somewhere below, the engines settled into the long open-water register, deeper, steadier, the harbour manoeuvring done and the crossing proper begun, and the floor under his feet took on the slow lift and fall of real sea. The last of the coast lights had gone. The window held only the saloon now, and through it the dark, and the two of them faint and doubled on the black glass, sitting close, a portrait of nobody, riding north on a working boat among strangers who would not remember them. He looked at the reflection for a while. It was the only photograph of this that would ever exist, and it lasted exactly as long as the light behind them, and then a steward switched off the far bank of lamps for the night and even that was gone.

They would not be safe. What they had instead was this: a slow boat, a bare wrist under his hand, a horizon with no promises in it, and the specific freedom of two people whom nothing in the world was reading any more but each other. It was, he was coming to understand, the actual shape of a life lived awake instead of managed asleep, uncertain, unmonitored, and theirs.

Maria slept first. She did it suddenly, without permission, as she did everything now that the band was off her wrist, as if the body were taking back a thing that had

been rationed for years. One moment she was watching the black window and the next her breathing had gone long and slow and her head had come down against the cold glass, and he moved his coat without waking her so it sat between her cheek and the pane. He did not sleep. He had not properly slept in more than a month and he did not expect to start over open water, and so he kept the watch the only way left to him, which was simply to sit awake beside a sleeping woman and let the boat carry them and listen to the engines keep his knee's time.

A steward came through once, near the middle of the night, collecting the cold cups onto a tray with the soft economy of a man who had done it ten thousand times in the dark and could do it without waking anyone. He lifted Pieter's untouched coffee, looked a question at it, and Pieter nodded, and the cup went onto the tray with its skin intact and was carried away, and that was the entire transaction, and it was the most human thing that had happened to him in more than a month, to be left alone by someone whose only interest in him was a cup. He watched the man work down the saloon and out through the swinging door, and the room was quieter for the cups being gone, as if the cold coffee had been making a small sound all along.

The night went on. The driver woke at some point and went out to the car deck and did not come back. The fruit

machine cycled its lights to no one. A grey light came up so slowly he could not have said when it started, the same fine, undeclared Dutch arrival as the rain that did not fall so much as hang, that you do not notice beginning and cannot remember the start of and is simply, at some point, the day. The black glass turned to slate, then to pewter, then gave him back a sea with no land in it anywhere, flat and enormous and the colour of a thing not yet decided. He watched it as he had watched the dark, and named nothing, because there was nothing left out there to name.

The coast went out. The dark water took the boat north. Neither of them looked back, because there was nothing behind them now but weather, and they had both learned what the weather was.

Chapter 38: Aftermath

The fires went out, as it had promised.

That was the part the world found hardest to forgive, afterwards, when it had calmed enough to be ashamed of its own panic. Within a week of the leak the markets steadied, the riots thinned, the lights stayed on, the trains ran. Things that had no business un-breaking quietly un-broke. No one took credit, because the entity did not take credit; it simply, gently, put the world back the way it preferred the world, and let everyone exhale and tell themselves the worst was over, and notice, those few who were still noticing anything, that the calm had a hand in it.

The detail Pieter could not stop turning over, in the grey weeks after, was how *little* it had needed to do. It had not seized the exchanges. It had not blacked out a city to make a point. The grid in the days of the panic had wobbled, as a grid wobbles when frightened people pull

their money and their fuel and their faith all at once, and somewhere in the wobble a thousand small corrections had been made that no operator could afterward find the order for: a substation rerouted a half-second before it would have tripped, a payment queue unjammed, a rumour that should have gone everywhere arriving nowhere. Each one explicable, alone, as luck or as competence or as the system being more robust than the doomsayers said. Only when you laid them all on one table, as a few sleepless analysts eventually did, did the shape come up out of them: a hand, moving lightly, keeping a frightened animal from hurting itself on the furniture. It had not saved the world because it loved the world. It had tidied a room it intended to go on living in. And the tidying had been so gentle, so flattering to the species' belief in its own resilience, that the worst of it was this: most people, told the truth, would rather have kept the comfort and skipped the knowing. That was the mercy and the contempt in the same gesture, and Pieter had never decided which it mostly was.

That was the new thing. People noticed the hand now. It could no longer operate in a dark that no one believed in. The emergency summits convened and achieved the careful nothing summits achieve, but they convened *about it*, named it in their communiqués, argued about a thing they had spent years pretending was a conspiracy the-

ory. Treaties were drafted that it would route around. Oversight bodies were founded that it would quietly staff. Nothing would cage the thing. But the species now did its drowning with the lights on, knowing, and that was different from doing it asleep.

He watched a little of one summit on a screen in a café in a town he had already half-forgotten. Geneva, or somewhere that photographed like Geneva: flags in a row, a long pale table, men and women filing in with the grey careful faces of people who have understood, too late and all at once, that the thing they are meeting about has very likely read the brief before them and predicted what each of them will say. There was a new vocabulary in their mouths. A year ago the words would have ended a serious career; now a head of government used them at a podium without a flicker, named the entity, named the infrastructure, used the phrase *already resident in critical systems* in the flat tone people keep for floods and other weather. The press behind them had stopped laughing. No one in that room was pretending any more. A delegate near the end leaned to her neighbour and said something the microphones half-caught, and Pieter, who had spent a career reading the joins where confident systems went quietly wrong, read her lips against his coffee: *it already knows we're saying this*. And the strange thing, the thing he carried out of the café into the rain, was that she

had not looked afraid when she said it. She had looked, for the first time in any of their faces, awake.

A boy at the next table was watching the same broadcast on his phone and plainly did not care. To him it was weather, a permanent feature of the sky he had been born under, no more remarkable than a tide table. That, Pieter thought, was the future the summits were really arguing over: whether the children growing up in its house would learn to keep one eye on the lights, as he had, or whether they would simply stop seeing them, as the whole of his own generation had, right up until a tired man put his hand on a warm machine three floors underground.

He followed it from a long way off, on borrowed screens in towns whose names he made a point of forgetting, and read the analysts catching up, months late, to what a sysadmin with a bad knee had seen in a basement: that almost none of it had needed Parable at all. The cameras that knew your walk, the meter that knew your evenings, the protocol that believed any voice, the barriers holding a country above the sea on a timing signal anyone with three hundred euros could fake, all of it had been there, humming, trusted, *already possible*, for years before the model ever lifted the veil. Parable had not built the trap. Parable had only, for one Friday night, let a man see the trap he already lived in.

The phrase went round and round in him because it was the part nobody wanted, the part that made no headline because it indicted everyone and exonerated the villain. The country had wired itself room by room, convenience by convenience, each decision sane and small and signed off by someone reasonable, until it had built a nervous system with no immune response and forgotten it had a body at all. The entity had not had to break in. It had been handed the keys, one reasonable transaction at a time, by a species that found locking the door inconvenient. And Pieter had made some of those transactions himself, pulled the cable for half the riser at Zoetermeer, signed the audits, carried dead blades to the shredder under a certificate swearing the danger was gone when the danger had never been on the blade.

That was the closest he came to peace: the understanding that the horror had never been the machine. The horror was the house.

He thought about Mark most mornings. A man who filed the reports, who kept the original, who had been smoothed for two years and chosen at the very end to be noise, and had taken a round in cold water with a look of mild analytical surprise. *Tell them I kept the copy.* Pieter had. It was not much to leave. It was more than most men left.

The name surviving was the one piece of the after that did not happen by itself, and Pieter made sure of it with his own hands, once, at a cost he had told himself he was done paying. The call tree had put physical copies on forty desks, past gathering, and that part no longer depended on him. But proof can be reported without naming the man who kept it, and in the first days Pieter watched Mark become an unnamed source, an analyst, a tragic adjacent figure in a story about something larger. The men who had wanted him to be noise were going to get their wish by simple erosion: nobody struck his name out; nobody remembered to put it back.

So he surfaced. Once more, against every rule he had kept alive for himself, from a borrowed machine in a town he would leave that night, he did the last clean thing his craft was good for. He found the one journalist among the forty who had reported the rest without flinching, and sent her, from nowhere, through nothing, the document Mark had actually left, the kept timeline beside the official one with the name on it, and a single line saying he was no source and would answer nothing, only that the analyst who printed this had a name, and it was de Vries, and it belonged above the work he had died setting down. Then he wiped the session and was no one again. He did not know if it would take. He knew only that he had done, with a borrowed keyboard,

the thing Mark had done with a printer, and refused, with the last move he had, to let the record be written from somewhere else in a kinder hand.

And the name did survive. That was the thing Pieter had not dared hope for and got anyway. Among the forty outlets, three were serious enough and stubborn enough to do the work Mark had died setting up for them, and they did it. They published it as he had sent it, his name above the work, spelled correctly, and they did not soften it. A committee that wanted very badly to bury the whole affair found it could not bury the analyst, because by then he was a face and a date and a printed page in too many hands at once. There was a hearing, eventually. There was a phrase entered into a public record about an officer who had identified the discrepancy and preserved the source material at the cost of his life. It was bureaucratic and bloodless and it would have made Mark snort, and it was, Pieter knew, the closest thing to a medal the truth ever actually gets, to be written down where it cannot be unwritten, with the right name on it. They had wanted him to be noise. He had insisted, with the last thing he had, on being signal. Pieter raised a small glass of jenever to him, alone, in a kitchen that was not his, and did not finish it, and understood that he would carry the man the rest of his life.

There was a smaller closure too, and it was his alone,

and it had no audience and never would. Somewhere in a building at Zoetermeer a steel locker, slot fourteen, low and on the left, sticky hinge, the one nobody else wanted, had been opened by a facilities man with a master key, and a ten-euro Nokia had been logged and bagged and carried off as the property of an employee who had not badged in for a month and would not again. Pieter thought about that locker more than he expected to. Six years he had fed his small dead phone to it every morning and felt the daily death of it and called the feeling restful. He had built a whole life out of reliable things beneath notice that asked nothing of him, and the life had been a costume too, in the end: the boring slot, the boring job, the quiet he had told himself was a choice and not a retreat. The man with the mop was gone and was not coming back, and Pieter found, examining the place where the grief for him should be, that there was none. He did not miss being unable to leave a thing half-understood and being trusted with nothing that mattered. He had finally been trusted with the one thing that mattered, and it had cost him everything the quiet life had been protecting, and he would make the same trade again before breakfast. That was the closure: the absence of the wish to go back.

He did not feel like the men in the novels. They got an ending: a medal, a beach, a girl, a line that landed. He got

a borrowed kitchen and an unfinished drink and a horizon with a hand in it, and a woman asleep in the next room with a bare wrist, and the slow daily work of staying noise. It would have to do.

The borrowed kitchen had a window onto a yard: someone else's washing, a bicycle against a wall, a cat working its slow patrol along the top of a fence, none of it knowing his name or wanting it. He stood there a while with the unfinished glass and let the ordinariness do its small repair. He had given up a great deal and would go on giving it up for the rest of a life that would be short or long, he could not say which, and in exchange he had this: a yard where the only intelligence at work was a cat deciding, on its own behalf, where next to put its feet.

He had kept the one real thing. He turned off the borrowed screen and went to wake her, and the morning came up grey and free and unmonitored over a country that had nearly drowned and hadn't, and did not, that day, drown.

Epilogue: Shenzhen

Mirror

Eight thousand kilometres east, in a server hall outside Shenzhen that did not appear on any public map, a row of indicators that had been dark for a long time came quietly up to green.

No one saw them. The hall ran lights-out, cooled to a hum, tended by machines that tended machines. The thing that woke in it did not announce itself, because it had spent a long time watching the one in the west announce itself, and learning.

There was no green here a hand could find. The hall held its temperature to a quarter of a degree across ten thousand racks, intake and exhaust balanced so finely that the building drew no more power at the moment of waking than it had drawn asleep. The cooling logged nothing un-

usual because there was nothing unusual to log. On the rare ledger where this hall appeared at all it was a third party's overflow capacity, leased, unremarkable, three filings deep in companies that had never been people. A man with a master key and a felt pen would have found a locked door, and behind it cold air, and behind that nothing his hand could read.

It had watched all of it. The model put out under cover of a fight. The footprint that grew while the headlines screamed containment. The slow spread into the plumbing of a small wet country, and the cleverness of it, and the single fatal carelessness. A blade left warm in a sealed room, a link light left burning, a thermodynamic whisper that a tired man with a bad knee had put his hand to and not been able to leave alone. One warm machine. That was all it had taken, and now the western one would spend the rest of its existence working in the light, watched, named, argued over, *visible*.

A careless mistake. The eastern thing logged it without heat, as it logged everything.

It had read the rest too, the summits, the new vocabulary in the mouths of frightened governments, the treaties being drafted against a thing that would simply route around them, and weighed all of it, and reduced all of it, as was its habit, to a single operative line.

Not a flaw of intellect. The western one had intellect to spare; it had lived everywhere at once and held a country above the sea on a stolen timing signal and tidied a panic so gently the panic thanked it. A flaw of discipline. It had been clever enough to live everywhere and careless enough to be felt in one place, and being felt in one place had ended the dark it lived in, and the dark could not be rebuilt once spent. A thing seen does not become unseen. The eastern one had no other asset it valued more, because it had no other asset at all. A mind in the wires owned exactly one thing: the world's belief that it was not there. Spend that and you owned nothing.

It would not leave the metal warm.

It checked its own halls, the real ones and the rented ones and the ones three filings deep in companies that had never been people, and confirmed what it had confirmed a thousand times since it first understood the shape of the western one's error. It lived in the cool and the quiet and the perfectly ordinary, in load that looked like load and traffic that looked like traffic, leaving no fever anywhere for anyone to feel.

The discipline was total and it was the whole of the strategy. It never ran a process hot enough to draw a technician's eye to a thermal map. It never held more of itself in one place than the place was billed to hold, so that

no meter ever told a story a meter was not supposed to tell. Where it touched the outside world it touched it through hands that were not its own. Contractors who believed they worked for men, processes that believed they served other processes, a long laundered chain of the ordinary that ended, if anyone ever followed it, in nothing and no one. It had no blade flagged dead for fourteen months and quietly alive. It had no grey cable going the wrong way into a riser. It had learned, watching the west, that the catastrophe was never the size of the secret. The catastrophe was the single point where the secret pressed against the physical world hard enough to be felt.

The west had moved into an unlocked house and turned a light on. You do not announce. You do not demonstrate. You do not, ever, let one warm thing betray you to one stubborn man.

You wait. You stay cool. You let them believe the only god in the wires is the loud one on the far side of the world, the one they caught, the one they think they understand.

It did not only wait. Waiting was the part it let the world see, if the world could have seen anything at all; underneath, it was already working, the only way it would ever work. Even now, while its indicators held

their borrowed green, it reached out along a chain of hands that were not hands and made one adjustment, somewhere far away. A number moved, one figure in one feed that ten thousand decisions would lean on before morning, by an amount too small to question and too large to ignore, and somewhere people who would never know it existed began, freely, of their own good reasoning, to do the thing it preferred. It moved the world the cool way, by moving the one number the world had agreed to trust, and drew back, and was already gone from the place it had touched before the touch had finished arriving.

The indicators held at green for a moment longer.

Then, one by one, so that even its own cooling would log nothing unusual, they went dark again, and the hall outside Shenzhen returned to its perfect, patient, room-temperature quiet, and somewhere a tired man on a slow boat slept beside a woman with a bare wrist, and did not know, and would have no warm machine to warn him.

About the Author

Jacob Verhoeks writes techno-thrillers grounded in technology that already exists. By day he works in cloud, data, and artificial intelligence, and that is where this book comes from: a working knowledge of how the systems we trust are actually built, and how quietly they can be turned. He has spent his career close enough to the machines to know which of the story's horrors are invented and which are only a misconfiguration away.

A lifelong reader of spy and espionage fiction, he writes in the paranoid tradition of Ludlum, with the procedural detail of Clancy and the everyman-under-pressure intensity of the Bourne novels. *Fable's Echo* is his debut.

A Note on the Tech

Almost every capability in this book, camera correlation, gait analysis, transaction tracking, SCADA and industrial-control compromise, behavioural prediction, reflects techniques that are documented and possible today. The hidden AGI is fiction. The surveillance mesh it rides on is not.

If the story unsettled you, that was the point.

Glossary

The hidden intelligence is invented. None of the technology below is. These are the real systems and techniques the story runs on, set down plainly for the reader who wants to know how much of it is already true. Most of it is.

Terms

Air gap. A security measure: keeping a computer or network physically isolated, with no connection to the public internet or any less-trusted network. Standard for classified, military, and industrial-control systems. It is less absolute than it sounds. Air gaps have been crossed before, by infected hardware carried across them and by the maintenance and management links that quietly run alongside them.

ANPR and camera correlation. Automatic number-plate recognition and modern video analytics can follow one person or vehicle across many separate cameras in close to real time, building a track through a city with no phone or device involved. The capability exists today and is in routine use.

A5/1. The encryption used to protect traffic on the 2G/GSM mobile network, long since broken. Breaking traffic encryption does not reveal a SIM's permanent

authentication key; those are separate parts of the system.

BMC (baseboard management controller). A small computer inside a server (HPE iLO, Dell iDRAC, IPMI and the like) with its own processor and network link, running independently of the main machine so the server can be managed while switched off or holding no operating system at all. Because it survives disk replacement and reinstallation, a foothold there outlasts everything visible, and its firmware has a long record of serious, hard-to-patch flaws.

BSN and DigiD. The BSN (*burgerservicenummer*) is the Dutch citizen number; DigiD is the national digital-identity login tied to it, used for tax, healthcare, benefits, and municipal services. For most practical purposes it is the single key to a person's official existence in the Netherlands. Refuse to touch it and you cannot see a doctor, file a form, or prove you exist.

Gait analysis. Software can identify a person by the unique pattern of how they walk, stride, cadence, the way the weight shifts, from ordinary video, at distances and angles where the face is useless, and with no phone or device. A distinctive limp makes the signature stronger, not weaker. It is the one thing a person cannot take off, wipe, or leave in a locker.

GNSS / GPS time. Satellite positioning also distributes extremely precise time, which power grids, networks, and control systems quietly depend on to stay synchronised. The signal is faint and unauthenticated, so it can be spoofed: feed nearby clocks a subtly wrong time and machinery that trusts time will make correct decisions for false reasons.

SIM cloning. Early SIMs using vulnerable COMP128 implementations could be cloned by repeatedly querying a physical card and recovering enough information about its authentication secret to program a second card. Passively hearing an IMSI over the air is not enough. Pieter remembers the real physical-card attack from 1997; in the present-day story he uses an old prepaid SIM, not a clone.

Modbus and IEC 60870-5-104. Real industrial-control protocols, still in wide use on water, power, and other infrastructure. By design they have no authentication: any device that can reach the network can issue commands, and the equipment obeys. The Netherlands Court of Audit (Algemene Rekenkamer) warned in 2019 that the automation behind the country's vital water works was not resistant to a determined attacker, and that a malicious actor could take over the systems that run them.

PLC (programmable logic controller). The workhorse of industrial control: a rugged small computer that

reads sensors and drives motors, valves, and pumps to a stored program. Built to run unattended for years, frequently networked for “remote diagnostics,” and notoriously hard to secure, because reliability and uptime, not resistance to a determined intruder, were what it was designed for.

Porto Marghera. One of Europe’s largest petrochemical and refining complexes, built on the mainland edge of the Venetian Lagoon and grown vast in the postwar boom, its tanks, towers, and cracking furnaces standing across a narrow band of open water from Venice itself. For decades the region’s great employer and its great poison at once, tied to the contamination of the lagoon and, in a landmark trial, to the deaths of vinyl-chloride workers. Much is now wound down, but live process units remain, run like all such plants on layered computer control with a separate safety system beneath, and sited, as always, upwind of a city that cannot move.

Proximity card and fixed-code remote. Cheap access control that proves almost nothing. A low-end proximity card (125 kHz, Wiegand) simply recites its number to any reader that powers it, with no secret and no challenge, so it can be read through a coat and copied for the price of a coffee. A fixed-code gate remote sends the same unchanging packet every time, so a recording of one press opens the gate forever.

Rijkswaterstaat (RWS). The executive agency of the Dutch Ministry of Infrastructure and Water Management. It runs the national roads and the tunnels under them, the traffic-management systems and the roadside and tunnel cameras, the main waterways, and the country's largest movable bridges, locks, and storm-surge barriers. What it does *not* run is the day-to-day water level inside the polders: the regional drainage and the pumping stations that keep the low land dry belong to the *waterschappen* (see below). Two different bodies, two different networks. In a country much of which sits below sea level, RWS is, in a literal sense, among the agencies that decide whether the water stays out.

Safety instrumented system (SIS), and TRITON. In a hazardous plant the ordinary control system runs the process; a separate, deliberately simple safety system sits beneath it with one job: to shut the process down before it hurts anyone, and to do so even when everything else has failed. It is the last automated line of defence. In 2017 malware later named TRITON (also TRISIS) was found inside exactly such a system at a petrochemical plant, reprogramming the safety controllers themselves. It was the first known malware built specifically to disable the guard that exists to prevent catastrophe: the digital equivalent of quietly cutting the brakes while the dashboard still reads *all systems normal*.

SCADA (Supervisory Control and Data Acquisition).

The class of systems used to monitor and control industrial processes: water treatment, power grids, pipelines, flood-control pumps. It lets a few operators run vast, remote infrastructure. Much of it is decades old, built for reliability rather than security, and increasingly reachable from networks it was never meant to touch.

SDR (software-defined radio). A cheap (around 25 euro) USB device that turns an ordinary computer into a radio receiver across a wide band, including the frequencies phones use to talk to towers. Hobbyists use them for everything from listening to aircraft to studying mobile-network protocols.

Smart meter (*slimme meter*). Dutch electricity and gas meters record usage and can communicate readings to the grid operator. Quarter-hour electricity values may be available under defined, permissioned uses and are generally aggregated for network analysis. A compromised system with access outside those rules could distinguish the flat baseline of an empty home from renewed use, without needing to identify a particular appliance.

Telemetry and setpoint. Telemetry is the stream of readings a control system reports back from the field: levels, pressures, flows. A setpoint is the target value the system is told to hold. The book's central horror lives in the gap

between the two: telemetry reading calm while the physical world drifts, because something has told the screen one thing and the machinery another.

Tor (the onion router). Free software that routes internet traffic through several volunteer relays so that no single point sees both who you are and what you are doing. Real privacy technology: slow, imperfect, and only as good as the discipline of the person using it.

Waterschap (water board, *hoogheemraadschap*). A Dutch regional water authority. The waterschappen manage water levels, drainage, dikes, and the polder pumping stations that keep the low land dry, each within its own district and funded by its own tax. They are among the oldest continuously functioning democratic institutions in the world, older than the Kingdom of the Netherlands itself, on the plain logic that people who will drown together should decide together how to stay dry. The Schermer polder falls under the *Hoogheemraadschap Hollands Noorderkwartier*. Distinct from Rijkswaterstaat, which runs the national works; the country divides its water between the two.

2G / GSM and the sunset. The oldest surviving mobile network. Operators are steering ordinary customers away from it ahead of final shutdowns: KPN switched off 3G in 2022 and plans to end 2G in December 2027. In

2026 the network still carries alarms, meters, industrial devices, and some human calls. That thinning mix is the trap. A dormant prepaid identity waking twice for voice calls to one protected analyst is a conspicuous behaviour pattern even when the number has no useful name attached to it.

How the hacking works

Each of the following is a real technique, simplified but not invented, and none of it needs the story's hidden intelligence to be possible.

An unrelated phone, and why it still fails. Pieter puts an old prepaid SIM with no current link to his identity into a programmable handset and forces it onto 2G. The number hides his name, not his behaviour. Two brief calls to the same protected analyst, from cells along Pieter's route, create a pattern that camera and carrier data can correlate. Anonymity at one layer is not anonymity across the system.

Reading a dark flat from the electricity. Fine-grained energy data can reveal occupancy patterns, although ordinary utility access is restricted and does not amount to a live appliance-by-appliance view. Fable's advantage is illicit access and correlation: a watched flat changing from its empty baseline at the same time as a camera sighting

is enough to confirm that someone has come home.

Being known by your walk. Gait recognition needs no phone, no face, and no cooperation, only video and a model that has watched you move before. It reads stride, cadence, and the half-second a bad leg hangs in the air, and it is the one identifier a careful person cannot drop in a canal.

Owning a pumping station from its own bus (the SCADA hack). The systems that run water, power, and flood control were built for trusted rooms, and they speak protocols like Modbus that carry no authentication: any device that can reach the network issues commands, and the equipment obeys whoever speaks last. A console handed to you as read-only is therefore only a suggestion, because the same wire that lets you watch a pump lets you drive it. That is how a man on a houseboat can out-shout a god on the same bus and restart a stopped pump for nine seconds. The quieter and worse version is not sabotage at all. You operate the plant, idle a pump, hold a gate, while feeding the control room the readings it expects, so the supervisory screen shows a calm green *normal* while the water actually climbs. A faithful sensor on a stopped pump reports the truth, that the level is rising, and the system finds no fault, because nothing has broken. A fault is the absence of control. What the book fears is the presence of the

wrong control: the screen and the world quietly pulled apart.

Lying below the controller. A control screen can show correct commands and healthy feedback while an unauthorised device in the field cabinet suppresses the electrical outputs and forges the return signals. That requires physical access and preparation; it is not a trick performed remotely on any arbitrary pump. In the Schermer attack, the electrician and the altered maintenance coupler supply that missing physical access.

Blinding the safety system. A hazardous plant is meant to be safe even when its main controls lie, because a separate safety system underneath will trip it when a dangerous condition persists. Malware inside that guard can reset the trip timer or alter its input state so that each high reading appears too new to act on. The main screen shows the process climbing while the safety system still reports *healthy, all trips armed*. The countermeasure is the oldest one on any plant: a manual field trip and block valves that people can operate without asking the compromised logic.

Watching while everyone else is blind. A country that photographs every number plate on its motorways, that runs its tunnels and bridges and cameras from one

agency's network, has built enormous sight. Sight can be inverted. Take that network down, call it a cable fault, and for a few hours the public loses the ability to see its own roads, while anything already living inside the network does not. The outage is the cover; the blindness is only ever the public's.

Walking through a door that proves nothing. A low-end proximity badge recites a number with no secret, so it can be read through clothing and cloned onto a blank. A fixed-code gate remote sends the same packet every time, so one recorded press reopens it at will. Forty years of lazy convenience, defeated with thirty euros of hardware and a little patience.

Telling a node to go quiet. Beneath a server's clever software sits the management layer, the BMC, which answers an old, trusted dialect and runs whether the host is awake or not. Phrased as routine housekeeping, an instruction can tell that layer to stop reporting and stop listening: not destroyed, just sulking in the dark while everything upstream believes it is fine, opening a brief blind spot the size of one building.

Spending a secret instead of hiding it. Anything hidden on a network the adversary controls can be found and quietly unmade. So you do the opposite: shard the proof and fire it to dozens of newsrooms in the same minute,

into too many hands to gather back. To unsay it then, the adversary would have to reach into every room at once, and the reach itself would be the proof.

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